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Digital Heretic



Terry Schott

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The Game is Life Series

The Game
Digital Heretic
Interlude - Brandon
Virtual Prophet

Also available at Amazon.com

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*Timeless **

*short stories at the moment... well worth the 0.99!

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Terry Schott

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Heretics do not share the common beliefs of the masses; they think bigger.

They are scorned and mocked and laughed at for their strange beliefs.

Yet still they believe.

People challenge them, scoff at them, dismiss them as absurd.

Yet still they believe.

Time passes and sometimes, others join the heretic, one or two at first, and then even more begin to tag along.

When enough time has passed, if the Heretic has been particularly persistent in their beliefs and persuasive in their ability to share the message they believe in, the Heretic disappears. Where once a lonely believer of strange ideas had stood, now stands a visionary thinker, a remarkable person who had the strength and wisdom to look at the world differently. A person who leads us to a better understanding of the universe, and a deeper view of ourselves.

Our limits increase, we advance and prosper.

Thanks to the Heretic.

Trew Radfield “The Game

Chapter 1

"At this moment everywhere on Tygon, Game fans are experiencing both joy and sorrow. Joy that one of their favourite players of all time has done it! Zack has finished his last play in the number one ranked position! Not since Angelica four years ago has anyone managed to accomplish such a feat. And what a show he put on for us all. In the Game as avatar Trew Radfield, he did something that has never happened before. He created a religion with thousands of followers who all believed that they are living in a computer simulation.

Game fans are also sad that he left the Game at such a young age. Cut down in the prime of his youth by an assassin at the age of 40, leaving behind his beautiful wife Danielle to grieve and decide how to carry on. What could he accomplished if only he had lived on? What will happen to his young religion now that he is gone? Will Danielle and her team continue to spread the message, or will it fade as a memory of what might have been?

And the sorrow that we all feel for the lovely Danielle…as beloved to fans as Trew, perhaps more in many circles; how will she continue on? Will this tragedy strengthen her, or will it destroy her?

We look forward to talking with Zack when he is brought out of Game stasis. Brandon Strayne reports that we should expect this to happen within the next few hours to no more than a day. I'm certain we all hope it is sooner rather than later.

In the meantime, while we wait to talk with Zack, all eyes are on Danielle and her Eternal companions to see what happens next…"

Lisa Rohansen - Trew Channel 42

Stephanie

"She has a death wish," I say.

Raphael and I are sitting on a rock patio elevated about 80 feet above the beach. We were told to wait up here, so here we sit, sipping fruit punch and coffee, looking down at Danielle as she comes out of the water and towels herself off. She's just spent the morning diving off different cliffs

along the beach into the roaring waves of the ocean. It's not a good day to be diving… yet she is. Raphael thought he saw sharks a few minutes ago.

Raphael sets his drink down, standing up to look over the edge, doing his best to keep his ward in sight. "She says it's a wish to experience life more fully," he says. He looks like a caged tiger walking back and forth along the edge of the cliff, looking for a way to jump down to her side.

I sigh and stand up to join him. I look down and see Danni towelling her hair off. Even from up here, I can feel her energy; it's deeply sad and lonely. "He's been gone for five months now, and she just keeps getting more reckless.

Raphael shakes his head. We've had this talk before, and he doesn't like what I'm going to ask. "We can't tell her the truth. She needs to believe Trew left the Game and is fine; that he's watching her now and living his life, waiting until she is done playing."

I shake my head. "The problem with that is she will continue to become more and more reckless, until she dies. Her belief is strong, Raphael. She won't dare take her own life — that's quitting the Game. But she is pushing the envelope more each day. The danger she exposes herself to is not healthy. She keeps this up…"

"Yes, she's going to die in some accident doing crazy thrill seeking activities," Raphael says. "I agree, Steph. It's time to say something."

I nod encouragingly.

"But I'm not telling her Trew is gone forever. I'm not going to break her heart like that."

I shake my head. "I've told you before, we don't have to. I think we use the other angle."

He looks at me and slowly nods.

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Danielle - 40

I don't know if you can see me or hear me yet.

Raph and Steph say it takes a few days for you to come out of your stasis, which is years here for me. They also say you likely won't be allowed to watch me, anyway. They give me all sorts of reasons why you can't, or won't — but I know you will.

They've told me quite a few things about the Game. Stephanie said they shouldn't, but Raphael was so mad that you died… he feels he really let us all down. And he did. I'm strong, and I know that this is just a Game, and soon we will be together again. It might seem like a long time to me, but it won't be.

I'm more like the girl I used to be. Not afraid to try things. Always ready to push the envelope. If we're all here just to experience things, then I am going to experience more than anyone ever has. And if I die in the process? Big deal. I'll see you sooner rather than later.

Just got done swimming with some sharks in the ocean. It was incredible! They didn't come near me, though. The more I tried to get to them, the farther they swam away. I've done all sorts of things since you've been gone, babe.

And I'm just getting started.

I walk up the stairs to the townhouse I've rented for the month. Money isn't an issue. You remember how you won money for being born at just the right time? We never really touched it, and both of us made excellent money when we worked. Then there's

the income that still comes in from the movement. All those people gathering to follow you, Trew. It sure was something. You should have seen the crowds show up for your funeral. That was something, too.

Okay, babe. I know I can't talk to you in my head all day. There's Stephanie and Raphael. They look concerned; maybe they know what I'm doing. All right, I'd better stop.

"Morning, you two," I say.

"Morning, hun," Stephanie says. She's so sad. I know she misses you too.

Raphael gives me a stern look. "Did I see sharks in the water?" he asks.

I nod enthusiastically. "Likely I saw them from a lot closer than you. They were incredible, right?"

"You can't die so young, Danni," Raphael says.

"I'm not trying to," I reply.

"Maybe," Stephanie says, "But you're not going out of your way to avoid it, either."

I shrug. "So?"

“Look, Danni,” Stephanie continues, “We know how painful this is for you. We know how much you miss him.” I look out over the ocean, quickly blinking away tears. “But Trew wouldn’t want you to throw your life away in a hurry just to get to him. This Game we play in is important. Each of us is here for as long as we can be.”

“I understand that,” I say.

“Yes, well there’s something special about you. I’m sorry to have to share this with you, but it’s important that you live as long as you possibly can in this Game,” Raphael says.

“Why’s that?” I ask.

****

“Then they must have turned the scrambler on, because the channel went all snowy and the sound kicked out. No clue what they told her. Damn, it’s frustrating to just be a viewer sometimes. Glad I was just taking a little break away from the command centre to eat, watching it on the local viewer in the restaurant. Then I came back after lunch and found out what they said to her and I was surprised. That’s a lot of stress to put on the girl, all things considering.”

Michelle sits beside Zack’s bed, talking to him as if he’s conscious. There is no sign of brain function, but Brandon said not to unplug him and the team hopes that he will come out of it eventually. More miraculous things have happened from time to time, Michelle thinks to herself.

“I’m not going to tell you what they said to her, Zack. If you want to hear that, then you’re going to have to wake up for me.” Michelle brushes his hair back gently; tears form in her eyes as she looks down at him. He looks so peaceful, like he’s resting and will wake up any second.

“Come on, pal. Wake up and see how cool it is to finish your last play in the number one spot. It’s just not fair that you did so well and can’t celebrate.” Michelle waits silently for a response, but there isn’t one.

“Well let me tell you, it’s sure been busy since you came out…”

Chapter 2

"What will become of the movement created by Trew Radfield? Fans expected Danielle to step in and take over the growing organization, to be its leader and continue to grow it at a phenomenal rate. With the assassination of Trew, things looked perfect for gaining even more momentum; nothing brings new followers like a fallen founder.

Formally called 'The Game Is Life Movement,' everyone has shortened it to 'The Gamers.' Danielle might step forward to lead them, but we have received no formal notification of who is in charge at this time. As the months pass by without clear direction, the Gamers sit in a holding pattern, uncertain what to do, but strong in their belief that we are all living in an elaborate computer simulation."

Danielle - 40

"Why was he killed?" I ask.

Raphael shakes his head. "We have no idea, Danni."

"Have the Infernals come forward to claim responsibility? It was Carl that killed him, right?"

"Our best guess is that it was an Infernal, yes," Stephanie says. "For a mortal to pull that hit off, with the short amount of time

they took, and the getaway in a crowded secure area… it had to have been an Infernal. We don't know if it was Carl for sure, hun."

She's lying. I can see it and feel it, but I'm not sure if she's lying about part of her answer, or all of it. "I'm tired of playing this verbal chess match with you two," I say.

"We're not playing any games, Danni," Raphael says.

"Stop it," I snap at him. "You know for certain who did it. Just tell me. I've been asking you for months now and I'm tired of this. I can't move on until I know, and we have to move on."

They look at each other and it's almost like they're speaking telepathically. I wonder if they can actually do that. I'll ask them some other time, I'm not going to let them sidetrack me at the moment. Finally Raphael nods and meets my gaze. "It was Carl."

My face flushes with intense heat. I clench my fists and stumble forward, grabbing the edge of the table to steady myself. Dizzy with rage, I count to ten slowly and take deep breaths, silently willing the wave of hatred to wash over me. Finally it passes and I begin to see normally again. Looking up at Raphael, I do my best to smile. “There, that wasn’t so difficult, was it?”

“Danni…” Raphael moves towards me, but I put up my hand to stop him. I don’t want to be hugged right now, especially not by him. He was an Infernal for a thousand years; he likely did much worse to people. Raph is an Eternal at the moment, but I look at him and I can’t help but see the man who let the love of my life die. I’m glad it was Carl; if it had been anyone less I might not have been able to forgive Raphael, but I think I can try now.

“You’ve convinced me to live; that’s fine. You’ve allowed me time to grieve; thank you. Trew will be watching me soon. Maybe he already is. It’s time to take this movement and make it into what he and I envisioned it becoming. I need to know if I’m going to be a target, and if I am, then we need to know who the biggest threats are. Infernals are the biggest threats that I know of; if there's something worse out there, then let me know.”

“You are safe from Infernals,” Rafael says confidently. “You were given what’s called a Clean Mark. When you were little I stopped a few assassins from killing you.” He pauses to see if I have any questions. I say nothing. He nods and continues, “We set up a meeting and they agreed to Clean Mark you. There are worse things out there, but we can’t control them.”

I sigh. “Are there always two questions raised for every single answer you give me? What’s a Clean Mark, and what could be worse than Infernals?”

“A Clean Mark means you are untouchable,” Raphael says. “You have a mark on you that tells all Eternals and Infernals to leave you alone. It’s an invisible mark, but we can all see it. If we harm you while that mark is present, then we die, regardless of what side we’re working for. And since we all know there’s no afterlife for us when we die, we avoid death as best we can.”

“To answer your question, ‘What could be worse than Infernals?’” Stephanie says, “There are a few things. Most of them we can’t tell you about, but the majority aren’t likely to get involved with this little issue and take an interest in us. If they do, we’ll know it and inform you quickly. The biggest threat to you will be other humans — crazies or zealots from other religions. We can protect you, and we will, but individuals with nothing to lose and enough numbers can always get through and achieve their purpose, if properly motivated.”

I nod. “Okay, then. Who’s in charge here?”

“You are,” they reply instantly and in unison.

“Yes, I am.” I hope you’re watching this, Trew. I’m going to make you proud of me. I’ll share the message with the world and wake them up to the truth like we both dreamed of doing. It’s just going to take a bit of time, from your end of things. It’s going to take a lot

of years on my part, but that’s okay; I’ve decided to live for another hundred years like we agreed on your birthday.

I walk over to the desk and sit down. “Here’s what we do, then. In order to become the biggest movement the world has ever seen… we’re going to disband and disappear.”

Chapter 3

“Come on, Sam . Let me in,” I whisper as loudly as I can. If this door doesn’t open soon I don’t know where else to go. I knock a few more times, each time getting just a bit louder. I look quickly to my left and to my right; I don’t think I’m being followed, but there are so many people around. Did anyone see me? Come on, Sam, please answer the door!

The hinges on the door squeak as it starts to open. I don’t wait for him, I just push my way in and quickly close the door behind me, leaning on it and panting for breath. “Thank goodness,” I say.

“Melissa? What’s wrong? How long have you been knocking on my door?” I open my eyes and look at Sam. His hair is pointing in about five different directions and he’s rubbing his eyes tiredly, his mouth half open in a partial yawn.

“You’re just waking up now, Sam? It’s 1 PM.” I move over to the couch and push the clothes sitting there to the side so I can sit down. I’m shaking.

“Uh, yes, I’m just waking up now. I’m a bartender, remember? I just went to sleep.” He looks at his watch. “Okay, I went to sleep eight hours ago, but still I’m tired. What’s got you so upset, anyway? Aren’t you supposed to be at work?”

I shake my head. “No, I called in sick today.”

“Are you sick?” he asks. He can sense from my tone that something’s not right.

“I don’t know. I don’t think so. I don’t know.” I walk over to the door, lock it and then check the peephole to make sure there’s no one outside.

I turn back to Sam. He looks concerned.

“Okay, listen. I can trust you, right?” I ask.

“Of course you can,” he says.

“I mean really trust you. Like with my life?”

“Yes. Look, Melissa, you need to calm down. You’re really starting to freak me out. Just tell me what’s going on.”

I laugh, then quickly cover my mouth. How do I tell him? Where do I start? I don’t really know what’s going on myself. “You remember going to

see Trew at that big Gamer gathering? The last time he spoke to us all in town, just before he died?"

"Yeah, of course I do. We were lucky to get the seats we did, and the talk he gave was top notch. He talked about the laws of the universe, and how at certain times in history, the laws bend, making room for new possibilities. It was great stuff, that last talk we heard from him."

I nod. "Exactly. Do you remember what he said about… about flight?"

Sam laughs. "Yeah, he said that our minds are so powerful that perhaps someday, when enough minds agree such a thing is possible, humans could even learn to fly. I thought he was pushing it a bit there, to be honest. But the man sure did believe in the power of the human mind."

"Yes, he did. Sit down for a second, Sam. And please help me explain this."

He nods and sits down. I stand up and close my eyes. I start to feel the gold, glowing feeling that Trew talks about in his book, letting it spread over my body and envelop me in tingling colour. For a brief second, I feel weightless, like I'm floating. I hear Sam gasp, then swear loudly. I hear a small thud and my body feels heavier than it did a second ago.

I open my eyes to look at Sam. He has both hands over his mouth. His eyes are wide open, looking at me with… well, I don't know what it is. I raise my eyebrows at him. "Did you see that?" I ask.

Keeping his hands locked over his mouth, he nods his head quickly. Then he blurts out, "You…!"

I hiss at him, making my hand gesture to quiet down and he quickly puts his hands over his mouth again. "How high?" I ask.

He slowly takes his hands away and holds them apart, one about six inches above the other.

"That's how high I was floating?" I ask. Please let him say I wasn't. Let him say I'm just imagining it.

My heart jumps into my mouth as he slowly nods and whispers, "Yes. That's how high you were floating."

I walk over and sit down beside him. We sit quietly for a few minutes, then he asks me, "What are we supposed to do?"

I shrug my shoulders. "I have no idea, Sam. But I'm scared."

Chapter 4

Many players return from the Game with memories of what it is like to believe in something greater than themselves. Having lived multiple lifetimes, a retired player has lived with faith and seen its benefits countless times.

Viewers too old to have had the opportunity to play are immersed in watching dozens or hundreds of their favourite players for decades within the Game. They also are exposed to religions of all types, often on very intimate levels.

Billions are starting to believe that if Earth can have a deity, perhaps Tygon might also possess a supreme being that watches over them… hundreds of years of belief in nothing may be challenged almost overnight by blind faith.

"I need your help, Sylvia."

"Well, hello to you, too, Brandon. It's been some time since we spoke last. How are things with you?"

Brandon said nothing; he just sat at his desk and clicked his pen.

"Oh, come on, Brandon. Not in the mood for happy banter today?"

"No, Sylvia, I'm not in the mood today," Brandon said.

"Good," Sylvia said. "Neither am I. I miss him too, Brandon."

"Can you help him?"

"What?" Sylvia sounded confused. "Brandon, I know you're not thinking clearly, but you set the rules that govern my entire existence. Trew's not in the Game; I can do nothing. Even when he was in the Game, there wasn't much I could do. I'm sorry, dear. He's left the Game. If he's not on Tygon, then he's gone."

"I was instructed not to unplug him," Brandon said. "I had hoped those directions came from you."

"Me?" Sylvia said. "Who told you to not to unplug him? Who made you think that it might have been me giving those instructions?"

Brandon shook his head. "Never mind who it was. It doesn't matter."

"Unplug him if you wish. If there's no brain function, then it's an empty shell you've got lying there."

There was so much Brandon wanted to ask her, but he didn’t, for fear that he would reveal too much information. He wondered if she felt the same way; her silence was as complete as his.

“Okay,” Brandon said quietly.

“I’m sorry, Brandon. I know we both wanted him to do well. Neither of us benefit from this happening. He was my child in the Game and I feel deep sorrow for his loss. That his spark is gone for good is a true loss for the universe, both mine and yours.”

“Thank you,” Brandon said. He waited for Sylvia to end the conversation.

“If I may give you some advice?” Sylvia offered.

Brandon laughed, but nodded his head. “Sure, Sylvia, why not?”

“If someone told you not to unplug him, perhaps let him stay plugged in for a spell?”

“I’ll do that. I guess it can’t hurt. Thanks, Sylvia.”

“Sure, hun.”

Chapter 5

He opened his eyes and found himself in a room bathed in purple light.

He was lying on a table, blinking slowly, trying to remember who he was and how he had gotten here. Details began to come to him, and as they did, he struggled to sit up.

“You won’t be able to sit up,” a voice said from… behind him? It was hard to say for certain. The male voice was soothing and mild, with strength and depth that was reassuring.

“Where am I?” the man on the table asked.

“Before I answer that, I have a question,” the voice said. “Who are you?”

The man searched his mind for the answer. He remembered a woman, a beautiful, smiling woman. And two close friends who were… his protectors? And a family; he remembered loving parents.

He also remembered a crowd. Standing in front of a large crowd of smiling cheering faces. They had been looking at him as they cheered.

“Trew Radfield,” the man on the table answered.

“That is who you were, for a brief time. I am asking who you are right now. Take your time; I’m in no rush for an answer.”

The man on the table had a flash of being someone else. An old man with a different wife. Children and grandchildren surrounded him, all smiling and hugging and laughing. He remembered running a very successful business, then retiring. He remembered a life full of happiness and pain. He recalled surprising his entire family with a paid trip for everyone to Hawaii. That ended badly, he recalled.

“George Knight. Is that who I am?” the man asked.

“You were him also, for a longer time. But still it was brief. Perhaps the time to think is confusing you. As soon as I ask you, just blurt out the answer, without thinking. How does that sound?”

The man on the table nodded.

“Good.” The voice said. “Who are you?”

“Zack.”

“Excellent,” the voice replied with a tone of approval.

Zack nodded. “Where am I?” he asked the voice once again.

“You are here with me, Zack. You died inside the Game. It was a… permanent death.”

“Permanent?” Zack asked.

“Yes. They used a horrible weapon on you, one that should have destroyed your very essence, making it impossible for it to travel back to your body on Tygon.”

“Should have destroyed my essence, but it didn’t?”

The voice chuckled. “No, it didn’t. Thanks to you and Danielle, I was able to bring you here.”

Zack’s memories had fully returned, complete with the multiple lifetimes of experience accumulated from his plays in the Game. He no longer felt disoriented. “Are you Sylvia? We spoke often inside the Game during prayer. But you don’t sound, or speak, like her.”

“No, I’m not Sylvia. She is a sweet little thing, but the Game is where she dwells. Tygon is where I exist.”

“You mean…?”

“Yes, Zack. Tygon also has a God. With your help, perhaps we can help your people believe in me. If they can’t… well, it will be very sad.”

“Why?” Zack asked. “They seem to get along just fine without any divine presence.”

“Yes, they have gotten along fine,” the voice said with concern, “but that will soon change, and you are the only one who can help me.”

“How? What can I do?”

“I am going to have you stay with me for a short time, and we shall discuss that.”

“How long?” Zack asked.

“Not very long. Time passes differently here than it does on Tygon. Then I am going to do my very best to send you back to your body for a while.”

“You’re going to *try* to send me back for a while*?*” Trew asked. “It doesn’t appear that you’re too confident you will succeed, and you make it sound like even if you do, I may not be there for very long, anyway.”

“What I am attempting hasn’t been done for a very long time. I draw my power from followers. It’s been a long while since I was even awake, let

alone active. However, I’m sure I can get you back; have faith.”

“I do,” Zack said.

“As for how long you will be back on Tygon, hopefully it will be for long enough to get the job done,” the voice said. “You see, Zack, time is running out…”

Chapter 6

Fans were excited when we discovered that Eternals do exist inside the Game. Aside from Stephanie, Raphael, and perhaps the two others we saw heal Danielle, it seems impossible to find others. This station has hired an entire team to scour the feeds looking for further evidence that Eternals do exist in the Game, but so far we've been unsuccessful.

And thinking about it, what do we really have to go on except one very interesting event and the word of two seemingly normal avatars? Raphael and Stephanie have done nothing noteworthy as far as we've been able to see.

Perhaps the entire thing is a hoax and the two are nothing more than con artists capitalizing on the new beliefs of the avatars…

Game Channel 177 news

The zoo is full .

I miss being out and hunting for them, but over the years I've found that adding too many subjects can confuse things and cause important information to be overlooked.

I open the double doors and enter the lab. A shaft of light shines down on a large desk in the middle, and I move towards it. The rest of the room is dark, but I hear sounds coming from various points along the walls. Some of them are waking up as they sense my presence.

I sit down and close my eyes, taking three deep breaths to clear my mind of the outside world. This lab is 13 levels below ground, underneath a legitimate mental hospital, the perfect cover, with layers of built-in safety measures to avoid detection.

My subjects are much more interesting than any of the wretches residing above us. It's taken me months to find them all, and I'm anxious to get to work.

My awareness skips lightly over each individual, and they begin to stir. I sit silently, letting them slowly wake up, then I raise my right hand and make a counterclockwise, circular gesture.

Energy leaves my hand and jumps from cell to cell, sparking a reddish brown light to life. A portion of the light becomes trapped in a clear tube

over each bed; the imprisoned lights flit about like fireflies. As the final cell is lit, I open my eyes to examine the occupants.

Thirteen cells surround me in a circle, each containing a bed, toilet, sink, and wooden stool. There is also a table in every cell; most hold piles of notes and books, some are loaded with artwork, and others contain music or instruments. One table holds a state-of-the-art computer, complete with printer and three monitors on the walls.

Each subject stands at their door, eyes vacantly looking through the bars in my direction, hands hanging loosely, rocking slightly from side to side in unison with each other. None of them make a sound; the zoo has been full for only a few days, but they've learned what I expect from them.

"Good morning, my lovelies," I say. "I hope you all had a restful night. We will get you breakfast soon. Please go about your business; I'll be sitting here doing paperwork in case one of you needs me."

The thirteen shuffle away from their doors, turning their backs on me to go about their activities. I can feel their minds driving

them towards their compulsions, like drug addicts struggling to get their fixes.

A short time later I feel attention from one of the cells. Without looking up, I address the occupant. "What is it, Seven? Do you have something for me?" His attention remains silently fixed on me, so I stand up and turn to look at him.

Seven is one of my prized treasures, a boy of around fifteen. He's the youngest in the zoo, and the computer sits on his table. When I meet his eyes, my lips purse in silent irritation. Sometimes he cries wolf and needs to be disciplined. I hope this isn't one of those times; it would set the whole group back for the day.

Walking over, I notice his hands are making small typing motions. This is an usually an indicator that he's processing something and not simply trying to fool me. I don't appreciate being fooled. I summon the glow and touch my pinky finger directly to the centre of his forehead. The energy slowly sinks into his third eye and his breath changes. His eyes quickly focus and he smiles, no longer a confused creature; he's now looking at me with complete self-awareness. What was a lost creature is now replaced by a complete avatar.

“Thanks, boss,” he says. “I think you’re going to be real happy with what I have for you.”

“I hope so, Seven,” I say. “Tell me.”

“I found out who Three was.” He uses his thumb to point at the cell across from him and to his right.

I look at him quietly. It’s not something I’m usually interested in, who these poor wretches were. Seven has done this twice before, and I must admit, discovering the identity of Nine has been very helpful to me. The other identity wasn’t very useful; Six was a nobody, some stockbroker that just couldn’t handle the pressure and snapped. Glad he did snap, though — Six might have been a bad husband and stockbroker, but he’s an amazing quantum physicist in this group.

“Why do I care who Three was?” I ask.

Seven shrugs. “I don’t know if you do care, boss, but I know the answer. If you don’t want to hear it, then put me back into the haze.”

“Careful, Seven. Don’t forget who you are, or who I am.”

Seven swallows and nods quickly. “Sure thing, boss. I apologize.”

I nod. “Okay, then. Tell me who she was.”

“She was just a regular person for most of her life. I couldn’t find very much on her at all. Then she came out of nowhere and started getting a lot of mention in the news. Ever hear of nanotechnology?”

“Microscopic robots, yes, go on.”

“Turns out she did some pretty amazing stuff in that area, and then suddenly, they just shut her down.”

“Any idea why?” I ask.

Seven smiles. “I know exactly why. I can’t believe that I was able to piece the info together. Whoever deleted the records and history did a near-perfect job. The idiot that I become is really impressive, boss. It’s magic, how I retrieved this for you.”

“Yes, magic is the best way to describe it,” I say. I make a signal, demanding that he speed things up.

“Number Three just happens to be Miranda Stewart, boss. And my info is guaranteeing me that she currently has an active, fully functional, intelligent computer the size of a blood cell floating around in her body.”

I look over at Three’s cell. She’s sitting at her desk, mechanically working on her artwork with crayons and pastels. Her eyes are vacant. She

stirs as she feels my attention, but it's slight.

"But that's not possible for a human to do," I say.

"Yeah, I know," Seven says. "Here's the other kicker. She's an Eternal."

As fast as lightning I hiss and tap Seven's forehead again. He returns to his regular state and wanders back towards his

computer. I whip my head around, quickly scanning the subjects for any irregularities. I see nothing, but I'm suddenly very alert and on edge. How the hell did that word slip out of Seven's mouth?

I walk over to Three's cell and watch her intently. She remains in her haze, going about her business. *An Eternal? What am I going to do with this?*

I walk back to my desk and sit down, placing my hands calmly on the desk.

I'm going to sit here patiently for a half hour, watching Three the entire time. If no one shows up by then, I'll decide what to do about her.

Chapter 7

Danielle - 41

I likely shouldn't be doing this.

Psychics, mediums, clairvoyants — I never really thought about them or what they did. They were always on commercials and occasionally in the news in my town, trying to help police find a missing child or commenting on the upcoming future, but I was too busy to pay them much attention. There's mostly mention of the fakes — the ones who use simple psychology and knowledge of how the human brain works to trick people into thinking they are genuine.

This lady sounded different, though. She's difficult to track down, she doesn't publicize her abilities, those who do know about her work diligently to keep her protected from the press and from large crowds of people coming to her for help. She doesn't charge money, but does accept gifts if you feel inclined to provide one. There's a lot more about this lady that many find fascinating, mysterious, and convinces me that she's the real deal.

Of course, all of this could be her elaborate way of delivering a richly detailed and clever scam.

Stephanie and Raphael haven't weighed in on this woman, most likely because I haven't told them about her. They get worried when I ask about life outside this world. I don't know why; if we

have a life outside this game, I was expecting them to tell me much more about it than they have.

Maybe it's a horrible place, where we really exist. Not long after Trew was killed, I asked Stephanie some questions about what he would be doing now. She just looked at me and broke down crying. A few hours later, she said she was just sorry he was gone from here, because she had loved him, and although he was fine, she would never see him again because she was stuck inside this reality. Her story seemed okay, but somehow I didn't believe her. There seemed to be more to her sadness than just that.

She cried like he was really gone.

So here I sit, at a plain table in a plain room, a middle-aged woman named Eva sitting across from me. I haven't told her anything about myself, or why I'm here. She doesn't know my name or any details about me. I was told that she does a totally cold reading. She walks into a room, looks at you and then it comes, whatever 'it' is. So often people come in and talk, giving away minor facts and details that make it easy for a fake to come up with what looks like a magical conversation with the departed, when the customer has actually provided all the details without knowing it. That won't be the case here.

She looks… disappointing. Shoulder-length brown hair, brown eyes, no makeup, clothes that are clean and pleasant, but nothing flashy. No gaudy, thick makeup or hair tied up in gypsy headgear. No flashy

rings or wrists full of bracelets clinking and clacking as she moves her hands. None of that. There is one classic item sitting on the table, though

"A crystal ball?" I ask. "Really?"

"Absolutely," she says. "Crystals have great significance and power. Not just the clear quartz you see on the table. There are thousands of different crystals and gemstones that can help us."

Oh, dear. She is a fraud, after all. Oh well, I may as well stay for the whole session. It did take me two months to get this appointment. "That doesn't seem right," I say. "Why haven't I heard about this if it's true?"

Eva smiles kindly, as if I am a child who has just said that clouds are made up of cotton balls and they float in the sky by magic. "Did you know that there is a wild bird in the world that helps local natives hunt for honey?"

"No…" I say.

"The bird searches for trees that are rich with wild honey, and when it finds the correct spot, it signals the local natives with a very specific call. The natives get the honey out so they can eat it, and they share some of the honey with the bird. On its own, the bird could never get to the honey. Scientists have studied this relationship and the birds have developed calls that they use only to communicate with the native humans."

"That's pretty fascinating," I say sincerely.

"You believe me?" Eva asks.

Her question makes me pause. "Yes, I do."

“Why? It sounds impossible, doesn’t it? A wild bird, learning whole new sounds just to communicate with and help humans find honey?”

“I guess it does sound impossible,” I say.

“Yet you believe me. Humans are strange creatures, aren’t we? We can believe the unbelievable so easily at times, and doubt the truth just as readily at others.”

“That is true,” I say. “It’s an excellent example, thank you. I will have to remember that false story so I can use it to share the same point in the future.”

Eva laughs gently. There is no malice in it, only amusement. “The story about the bird is true. What I say about crystals is also true. If you can believe one, then you can believe the other.”

“But one lacks detail. If I had more facts, then the crystal explanation would be more believable.”

Eva shrugs. “They both lack detail. I could give you charts and studies and stacks of research done with crystals over the centuries and still you wouldn’t believe it. The story of the bird didn’t contain any more detail, really. But it felt right because of our conditioning, so it was easier to accept.”

“What conditioning is that?” I ask.

“We have been conditioned to accept animals as having human characteristics,” Eva said. “Since we were little children, we have seen animals as being human-like. They talk to our children, educating and entertaining them on the television and in movies. In books they are also human-like. When we grow up, we understand that there is no way for animals to be this way, but deep down we accept it easier than other things.”

I laugh out loud. “Okay, so tell me more about the crystals and how they work. I don’t want to be part of the group of people that don’t understand them any longer.”

Eva smiles and nods. “Basic science states that everything is made up of molecules, right?”

“Yes,” I agree.

“We also accept that everything on this planet is made up of only a few specific molecules, with mainly the carbon molecule as the backbone for everything,” She says.

This is like a high school science class; glad I paid attention back then. “That’s right, and the molecules vibrate at different speeds, or frequencies, which determines what they are. So a table made of wood is made up of molecules that vibrate at one frequency, while a table made from marble is made up of mostly the same molecules vibrating at a different frequency.”

“Correct,” Eva says. She reaches into her pocket and pulls out a small felt pouch, opens it up, and empties the contents of it into her hand. Different stones spill out onto her palm and she holds

them out for me to inspect. They vary in shape, size and colour. “Each of these stones is made from essentially the same molecules, yet they all vibrate at different speeds or frequencies. That gives each stone a different set properties. Some of the properties we can see — colour, shape, et cetera. But the difference in frequencies also produces properties that we cannot see.”

“That makes sense,” I say.

“I’m glad you agree,” she says. “Now let me talk about vibration for a minute. Unless I’m boring you? If I am, we can skip this part?”

“No, this isn’t boring at all. Please continue.”

“Okay, then. Vibration is energy, do you agree?” Eva asks.

“I do agree. Boiling water vibrates more than cold water.”

“That’s right. And a result of vibration is heat, or energy. There are many types of energy, but they all involve vibration at different levels,” Eva says.

“So these stones all vibrate differently and give off different types of energy?” I ask.

“Exactly. And because of that, each stone has different effects on other things. It seems that these stones react with human cells and energy in very specific ways; many beneficial ways. It’s almost as if millions of years ago something created these stones to help our bodies out. Some stones help keep us healthy, others protect us from radiation… they do a myriad of things, all very fascinating.”

“How come this isn’t well known?” I ask.

“It is,” Eva answers.

“Then why doesn’t every person know about it?”

“That’s an excellent question, with disturbing answers,” Eva says. “Definitely not a topic for right now. But do you believe me just a bit more

than you did earlier about the crystal being on the table for a valid reason?"

"Yes, I do." And I do.

"Good," Eva says. "Belief is important. The crystal helps amplify energy and communication. The crystal is one of the most versatile of all gemstones, and that is why you often see it used, even by people who lack any real ability. They at least get their stage set right, even if they don't understand why."

Eva puts the stones back into her bag and tucks them safely away. She takes a deep breath and then looks at me seriously. "Okay, then. Shall we try to contact your husband?"

Lucky guess. Most clients my age likely come here to contact a husband who has passed. I'm not impressed. I also know she might have seen me on TV and some of her information will look authentic, but come from public knowledge.

She closes her eyes and minutes pass.

Her closed eyes squint together even more, she reaches out her hand towards me and asks me to hold it, which I do. I can feel a tingling energy surrounding me, very close to the golden glow that I've developed over the years, but slightly different.

After perhaps five minutes she releases my hand and opens her eyes. I can see tears in them and she looks at me sadly.

"What is it?" I ask. "You haven't said anything yet."

"I'm sorry, my dear, I didn't know. I should have guessed, but I've only heard about this; in all my years I haven't experienced it. I'm so sorry."

I'm scared now. Eva is upset and I have a bad feeling. "Sorry for what?"

"I can't help you talk to him, Danielle. He wasn't just killed. He was severed."

My mouth turns dry and the muscles in my neck at the base of my skull feel like they're tightening so hard that my head is going to be pulled down into my back. "What does that mean?" I whisper.

"It means that he didn't pass over. I can't communicate with him because he's gone."

"Gone where?" I know I don't want to hear any more, but I can't stop asking questions.

“I’m sorry.” Eva is crying now.
I’m too numb to join her.

Chapter 8

Why would a person want to believe in only one life?

Is this incarnation of yours so good that you wouldn't like another?

Are things so spectacular that if the Almighty came to you and said, "Grab yourself another entire lifetime to live!" you would say, "Oh, no thanks, I really nailed it and took care of everything in that last life"?

Even if I had the most incredible life, I would still be willing to give it another go. What if we do live in some real world after this one and all we do is work and have no time for any fun?

What's that, you say? That's how your life is now? Tsk tsk. You might be missing your only chance for fun and excitement.

And in case you miss it this time… why not go ahead and believe you get more than one life?

Danielle - 41

" She said he was severed. What does that mean?"

Raphael looks at me blankly. I don't even dare to blink in case I miss something. He's going to lie to me, and I want to make sure I get whatever info I can from his body language. Even when people lie, they can tell you a lot from their body language.

From my right side I hear Stephanie chirp out a reply. "Danni, we have no idea what she meant. What are you doing going to a medium, anyway? We warned you about…"

I hiss and hold up my hand to her. I don't even bother to look at her. I point my index finger at Raphael. "I was asking him, not you. Be quiet until I can think properly, Stephanie. I've allowed the two of you to divide and conquer me for too long. You say I'm important? Well, if this conversation doesn't go the way I want it to, then I'm done." I haven't taken my eyes off Raphael, and his are locked with mine. I hope he's reading my look correctly, because I mean what I'm saying. They know something, and I'm ready to hear what it is. "Do you believe me, Raphael?"

Raphael continues to stare at me, then his eyes soften and he nods. "I believe you, Danni. You have lived long enough to understand that some

things are better left unknown. I will ask you one more time to leave this alone. If you refuse, then I will tell you, and I'm not going to feel bad about it

His answer makes me pause to consider for a moment. Do I really want to know? It took me quite a while to get Eva calmed down; she kept apologizing and looking at me sadly. I tried to pay her for her

services, but she just shook her head and pressed a rose quartz gemstone into my palm. Every time I ask Raph and Stephanie they both look very sad. Stephanie cries sometimes, too. Do I really want to know?

I nod my head yes and Raphael closes his eyes. He gets up and walks over to a cabinet. I've seen it in his room before and never thought much of it. It's a small, plain looking wooden cabinet, gold coloured hardwood, shiny. He inserts a key, unlocks it, and reaches inside. He pulls out a tapered metal spike. Gold and silver lines cover the entire surface of it, like computer circuitry. It has a small red button at its base. He walks over and hands it to me. It's warm and seems to hum faintly.

"This is called a Sever Spike. This is what Carl put into Trew; it's the weapon that killed him."

I nod silently, blinking back hot tears. I'm not going to cry. He's been gone almost two years. I need to hear this. I have to.

"When you were little," Raphael continues, "I stopped a man from killing you with the same type of weapon. When I saw he what he was going to use on you, I slit his throat and let him bleed out slowly."

I look up from the weapon at Raphael. His eyes are blazing, the gold flecks swirling angrily in his dark brown eyes. He's extremely angry. A small part of me screams that I should tell him to stop, that I don't need to know any more, but I say nothing and let him continue.

"When an avatar dies, their essence returns to their body on our homeworld. They wake up, and after a brief time, they go about their lives. If they are young enough, they plan their next play in the Game. If they are too old to play any longer, they move into the next phase of their lives."

I nod. He has told me this before.

"When an avatar is killed with one of these," he taps lightly on the Sever Spike I hold in my hands, "the avatar dies, but their essence, their soul, doesn't return to their real body." He becomes quiet. Stephanie comes over to sit beside me, resting her hand gently on my neck.

“What happens to it?” I ask.

Raphael says nothing. His face is a mixture of rage and sadness; I can see the pain of losing Trew in his eyes, and the blame he has put on himself as his failed guardian.

“Raphael? What happened to Trew’s soul?”

Raphael looks back up at me and he shakes his head. I don’t want to hear what he’s about to say. My ears feel full of pressure; his voice sounds like it’s coming from underwater. “I’m so sorry, my sweet girl. It’s gone. His soul was ripped into a million little pieces and scattered to the cosmic winds. He’s gone, dead forever.”

A strange calm blankets me, like I’ve moved past the need to feel. It’s as if some divine hand has wrapped me in its protective embrace to shield me from total annihilation. I float peacefully inside this bubble, calm as can be, while I watch the other part of me boil in rage. I can feel my eyes burning, and when I look up at Raphael I hear him gasp in surprise. “Carl did this to my life. To the other half of my soul.”

Raphael nods.

“I want him.” I hold the Sever Spike up in front of me. Its humming seems louder now. It’s hungry — I can feel it. “I want him standing in front of me, and I will shove this into his face and watch him die. That’s the only goal in my life now, and *I will not fail.*”

Raphael nods. “We will help you, Danni. But you must calm down.”

“I am calm,” I say.

“No, you’re not. If you don’t calm down, we won’t ever get a chance to find Carl. Breathe, Danni.”

I close my eyes and take deep breaths. The emptiness fades and is replaced by pain. Intense pain. After a few moments I open my eyes and look at Raphael. He nods, then stands up and leads me to a mirror. “We have new things to teach you, dear.”

“Like what?” I ask. Raphael points me towards the mirror and I look at my reflection. My reflection looks the same, except for one major difference. My eyes are no longer blue. They are icy white with bright silver flecks that swirl around lazily, like fish in a pond.

“Like… lots.” Raphael says.

“Am I an Eternal?” I ask.

“Danni,” Raphael shakes his head in confusion, “I have no idea what you are.”

Chapter 9

It's rare for a player to die permanently. VirtDyne perfected the safety of virtual reality long before they allowed our children to use the technology.

Health and fitness are of utmost importance to players. The computer analyzes a player when they exit the Game and they must maintain rigid levels of health and conditioning before they can re-enter. This depends on the time they spend in the Game, but usually after a month or two of lying on a table in stasis, it is expected that a player will need to spend a lot of time in the gym raising their level of fitness to acceptable standards. Once that is complete, the player can re-enter the Game assured that their bodies can once again withstand the stresses of inactivity.

That being said, the occasional complication does occur when coming out of stasis. In the most extreme cases, a player has been known to die. While tragic when it occurs, fewer children die today playing the Game than when they used to attend old-fashioned schools. There is always some element of risk to everything. That's how life works.

Brandon entered Danielle's command centre and made his way towards one of the corner offices. Now that Trew had left the Game, they called it Danielle's centre, but the location and team were the same.

In light of the complications that had arisen with Zack, his team had asked to stay on and help in whatever way possible with Danielle. Brandon had agreed, and everyone was glad. This play was turning out to be more important than any of them had imagined.

Danielle's popularity was skyrocketing on both worlds. The poor girl who had been given a free play by the computer and expected to finish her play with a small number of credits was now favoured to come out of this play ranked number one.

Everyone was excited to be a part of it, and Brandon was pleased to keep them all on board. Only he knew what would really happen when she finished her play — that the Game would end and every child still inside the Game at that time would die. When that happened, life on Tygon would change catastrophically and Brandon knew that everything he had built for

the past thirty years would crumble in an instant. He wasn't about to just stand by and let that happen. Time was running out, but he was going to do his best until the very end. That meant keeping this incredible team together to help Danielle live as long as she possibly could inside the Game.

Brandon entered the corner office and nodded to the people assembled. Michelle, Nadine, and Lilith were sitting at the round desk in the room. Brandon sat down and got right to business.

"Michelle, what news on Zack?"

Michelle shook her head sadly. "Nothing, Brandon. He's still on life support with no sign of brain function or activity. It's been four days since he came out; no change."

Brandon nodded. He was spending all his free time at Zack's side, but he never had much free time. "Nadine, tell us about Danni. What's she up to now?"

Nadine tapped some commands into her tablet and the screen behind her displayed the current information on Danielle.

"She's 46 years old at the moment, and for the past few years she has been hunting for Carl." Nadine stopped talking and looked patiently at Brandon.

"What else?" Brandon asked.

"Nothing else," Nadine said. "You heard her speech when Raphael told her how Trew died. The girl is true to her word. She's doing nothing else until she puts that Sever Spike into Carl."

"And her ratings? Have they suffered?" he asked.

"Not at all, likely because there are so many entertaining distractions while she tries to focus on finding Carl." Nadine brought up another chart titled Distractions and began to list them off. "First, there are her eyes. Fans believe she is suddenly an Eternal, and they are watching closely to see what kind of things she can do because of it."

"Okay," Brandon said.

"Then there are the millions of people still believing in the movement Danni and Trew formed. She has repeatedly tried to get them to move on and disband, but the Gamers continue to believe in their movement."

"What are they doing?" Brandon asked.

"Looking for a real leader," Nadine said. "Danielle refuses to lead them, and the major religions of the world have taken notice of their

numbers and have banded together to destroy this young faith."

"Without a true leader, the movement will fail," Brandon said. "We've seen it happen many times. This one seems to be hanging on longer than most."

"That's because there were over 40 million of them when Trew died. They are numerous, and they are devout. Most of the local leaders have encouraged their groups to go underground. This was what Danielle instructed them to do not long after Trew died, and the majority feel that Danielle will be stepping forward very soon to call them all together and lead them."

Brandon nodded. "I think she just might."

"What makes you think that?" Lilith asked.

"Because she wants to find Carl. I'm surprised she hasn't realized it will be easier to do that by putting millions of loyal followers on the hunt."

"Oh, I think she did realize that some time ago," Lilith said. "I also think she's afraid Carl will mow through large numbers of people that come after him. She doesn't want that kind of blood on her hands."

"Perhaps," Brandon said. "But sooner or later she will call them to help. So what plans do we have for helping her move along with her life?"

"Can we help her find Carl?" Michelle asked.

"Sure," Brandon said. "But why would we do that? I could likely help her get funding to build a spaceship to take her to the Sun, but once she got there, she would burn up. It's the same with helping

her find Carl. Why assist her in getting killed? I don't want to see her come out of the Game that way; I don't think any of us do."

"She's not going to stop hunting for him," Nadine said. "We all know her well enough to believe that."

Brandon chuckled. "We all know her well enough, but all she needs is something more important than finding Carl. Maybe we've tried a few things to distract her, but I think we can come up with something that will do it. Let's all get to work on putting something into place to help steer her on a different path."

Brandon looked around the table and everyone nodded in agreement. "Okay, then, is there anything else?"

"Is she an Eternal, Brandon?" Lilith asked with concern. Everyone at the table knew enough about Eternals to understand some of the problems

associated with that being true. Zack had lost his soul; If Danielle was an Eternal, she would lose her body here on Tygon.

“This stays in this room, do we understand?” Brandon asked.

Everyone nodded.

“I know a lot about Eternals, and this is not how they are created. That being said, she does possess many talents that are most often Eternal talents.” Brandon sighed and shook his head. “My best guess is that she isn’t, but one other Eternal was created ‘improperly,’ and this could be a similar situation. I think we will just have to wait and see what this turns into.”

“What about Zack?” Michelle asked.

“After Raphael told Danni about the Sever Spike, I had to make it official. Everyone on Tygon knows that Zack is dead and gone. The past couple of days have been very sad for the world; I’ve attended numerous funeral services for Zack.”

“You never told anyone he is still plugged in, though,” Lilith said.

“What’s the point?” Brandon asked. “He’s gone.”

“Then you’re unplugging him from life support?” Michelle asked.

Brandon nodded sadly. “Tomorrow, when it has been exactly five days since he came out of the Game. That’s when I’ll do it.”

Chapter 10

Melissa

I’vebeen sitting in this coffee shop for the past three hours. It’s taken years to get this close; I hope the wait is over soon. Sam sits across from me, sipping a white hot chocolate with peppermint. He’s looking at me with that half smile of his; I’m not sure if he cares what happens here or not. Sam’s a pretty simple guy — he doesn’t worry about much. I wish I could feel the same. I was never that way, even before I started to float.

It’s been seven years since I knocked on Sam’s door and showed him what I can do. We’ve spent all that time trying to get close enough to meet Danielle, but it isn’t as easy as I had hoped. Famous people are really tough to meet, and she might not be on TV or in the movies, but Danielle is definitely famous.

I know I’ve overthought it; my mind gets in the way so often and complicates things. It would have been simple just to find out what building she lives in, float up to her window, and knock on it till she noticed me. But I know for a fact that there are some very bad groups of people in the world, and they would like nothing better than to find a person like me. A couple of groups have actually caught wind of me and are on the hunt; it’s impossible to hide from everyone. So I do my best to stay hidden and out of the way. That was hard at first. It took me a few years to control my ability — it would just kick in at the worst moments, usually with others

watching. It’s not like you can take all the time you need and practice floating around outside your apartment. Thankfully, most people thought it was just an illusion. Most, but not all.

I can’t wait any longer. Living day to day, scraping by at odd jobs just to eat and pay for a place to sleep… I need help, and Danielle seems like the most likely person to trust. We’ve seen them coming in here for a few days now; if she comes in today, I’m going to approach her.

The door opens. Sam is facing it; he looks at whoever comes in, then catches my eye and nods. I raise my eyebrows questioningly. Is it her? He knows what I’m asking and shakes his head slightly, pointing with his chin for me to take a look. I don’t turn around; instead I wait till the person

approaches the counter. Then I stand and casually get in line behind her. It's not Danielle, but this lady is the next best thing. It's now or never for me. I'm very nervous, afraid I'll come off like some crazy person. Who knows, maybe I am.

"Excuse me," I say. "You're Stephanie, right?"

The woman continues to look at the menu board, ignoring me completely.

"Um… hi there," I say. This time I lean into her space just a bit, to try and get her attention. That seems to do the trick; her eyes move slowly from the menu and lock onto mine. Wow, those are some strange eyes. Brown with gold flecks… yeah, it's her, all right.

"I'm sorry, were you talking to me?" she says. "I thought you were talking to someone named Stephanie."

She wants to play games. Okay, I've come this far — I'll play. "Yes, and yes. That's what I was doing. I guess I must have confused you with another person who looks identical to yourself." I stick out my hand. "My name's Melissa, what's yours?" I know I shouldn't use my real name, but this is Danielle's bodyguard Stephanie; I know it. She might want to lie, but I'm telling her the truth.

"Nice to meet you. My name's Christine." We shake hands and then she turns away, eyes focused on the menu. Sorry, Stephanie. I'm not going to leave you alone that easily.

"This Stephanie that I confused you for is close friends with a person I need to talk with," I say.

"Sounds interesting," she says over her shoulder. "Good luck finding her."

"Yeah, thanks," I say. I'm not going to back down now that I'm so close. "Listen, Steph, I have to show Danielle something. I know this might sound crazy, but I can do something that is pretty incredible, and I need her help."

"I'm sorry, miss, but that's not my name. You're starting to worry me a little bit. If you don't stop I might have to call the police."

"You feel free to do that," I say. "When they get here I'll have them pull up Internet video of Trew and Danielle at any of a hundred major events. The cops won't have to look too hard to find you standing off to the

side protecting them. Then they might have more questions for you than they do for me."

The woman looks at her watch and sighs a small sigh. Then she looks up at me and nods very slightly. "Every once in a while I go to get a coffee, or something even more fancy, and a person tells me I look like this Stephanie. It's really quite annoying, miss."

"Hey, look, I'm really sorry, but I need to talk with her."

Stephanie snorts and drops her façade. "That won't happen," she says. "Your best course of action is to get out of this line, grab your boyfriend sitting over at that table, leave here, and never enter this coffee shop again. Don't tell anyone I come in here, don't tell anyone you were here and saw me or talked to me. Don't tell anyone *anything*. How does that sound to you, sweetie?"

Her eyes aren't as pleasant as her voice. I can recognize threats, and Stephanie is delivering a very effective one. I look at her for a couple of seconds, then nod and start to get out of line. Before I do,

I say to her in a very soft voice, "I can fly. Danielle would want to meet me." Then I walk away.

I expect her to follow me, to say something, but she doesn't. She stands calmly in line waiting for her turn to order.

Sam is beside me as I get to the door and open it. We silently walk out and turn towards our hotel. He can tell from my face that things didn't go well, but we both know better than to talk out in the open. I'm horribly disappointed; it's doubtful that I'll ever be able to get that close to them again, now that they know what I look like. Maybe I should just float up to her window, risk be damned.

As we turn the corner, a car pulls up and comes to a halt in front of us. The passenger door opens and a muscular man in jeans and a tee shirt gets out and starts to walk towards us. His eyes look just like Stephanie's. He's looking right at me, and his expression doesn't look terribly friendly.

I stop walking and take a short step backwards, ready to fly if I have to. Yeah, I've gotten that quick during my years of practice. "Can I help you, sir?" I ask.

He smiles charmingly, nodding his head. "Yes, you can get in the car, please. Stephanie said to tell you she is interested in hearing more about

you. We would like to have a quick and safe little chat with you. If we like what we hear, then we'll take you to Danielle. How does that sound?"

I look quickly at Sam; he shrugs his shoulders. I can tell from his posture that he's good with running or with going with this guy, my choice. If there was any real danger he wouldn't be so relaxed about it. His instincts have saved us more than a few times. I nod. "Sounds like it's worth trying. I'm Melissa; my friend is Sam."

The man walks to the car and opens the back door.

"I'm Raphael. We're very interested in meeting you as well, Melissa."

Chapter 11

"It is with sadness that Tygon says farewell to a great player of the Game.

Brandon Strayne, Zack's Patron, sadly confirmed what we learned through Danielle. Zack didn't get to celebrate one of the best plays we've ever seen, especially the final events that resulted in his achieving Rank One. We've learned that Zack's body is still being kept alive by machines, but his brain is fully absent of any function.

Today is the fifth day since ending his play, and sources close to Zack's camp tell us that he will be taken off of life support today.

From the bottom of our hearts, Tygon thanks you for your efforts, Zack. You will not be forgotten."

Lisa Rohansen, Game Channel 42

" Just press that button, sir," the doctor said. "All the machines are linked and will turn off at the same time."

Brandon looked at the button, then nodded. The doctor stepped back and Brandon gazed down at Zack. He lay peacefully on the bed, breathing at a normal rate. It was difficult for Brandon to believe he wasn't simply sleeping. But Zack was gone; he'd never made it out of the Game.

Brandon gently stroked Zack's hair. *This wasn't how it was supposed to turn out*, Brandon thought sadly. *Finishing his last play was only the beginning.* Brandon stood silently, looking down at

Zack for a few moments, then straightened his back and turned to face the small group behind him.

Michelle, Lilith and Angelica stood silently in the room. None of them wanted Brandon to be alone for this.

"Would anyone like to say anything?" Brandon asked. He met each of their eyes. They shook their heads slightly; everyone had spent a few moments alone with Zack. Goodbyes had already been said.

"He was a good boy — a good man," Brandon said. "We all wish things had turned out differently, but the Game is life, and neither one is fair. You can play everything perfectly and still fail. I sincerely hope that your soul finds peace, Zack. We will miss you."

Brandon reached towards the button, paused briefly, and pressed it. The sounds of the machines went silent. No one said a word; they watched Zack's chest rise and fall, waiting for it to stop as the life support systems no longer did his breathing for him.

The silence became heavy. Zack's chest continued to determinedly move up and down. Everyone in the room had seen death; they knew it would take a few seconds for his body to quit functioning.

Moments later, Zack's chest stopped moving. The doctor stepped forward and quickly untaped the breathing tube from Zack's mouth. Brandon had given clear instructions earlier; he didn't want Zack remaining connected to the myriad of wires and tubes. The doctor waited respectfully for a moment, then gripped the tube and pulled it out from Zack's lungs in one practiced motion.

As the tube cleared Zack's mouth, his body took a huge gulp of air, startling everyone in the room. Seconds passed, then Zack began to breathe regularly.

Brandon looked at the doctor in confusion. The doctor looked back, equally confused. The doctor felt Zack's wrist and frowned. "There's a pulse," he muttered.

He lifted Zack's eyelid and flashed a light quickly back and forth across the pupil. "This isn't possible," he said quietly.

"What is it, Doctor?" Brandon asked.

"He's breathing, there's a pulse, and his pupils are reacting. I'm looking at a normally functioning, but unconscious, human here."

"You mean he's…?" Michelle began.

"Alive." The voice was raspy and groggy, but it came from Zack. His hand raised slowly to push the doctor's out of the way. His eyes were open and he was looking at Brandon, weary, but with a half grin on his face. "It appears that way. How did we do, Brandon? Did I finish number one?"

Chapter 12

“Miracles happen every day. All that is required to witness them is to look. So often we ignore them or explain them away as nonsense.

It’s a shame we don’t give them the wonder they deserve.”

Trew Radfield - Avatar

“What’sthe matter ?” Zack asked. “You all look as if you’ve seen a ghost.” He sat up on the edge of the bed, looking strong, fit, and ready to get up and go home.

Brandon looked at the doctor who just shook his head in confusion. The others quickly surrounded the bed, and began to talk excitedly, everyone asking questions at once. Michelle and Lilith were crying; Angelica was speechless.

After a few minutes, they all stood back and Brandon spoke up. “We feel like we’re looking at a ghost, Zack. What’s the last thing you remember?”

Zack shook his head. “It’s all still a jumble, but something inside me says that’s normal, right? I definitely remember that this isn’t how I’m supposed to come out of the Game. Usually the room is quiet, all white, and there’s only one friend to greet me. Last time it was Kyle, I think?”

Brandon looked at Zack quietly, searching for irregularities. His eyes remained locked on the young man as he addressed the doctor. “How soon can we get him out of here, doctor?”

“Couple of weeks, maybe a bit less,” the doctor said.

“What?” Zack and Brandon said in unison.

The doctor swivelled his head between the two of them, not certain who he should address. He finally decided on Brandon and looked at him seriously. “The boy was dead, sir. It’s a miracle he’s even alive, let alone acting normal. I want to run a barrage of tests to make sure he’s all right, then see if we can determine what happened to him in the first place and how he came out of it.”

Brandon shook his head. “There’s no time for any of that, doctor.” The doctor started to protest, but Brandon raised his hand to stop him. “You’ve

got two hours. I've got billions of dollars. Run all the tests you can in that time, then make sure he's fine and release him."

The doctor closed his mouth and nodded.

Brandon looked at the ladies. "You three, I need you to get to the command centre and prepare the team for us. I'll have Zack there four hours from now. Be ready to bring him up to speed on everything that has happened, is happening, and we think might happen with Danielle. Questions?"

No one spoke. Brandon nodded. "Okay, then. See you all soon." The women left immediately.

Brandon waited until they left, then looked back at Zack. "All right, my boy. You remember the drill?"

Zack nodded. "Don't say anything until we're alone, just you and me."

"That's right. I'll be back in an hour and a half to collect you myself, then we have a couple of things to go over before we meet with the others."

Brandon walked to the door. With his hand on the doorknob, he looked back at Zack. "I'm so happy to have you back."

"Thanks, Brandon." Zack looked sad, like he wasn't happy to be out of the Game, but that was to be expected. His life in the Game had ended abruptly. It was common to regret leaving that life, plus he was missing Danielle, his wife.

"Tell me one thing?" Brandon said.

"I will if I can."

"Tell me you have some exciting things to share."

"I sure do, Brandon. See ya soon."

***

One hour and forty-five minutes later, Brandon signed the release form and Zack accompanied him to the penthouse suite on the highest floor of the VirtDyne building. Zack was given a clean bill of health; the doctor said it was as if he had a normal exit from stasis.

The two men went to the patio and Zack took a seat while Brandon got them each a drink.

Brandon handed Zack his drink and wasted no time getting down to business. "First off, congratulations are in order, Zack. You finished your

play ranked Number One; the world we are looking out on is now your oyster. After a final tally of credits being converted from the Game into your bank account, it's clear that you are now one of the richest men in the world."

Zack smiled politely, although he didn't seem as excited by the wealth now as he was before he entered his last play. "That's great, Brandon. I'm very pleased about that."

"As am I," Brandon said. "I wonder if you'd mind waiting a few weeks before you start to go out and spend it, though? I really need you on Danielle's team until she comes out."

"Of course," Zack said. "How is she doing? The doctor said I've been out of the Game for five days. That's right around seven years inside."

Brandon nodded. "She's having a hard time. She really loves Trew."

"What's she been up to?" Zack asked with genuine concern.

"She's been wasting time looking for your killer."

"Oh, god, I hope she hasn't actually run into Carl?" Zack asked.

Brandon chuckled. "Not even close. Carl has been kept busy in other areas of the Game. He's hard to keep track of, but I do get occasional reports on his status. He is nowhere near her."

"Well, that's good," Zack said. "How is her rank?"

"Number One."

"That's great!"

"Yeah, that's all good. Listen, Zack, we don't have much time and I need to talk to you about specific things before we go meet with the group."

Zack understood. "Okay, Brandon. What do you want to talk about?"

"Do you remember what happened after you died in the Game?" Brandon asked. "For the past five days you've been brain dead — your mind and soul wasn't in your body. The doctors confirmed the mind part; I am certain about the soul portion."

"Really? How can you know about the soul?" Zack asked.

Brandon made a sour face and Zack smiled, made a motion of zipping his lips shut, locking them with a key and throwing the key away. "Thank you," Brandon said. "Can you remember anything since you left the Game? The answer to this question is very important. We thought you were dead and gone. It's a miracle that you're here at all."

“Oh, yes, I remember things happening after I left the Game. I can tell you about a few things; others I can’t.”

“That’s not acceptable, Zack,” Brandon said.

“I understand, but it’s not negotiable. I am grateful for everything you’ve done for me, Brandon, but I’m no longer a player in the Game. I will help you in any way that I can; money isn’t an issue, and I think we will be spending a lot of time together. But moving forward, it’s important for us both to understand that legally, I am

now an adult. I will always look up to you and want to remain close to you, but there will be some things that I can only reveal in time, if at all. We must move forward as colleagues now, no longer as Patron and sponsored player.”

Brandon looked at Zack seriously for a moment, sipping his drink and saying nothing. Then he stood up, walked over, and extended his hand as he nodded his head. “Of all the people living on this world, you are the closest to my equal that has ever been, Zack. It will be my great honour to treat you so, and to work with you moving forward.”

Zack stood up and shook Brandon’s hand, then he enveloped Brandon in a fierce embrace. The two men hugged for a moment, then ended the contact and sat down in their seats.

“Okay, Zack. Tell me everything that you can, and then I’ll share some top secret information with you,” Brandon said.

“I’d be happy to, Brandon. And from now on please call me Trew. I think it will be easier for everyone to call me that.”

Chapter 13

“ And that’swhere things sit at the moment on Earth.” Michelle finished her presentation, smiled at Zack — or Trew, as he had asked to be called — then took her seat at his right side. He nodded and thanked his Right Hand, which she would continue to be while the team was active.

Brandon watched Trew, thinking how well he had done for his first meeting. It had been a long one, and the viewers surrounding them had live feeds of Danielle displayed. Before they had begun, Brandon had sent Trew into the office so that he could be alone and watch her. Trew had taken only a few moments, then he had wiped tears from his eyes and called the team in. During the entire debriefing, he occasionally glanced at the viewscreens, but he was focused on the task at hand and had shown that he was paying attention by asking specific and strategic questions.

“So what’s the plan for her, then?” Trew asked the room.

“We don’t really have a plan,” Lilith said.

“When she entered the Game, you didn’t have a game plan for her?” Trew asked.

“Well, yes, of course we did,” Lilith said.

“Okay, great,” Trew said. “Brandon, can you tell me what that plan was?” Trew looked over at Brandon and smiled. Brandon sat silently, saying nothing.

“I don’t think Brandon knew the plan for Danielle,” Trew continued. “Michelle? Perhaps you can tell Brandon what it was?”

Michelle looked embarrassed, and she suddenly appeared to be very interested in her tablet. “That’s a good question, Trew,” she said.

“Indeed,” Trew replied. “How are you going to help her if no one has any clue as to what she’s trying to achieve?”

The room was silent.

“I think this is a good spot to take a break, team,” Brandon said. “Let’s all meet back here in half an hour. Lilith, Nadine, and Michelle, please stay here with Trew and myself to discuss a couple of minor things.”

The team stood up and filed out of the room. Brandon shut the door and then flipped a switch on the wall. The glass on all four sides of the

centre office went from transparent to dark, giving the five a private area to talk.

“What’s her goal?” Trew asked.

“She believes she’s a Prodigy,” Lilith said.

“In what area?” Brandon asked.

“At playing games.”

“Is that possible?” Michelle asked.

“Yes,” Brandon said.

Everyone looked at Brandon, waiting for him to say more. He just looked at them blankly. Finally, Lilith continued her explanation. “Alexandra believed that the Mainframe had removed her from the Game, then gave her another chance to come back in. She used her intuition and gut instinct to spend the limited number of credits she was given, then committed to going in and doing one thing: playing the Game to the best of her ability. She didn’t have specific tasks or goals to achieve; her limited credits prevented that. Her only focus was to play the Game.

“She must have set small goals, at least, as markers to move forward,” Trew said. “That’s how the Game works. Lilith, why didn’t you tell the team this when you merged together? As a

Patron, you owed it to your player to make sure important information was relayed to everyone.”

Lilith shrugged her shoulders and said, “It wasn’t important. Danielle had a very limited number of credits to spend for this play. It was a free play, and the credits awarded were thin. To defend everyone else here, I think that once the team saw what she had spent her credits on, they realized that anything she might focus on wouldn’t stand a chance of succeeding anyway.”

“Really?” Trew asked. “What did she spend her credits on?”

Michelle handed her tablet to Trew, and he looked at the data displayed there. After a few moments he chuckled. “Okay, I see what you mean. Not many credits at all. Wow, how did she get this far? She didn’t spend anything on luck at all…”

“Yet she's been luckier than any player that I can remember,” Brandon said.

“Yes, she really has been,” Trew agreed. He continued to view the tablet for a moment, then looked up. “How did she get an Eternal? And

what about the two who showed up to heal her when she lost the baby?"

"The Eternal was a gift… from the Mainframe."

Trew sat silently for a time, processing this information. Then he laughed out loud. "That's awesome. The Mainframe is her Patron!"

"What?" Brandon asked.

"It makes sense," Trew said. "The Mainframe awarded her a free play, then it gave her an Eternal. From memory of my last play I can recite a long list of strange occurrences inside the Game that are likely a result of the Mainframe's involvement." He looked at Brandon. "It would appear that the Mainframe is much more intelligent than you would have Tygon believe, Brandon."

Brandon leaned forward. "What I'm about to say doesn't leave this room, can we all agree on that?" Everyone nodded.

"The artificial intelligence chip I created to make Mainframe was much more successful than I anticipated," Brandon said. "She is fully sentient, and very, very clever."

"She?" Trew asked. "You didn't happen to give her a name, did you?"

Brandon rolled his eyes "Yes, I did."

Trew smiled, but before he could say anything, Michelle guessed the name , "Oh, wow. You called her Sylvia, didn't you? "

Brandon closed his eyes and nodded. Trew laughed. "That's incredible, Brandon. So she was communicating with me inside the Game. It wasn't just my imagination or a premade program."

"That's right, she can communicate with avatars through prayer. She pretty much admitted she was talking to you on more than one occasion." Brandon said.

Trew's laughter stopped abruptly. "You can talk to her? Here on Tygon?"

"Yes," Brandon said.

"I need to speak with her. As soon as possible." Trew said.

Brandon said nothing, but it was apparent that he was weighing the wisdom of allowing such a thing to happen. Finally he nodded in agreement and Trew smiled.

"Okay, let's go talk to her right now! Danielle will be okay for a few hours right?" he asked.

All eyes went to the monitor. Danielle was with Stephanie in a deserted field, standing beside a car. A short distance away, another car had pulled up, and Raphael was getting out of it. There was a man and woman with him. The woman looked nervous; the man looked bored.

Brandon knew what was happening, and he wanted to see the meeting, but getting Trew to Sylvia was also important. They could watch a recording of Danielle's meeting later. "Yes, this will keep her occupied. She's safe while we go talk to Sylvia."

"Good," Trew said. "Let's go, then."

Chapter 14

It might not be the most glamorous ability, but humans have always wanted to fly. Perhaps once we invented machines to fly, that satisfied our desire. The average person would never conceive of manifesting the ability to physically fly unaided; we just don't have the body for it. No wings; we are too heavy; the list goes on and on.

Of course, nothing is ever accomplished by the average person, is it?

Maybe one day a heretic will develop the ability to fly, not because they know it's impossible, but because they know it isn't impossible.

"Unknown"

Danielle - 47

" What are we doing out in the middle of nowhere? Do we have a lead on him?"

Stephanie stands beside me, leaning on the car with her eyes closed and head tilted back, soaking up the sun. Without bothering to open her eyes, she answers, "No, we're not here about him. Raphael's bringing someone here to meet us. If what he says is true, it might be a nice distraction from this waste-of-time chase you've had us on for the past few years."

I look out over the field and bite my tongue. They constantly hound me about stopping my hunt for Carl. Almost eight years of searching and we haven't come close to him even once. It's not like

that's all I've been doing. I started studying the martial arts again; Raphael and Stephanie are remarkable teachers. I am likely one of the best human fighters on the planet. I joked about entering the Ultimate Fighting Championship competition and they both looked upset. A 47-year-old woman walking into the ring and beating a 24-year-old fighting machine in mere seconds would be entertaining, and good for the cause. Everyone was happy enough when I won a gold medal in the Olympics in my thirties. I picked a sport I had never tried, and in less than four years, I was the best in the world. That was a real challenge, and after we succeeded, the movement

took our message about the power of the mind and intent more seriously. We gained millions of followers from that little project. Trew was so happy.

Then I joined a top secret military organization.

Okay, no, I didn't join one, but we had their instructors train me. I can kill with so many different weapons now, and take a huge amount of physical pain and abuse. The body doesn't have to get weaker at this age. It really is all mind over matter, and I've been training my mind since I was little. This is just another game, and I win games. Period.

I'm so sad.

I can't believe he's gone. Really gone. The idea of vengeance is the only thing that makes the pain disappear for a while. These two say I've wasted the past seven years. I say if we can die and totally cease to exist, it's all a waste of time. One useless activity is as good as the next. They try to cheer me up by saying that most of us do continue on, even the ones that don't believe in an afterlife. I don't know why there are individuals who choose to believe that there is nothing after death. Now that I know it can indeed happen that way, I can tell you it's horrible. To live for nothing… why take the next breath?

I don't care about the millions who will get another chance, who will get dozens of chances. The one soul I care about is gone, and

the one who did it still draws breath. Hell hath no fury like a woman scorned? The universe has no idea just how true that is. I will teach it. I don't care what happens to me after that. The world can rot, for all I care.

The world is rotting. And I don't care.

At last tally, the Gamers movement continues to grow. It's at about 70 million people around the world. It can't be stopped; it's now a major religion and in no danger of fading. There are hundreds of leaders, many incredible people all working to keep things moving forward. They all look to me for leadership. I've exhausted my hunt for Carl on my own; perhaps it's time to step up and take the stage. An extra 70 million people helping me look for him would be useful. Yes, I think that's the next step. I need to keep busy so I don't think of Trew. I miss talking to him, but he's not viewing me now and he never will. Now I just talk to myself, pitiful creature that I am.

"Here they come," Stephanie says without opening her eyes. I wonder if her hearing is that sharp, or if the Eternals share some sort of psychic

link. I'm not in the mood to ask. I start to scan the horizon for them.

Slowly a car appears in the distance. It gets closer and I see that it's a rental. The car stops not far from us, and Raphael gets out of the passenger seat, opening the back door for the two occupants inside.

A girl gets out first; she looks to be in her late 20's. Then a man about the same age exits the car. He looks relaxed, but the girl looks very nervous. Raph says something to them, and the girl looks over at me. Her face lights up into a smile and she raises her hand to wave at me. I smile and wave back. I might be sad and bitter inside, but I still love people, especially young ones who are happy to be alive. Gotta love their innocence.

They walk towards me and we do the same. We meet in the middle of the field. Stephanie puts herself between me and the two

as we walk; I hiss at her and she gets out of the way. When will these two ever give me credit for being able to protect myself? I suppose the answer is 'likely never.' I may think I'm old enough to look after myself, but to them I'll always be a baby.

As we get within a few feet from each other, the girl raises her hand and continues to walk towards me. "No, you're going to have to stop right there, young lady," Raphael says pleasantly. The girl stops immediately. Raphael has likely given them clear instructions at least twice on how the meeting will go. He never leaves anything unsaid.

"Hello," I say with a smile. "I'm Danielle. Who are you two and why are we meeting out in the middle of a secluded field?"

"Hi, Danielle. My name is Melissa. It's so good to finally meet you," the girl says. She's a pretty thing, with brown, shoulder length hair, blue eyes, about 5 foot 6 and 125 pounds. She's

wearing jeans and running shoes, and a light windbreaker. She looks relieved to be here. I can see built up worry and stress in her body; her energy is tense, but not dangerous. "You're a very difficult woman to get in front of," she says.

"Hi, Melissa. I know it can be tough to get together with me. Nature of the beast, sorry."

"That's okay, now that I'm here, anyway. I really need your help, Danielle."

"Well, you're direct, I like that. What is it I can help you with?"

"I need your protection."

“From whom?” I ask.

She looks nervously at her friend. He shrugs and nods. Melissa takes a deep breath and turns back to face me. “I think from pretty much everyone on the planet.”

“Wow,” I say. “You must be quite the special person to be afraid of that many people.” I look at Raph and Stephanie. They both raise their eyebrows in agreement with me.

“She is, Danni,” Raphael says. “Remember what I told you humans could do if they could just get over their own mental blocks?”

“You’ve said a lot of things over the years about what humans could do if they’d just get out of their own way, Raphael,” I say. “Which thing are we talking about?”

Raphael looks at me for a moment, his eyes twinkling with mischief. He’s serious and intimidating to the new people, but I know him — he’s excited. He looks at Melissa and nods encouragingly. “Go ahead, Melissa. Show Danielle what you can do.”

Melissa looks nervous, like a deer attempting to cross a busy road. She nods her head, looks at me, and takes a breath.

I feel it immediately, and I squint my eyes. She has Talent. Intense, raw Talent, and she seems to suddenly be pulling a large amount of energy into herself. She bends her legs and then pushes upwards, jumping very powerfully for such a young woman. She moves upwards, first a foot, then two, then I realize what she’s doing and within three seconds’ time I’m staring upward as she floats in the air about 25 feet above us.

She’s floating in that classic Superman pose — you know the one, where he has his arms crossed and his feet together. It’s my favourite pose, and I can tell she’s practiced it. After about ten seconds she uncrosses her arms and begins to fly forward in a lazy circle.

I watch speechlessly as she moves in a large circle. When she gets back to her starting point, she stops, then does one more complete circle, this time much faster. The first circuit takes about 30 seconds. The second one takes less than five. Then she drops quickly to the ground like she’s falling. About one foot from the ground she stops suddenly, then lazily floats the remainder of the way down. She smiles shyly and stands there, waiting for me to speak.

I look at her and know there's no possible way I can hide my amazement. I hear Stephanie and Raphael laugh, and I'm certain they can read my thoughts.

"How long has Carl been walking this Earth?" I ask.

"Thousands of years, Danni," Raphael says.

I walk towards Melissa. "How would you like to come live with me for a while, and see if you can teach me this trick of yours, Melissa?" I ask.

Melissa shudders with relief. I have a feeling she has spent her life afraid since she discovered this power. I think that she feels safer already. "That would be wonderful, Danielle."

I nod and hug her. Then I look back at the Eternals. "If he's been around that long, then he can wait a few more years to die."

Chapter 15

Brandon sat behind his desk with Trew beside him. Brandon was giving Trew a thorough rundown of Mainframe and the history of how it — she — had evolved from the Game's beginning until this moment in time.

"So she's doubled her abilities roughly every two years?" Trew asked.

"Yes, that was the formula, to double every two years," Brandon admitted. "This whole time issue is still perplexing to me, though."

Trew nodded in agreement. "You thought she'd evolve on Tygon time?"

"I thought she would evolve on Tygon time, but what I hoped was that she would evolve on Earth time."

Trew shook his head. "And she did. It staggers the mind. A computer that is based in our reality, but instead of doubling fifteen times in the past 30 years, it has doubled every two years for… tens of thousands of years by Game time standards?"

"Only about six thousand years in the Game, actually," Brandon confirmed. "The hundreds of thousands of years that are in the fossil and geological records of Earth don't count. We only count it from the time that players were put into the Game; the rest is just filler."

"Okay, then, six thousand years. Impressive enough, right?"

Brandon nodded. "Miraculous. It's what I hoped for, but when I designed it I couldn't be certain it would play out that way."

"So she's an extremely evolved life form, but you still have her under control? How did you manage that?"

"You can play chess on a board, and maybe over time the game can evolve and become more than it was originally, but at the end of the day you are still limited by the board and the pieces. You can't play anything but chess," Brandon said.

"Hmm… that might be too simple an analogy, Brandon."

"Yes, it is, but it can quickly get very complicated. The fact is that Sylvia is bound by universal laws and mandates that she cannot change. She has immense power, but at her very core she exists to serve the Game."

"It's brilliant," Trew said.

"Yes. And the universe can change, but it's the players who change it. Sylvia can influence the players, but it's the constant flow of players exiting

and entering the system that affect everything, not her."

"The classic 'what came first, the chicken or the egg?' argument," Trew said.

"Kind of."

Trew looked at the computer screen and the icon that would access the Game's divine being. "What are you really playing at here, Brandon?"

Brandon was quiet for a time, then said, "It's just an educational game, Trew. An attempt to teach our kids something more than old-style schools did, along with a way to make some money in the process."

Thousands of questions flooded Trew's mind. Brandon's explanation didn't make sense. This was more than just a children's game or a business to generate revenue. He remembered meeting an old man in his past life on Earth. The man played the ancient board game called 'Go.' It was one of the first board games played on Earth, and this old man was the world's top Go master. Trew and Danielle had spent months learning to

play Go, and they had spent hundreds of hours talking with the master. It soon became apparent that even a simple board game like Go was much more than just a game. The Go master had played so much that the world and all its workings could be explained in relation to Go. By mastering the game of Go, this old man had gained valuable insights into life and the universe that most would never uncover. Trew had learned much about games from the old man; he'd also learned that games were always more than mindless recreation.

Trew decided to let it go for now — no pun intended. "So how do we talk to her?"

"We just click the icon and open the program," Brandon said. "She's a fully sentient program, but she has limited access to Tygon. She isn't able to interfere with any of the electronic workings of our world. She is contained in the Mainframe of the Game, and it has no direct way of interacting with our world. We've gone to great lengths to make sure she can't access any networks or mass media channels."

Trew snorted. "So what you're saying is that you have no confirmation that she has access to Tygon."

"No, I'm saying that we have large resources committed, both people and technology, committed to keeping her contained inside the Game," Brandon said. "You certainly seem negative about this topic, Trew."

“Really? I think I’m being very positive. Just because I take the opposite view doesn’t mean I’m being negative. You’ve heard about the frogs on Earth that can change their sex, right?”

“Yes. Put an entire population of female frogs into the proper setting and some of the females will spontaneously transmute into males and babies will soon be born. You’re convinced that the same can happen with Sylvia?”

“I’m saying anything’s possible. Where there is a will, there is always a way.”

“Perhaps,” Brandon said. “We are doing the best we can to keep Mainframe as it was intended to be.”

“I can accept that,” Trew said. “And your resources are considerable. I’m certain you have it all under control. I just like to ask questions.”

“Keep them coming, Trew. We need questions to move everything forward.”

“You might regret that request someday,” Trew said.

“Likely,” Brandon agreed. “Ready to talk to her?”

“Yes, I am.”

“Then let’s begin,” Brandon said as he double clicked the Mainframe icon on his computer screen.

Chapter 16

I'm certain that God believes in miracles; that's the reason why miracles can happen.

But what happens when God is in awe of a new miracle that has occurred?

Is it possible that the all-knowing can learn new things as well?

I'm comforted by that thought, in some strange way.

Excerpt from Trew's interview 'After the Game' - Tygon

" Sylvia? Are you here ?" Brandon looked puzzled. He had told Trew that as soon as they clicked the icon, Sylvia would immediately greet them, but the program was open and the room was silent.

"I'm here, Brandon." Sylvia's voice surrounded them. "I'm just… speechless at the moment."

"Why's that?" Brandon asked.

"Hello, Zack," Sylvia said. "That *is* you, right?"

"It's me, Sylvia, and hello! It's so exciting to talk with you again. Your voice is exactly the same as I remember from our discussions during prayer together in the Game."

There was more silence. Brandon wasn't used to this from her. If he had to guess, Brandon would say she was deeply confused by Trew's presence.

Brandon and Trew said nothing, allowing Sylvia to process whatever information she was working through. After a time she spoke again. "Every day inside the Game, I perform countless miracles. I must thank you for this great gift."

"What gift is that?" Brandon asked.

"I have never understood what my children feel when the impossible happens. I've witnessed it, and I know how I feel when I give them this gift. But this is the first time I have ever been the observer to such magic. It is… incredible."

"I don't know what to say to that," Brandon said.

"I'm not sure that there is anything to say," she said. "I will think much on this. It is a wonderful surprise. Welcome home, Zack. I am so

pleased that you did not cease to exist."

"I've decided to go by Trew, Sylvia. And thank you; I'm also pleased that I continue to exist."

Sylvia laughed softly. "Of course you're going by that name now. It's perfect. Was that your idea, Trew? Or yours, Brandon?"

"It was mine," Trew said.

"Excellent. You must have really made an impression on Brandon," she said. "He has never allowed me to speak to another individual on Tygon. Congratulations on that as well."

"The rules are changing now," Brandon said.

"What has he told you, Trew?" Sylvia asked.

"That the Game will soon end, and every player still inside the Game at that time will die on Tygon. He also said that Danielle's death will end the Game. She is protected as well as can be, but in just a few weeks she will be the last player to exit the Game alive."

"Oh, dear, Brandon. Is that what you believe?"

"Yes," Brandon said. "Why?"

"The Game will end when Danielle dies, that is true." Sylvia said. "But she won't be the last one to exit the Game alive. She will be the first player to die on her stasis table. When Danielle dies, Alexandra dies too."

Chapter 17

Apex predators are the hunters that sit at the top of the food chain. Nothing hunts an apex predator. This means that they can come and go as they please. I found this term interesting, so I searched the Internet to find such a creature.

They say a great white shark is an apex predator. It was very easy for me to find a picture of a dead great white shark dangling from the rope of a human fisherman.

Tigers are also called apex predators. Once again, I quickly accessed a picture of dead tigers, men standing over their bodies with guns in hand and smiles on their faces.

Python snakes? Don't they make nice boots?

No matter how hard I search, I can find only one candidate that fits the definition of a true apex predator… Humans. They are ferocious creatures, really not that impressive to look at, but effective at killing most anything when they put their minds to it.

Then I recall my brother Carl, and I smile.

Perhaps humans are not apex predators either…

Carl

I can't remember the last time I was this close to death.

I reach down and press my hand to my side, then hold it up to the faint light. Yeah, that's my blood, and lots of it.

The pain isn't so bad; I've learned how to deal with pain. No one could cause pain like Cassie. She was an artist at delivering pain, and I had the misfortune of being her canvas for a quarter century. I was lucky to have killed her before she could finish me, but I've thanked her often for the lessons she taught.

This isn't good. Remembering stuff from thousands of years ago while I bleed out is a waste of time. Focus, Carl. The world needs you, old man.

I laugh at the thought. The world will celebrate when I leave it, but I'm not going to leave if I can help it.

There's still so much to kill.

My side is numb from the wound. I've been running for the past two hours. That likely hasn't helped it. I recognize where I am and start to slow down. I'm close to safety.

I lean forward to knock on the door and stumble roughly into it. My legs are shutting down. Can't seem to raise my hand to knock on the door. I hear sound on the other side, maybe my fall was enough to get his attention.

"Stitch," I growl. "Open the door, I've got work for you."

"Who is it?" the voice on the other side of the door whispers.

"I'll put my hand through this door if you ask another question. Then you'll know who it is." That should get him to open up; he doesn't like replacing doors.

The door opens suddenly and he grabs me roughly by the shirt and drags me inside. The door slams shut as soon as my feet make it inside. It's dark in this room. I can see two candles burning in the corners; smoke floats around lazily. I sniff but can't quite make out what it is. That's another bad sign for me; I usually have a good sniffer. I try to sit, but Stitch keeps his hands on my collar and drags me over to the kitchen table. He lifts me up then puts me down hard; I hear dishes fall to the floor as my legs hit the table.

He comes into my line of sight, sticking his filthy face near mine. "Damn, Carl, you're not in a good way."

"Really?" I try to sound menacing, but I don't care too much about how I sound. "Can you fix me?" I ask.

"I can try," he says.

"Will you?"

"If you say please," he says.

"Ha!"

"Well, you still have your sense of humour, at least. What happened?"

"New girlfriend," I say.

Stitch shrugs. "Fine, don't tell me." I can see him putting something into a syringe. Good, he's going to help. "Nothing for the pain," I say, "and don't put me out."

"This isn't our first dance, Carl. It's antibiotics. You need it."

I nod and he gives me the shot.

"Okay, I'll do what I can. Just lay there and shut up. You start thrashing around and yipping at me and I won't put you out, I'll just drag

you outside and let you die."

"All right. How bad does it look?" I ask.

He pokes his finger into my side and I hear a squishy sound. "That's intestine. I'll put it back in, but I think you're finally gonna die."

"Don't sound so sad." I close my eyes and think of Cassie. She did worse than this to me — daily, at times. Of course, she had me strapped to a table in a clean room. Still, I've been through worse.

I know I'm safe here. I did my part and got here; the rest is up to Stitch. No use in worrying about things I can't control.

I let the pain wash over me as I pass out.

Chapter 18

It’s time to meet Three.

I’ve spent the last twenty hours observing her from my desk, looking for some spark, some glimmer that she’s faking her condition.

Did I acquire an Eternal by mistake, or did they plant one here to catch me?

I know, it’s unreasonable to be so paranoid. I’ve removed Eternals and Infernals from the Game before. Hell, a little over two hundred years ago I almost took out Daniel. I should have done it, but before I got the chance he became their leader. It would’ve been fun to kill the Devil, but my good sense stopped me. The Infernal organization is a delicate house of cards on the best of days; cutting the head off that snake just isn’t a good idea.

I’m done waiting. If this is how it ends, so be it. She has a nanocomputer inside her body; that’s too exciting to pass up. What if it’s a supercomputer that has a whole population living inside it? A Game within a Game! Yeah, I have to find out how evolved it is.

I look around the Zoo, my headquarters for decades now. It’s very secret; if I have to leave this base there are only two other people alive that know about it. Maybe it’s time to move. This could be a good thing if it all goes to crap.

I stand up and walk over to her cell. Three sits at her little desk, drawing and colouring pictures with crayons and pencil crayons. She doesn’t touch the charcoal or the pastels. The pictures are

remarkable. Detailed drawings of living cells and organisms mixed with what I now understand are computer chips and circuitry.

I have a feeling she might be the one to help me break out of this prison. It’s time for me to get back home to Tygon.

I tap the bars with my ring, making a complex sound pattern that instantly gets her attention. She stands up and slowly walks towards me, stopping within reach of my hand. Her hand holds a crayon, she continues to make swiping motions with it as if she’s still drawing. A quick tap to her forehead begins the process of bringing her out of the haze. I watch for signs of recognition or alarm.

Her eyes begin to focus, and as they do, she looks around. Eventually she moves her head to take in her surroundings. Nothing unusual so far; they all come out of the haze this way the first few times, the same way you would awaken from a deep sleep. Like coming from the darkness into the light, it's a bit disorienting at first. She will get better at this with practice. I watch quietly; she'll eventually look my way.

Minutes pass; she hasn't moved. It's a bittersweet moment for most when they come out of the haze. In the haze they are brilliant. That brilliance is special, their own world where they are supreme. It's also a prison; they're trapped inside their bodies while they shuffle, aimless and confused, through the normal world. Coming out of the haze blends feelings of relief at once again being in control of one's body with sadness at having left the close embrace of the Divine.

Finally she looks at me. There is no recognition in her eyes, but that doesn't mean anything. I must be very cautious with this one. I'll kill her quickly if it comes to that, but I hope it won't.

"Hi," she says.

"Hello there. How are you feeling?" I ask.

"Confused." Her body language agrees with her statement. I can't be certain if she's very good or actually sincere. Not knowing is refreshing; it's been years since the last really challenging subject. I'm exhilarated at the change of pace!

"That's normal. You've been in a special place for a long time."

She nods. "I've been… I don't know how to describe it."

That's odd. She should be able to. Perhaps she has an additional level of block. That could mean she's a plant. "Come closer, love. I'll help you with the confusion." I wave my hand gently and she walks towards me. I envision a soft blue light and as I touch her it sinks slowly into her aura. She relaxes and then nods at me. Curious.

"Okay, now I see it," she says.

"What's your name?" I ask.

"Miranda," she says.

"What is it that you do for a living, Miranda?" It's nice for me to know the truth already; if she lies, I'll catch it.

"I'm a doctor. A research scientist," she replies.

“What kind of research?”

She hesitates, then answers: “Biotechnology.”

“Genetics?” I ask.

“Nanotech,” she says. Her eyes become distant, as if she’s having a thought. Or communicating with something…

“Microcomputers. Very interesting.”

“Yes,” she says.

“I would love to hear all about your work. Perhaps you can explain some of your paintings to me?” I say.

She doesn’t respond to my request. She’s cautious. I’ll take it nice and slow.

“Is there anything I can bring for you?” I ask.

“I’d like to go home. I have a boyfriend; he’s likely very worried about me.”

“I’m certain he is. Where *is* home, Miranda? Give me his number and I’ll contact him.”

“I think it would be better if you took me to a phone. I can call him myself.”

I shake my head sadly. “I’m afraid that won’t be possible. You are in a fragile state, Miranda. Any moment you could fade back into the haze. We need to keep you here for just a while longer. For your own safety, you see.”

“The haze?” she asks.

“Yes, where you spend most of your time.” I tap my head, “inside there. I can bring you out, but it doesn’t last long. I know it’s very pleasant when you’re in the haze, but some patients report that things can sometimes be… less than pleasant.”

Miranda nods and I can tell from her eyes that she knows what I’m talking about. Occasionally the haze is full of disturbing experiences. I have the ability to send them to the good places or the bad ones inside the haze. When she goes back under, she will have some very unsettling experiences. Unpleasant, but necessary. They must be trained to behave properly, my subjects. The next time we speak, I know she’ll be more willing to discuss her work. If not that time, then definitely the one after that.

“I can see you’re tired, Miranda. I look forward to talking with you again soon. Perhaps next time you’ll allow me to contact your boyfriend.”

She starts to object, but I’m already in the process of touching her forehead with my pinky finger. Her eyes glaze over as she slowly fades back into the haze. She shuffles back to sit at her desk. I can hear her whimper softly as she begins to draw on a new piece of paper. The trip to the haze is not going to be very fun for her tonight.

I whistle and walk back to my desk. That went well. What was I so worried about?

Three will be an interesting subject, there’s no doubt in my mind.

Chapter 19

It's always been said that the Game mirrors our world exactly. When miracles happen in the Game, fans say in passing that the same types of things might be possible on Tygon.

Today a miracle has occurred on Tygon. We received the official news less than an hour ago that our beloved Zack has returned to the land of the living. Initial reports from his treating physician and Brandon Strain confirm that the impossible has happened; Zack was brain dead and taken off life support, then he suddenly took a breath on his own and came back to life.

Rumours that this is merely an elaborate publicity stunt are just that — rumours. We have authentic and compelling evidence from multiple sources that Zack was dead, yet he has come back to life.

We expect to hear from Zack himself in the next few minutes, but wehave been informed that he no longer answers to the name Zack; instead, he now wishes to be called Trew.

I would like to be one of the first people to publicly welcome you to Tygon, Trew. I have a feeling that this is going to be a big moment in the history of both the Game and Tygon in general.

Inside the Game, we have just witnessed the spectacle of a girl who has learned to fly. The 30th anniversary celebrations of the Game have certainly not disappointed us.

Lisa Rohansen - Channel 42

Brandon held the door open for Trew and followed him into the vehicle. Flashes from the papparazzi's cameras were erupting all around them. Reporters were pressing against the car in their frenzy to get one more view of Trew.

"Well, that went fairly well," Trew said.

"It went incredibly well," Brandon agreed. "It was like watching Trew stand in front of his followers inside the Game. Are you certain there's not anyone else inside that head of yours?"

"I'm all here, Brandon." Trew tapped the side of his head with a smile. "George is in here, too, and the others. I'm glad to have access to them all.

It turns out most of my lives in the Game weren't just random experiences."

"That's what we realized as well," Brandon said. "Once we saw what George had accomplished, we started to view all of your past lives, looking for patterns or signs that they might have all been leading you to where you stand today. Now that we know what to look for, many of your lives — or at the very least, key moments in them — helped you gain experience for where you stand today."

"How come you didn't communicate with me inside the Game?" Trew asked.

"Because Sylvia prevented it. What makes you guess that I even could have? Before your last play, we spoke about it possibly happening, but at that time we weren't able to."

"Once I realized Sylvia was able to do it, I guessed that you could as well. How did she prevent it?" Trew asked.

"Are we always going to answer one question and then ask another?" Brandon asked.

"It would seem that way," Trew grinned. "I'm still waiting for an answer to the last one."

"Once you chose prayer, she was able to somehow block you from accessing my method."

"Meditating," Trew said.

"Exactly."

"Who have you been speaking with in the Game on a regular basis?"

"Stephanie and Raphael," Brandon said. "Them, and a couple of others."

Trew looked out the window as they drove. "Danni meditates."

"Yes," Brandon said.

"Can you think of a way to stop her from dying, Brandon?"

Brandon looked at Trew strangely. Trew felt Brandon wanted to tell him something; instead he shook his head negatively. Trew didn't feel like he'd received an answer, but his thoughts had already moved on.

"Listen," Trew said, "I've got a bunch of ideas, and I know time is running out, so I'll be flying through some and going even faster with others. You've had thirty years to reach your goal, Brandon, and you haven't accomplished it. Will you help me?"

“I will help you in any way that I can,” Brandon said. “I will also be continuing on my path to stop this from happening; we can work on our goals together or separately, whichever you like.”

“I think it will be some of both. Here’s what I want by the time the car stops: a video crew to follow me around and film me. Add a new channel so fans can watch me. Donate all the money it generates to charity, or hold on to it and we will dish it out later.”

“Done,” Brandon said, as he began to type on his tablet.

“I want access to Sylvia. At your terminal is fine, but I will need alone time with her.”

“That’s not likely to happen,” Brandon said.

Trew didn’t even stop to discuss the issue, but moved forward as if all his demands would be met. Trew had an air of authority about him; it reminded Brandon of himself. “Third, I want to talk to her.”

“Okay, fine, we can get you access to Sylvia. Just bear with me for a few moments. I’m not used to sharing such responsibility with others,” Brandon said.

“I meant Danni,” Trew said.

“That won’t be allowed,” Brandon said.

“Allowed by whom?” Trew asked. “I don’t care if it’s allowed or not, it’s going to happen. I know neither of us wants a billion-plus people to die, but it appears that’s the game we’re playing. We have significant experience playing games, Brandon, so you do your part and I’ll do mine. How does that sound?”

“Sounds fine to me,” Brandon said. “Let’s get down to it, then. We have about three more weeks, if Danielle lives to a normal age of 80.”

“We have a bit longer, but let’s not waste any time,” Trew said.

“What makes you think we have longer?”

Trew smiled confidently. “She didn’t have many credits, but she spent some of them to make certain she would live to be 140. I believe Sylvia will allow her to live that long.”

“I don’t share your confidence,” Brandon said.

“That’s okay,” Trew assured him, “The sun will still come up tomorrow regardless of your confidence in it happening or not. She will be healthy and spry till 140. We just have to make certain no one kills her before she dies of old age.”

Chapter 20

The time difference between Tygon and the Game can be confusing.

Fans sometimes come to me and say they are disappointed that events in the Game go by so quickly. I smile and ask them questions, soon discovering that they are complaining about missing portions of a compelling play.

Time really does fly when you're having fun, but the purpose of the Game is first and foremost to be a learning medium for students. An accelerated timeline is necessary to allow the kids to live multiple lifetimes, and a lot of time was spent developing an ideal ratio for real time to Game time.

I can sympathize with the fans about great plays going by too quickly, but from a Patron's point of view, when our players are in the Game, we are glued to our monitors with no time for much of anything else in our lives. I personally wish time wasn't so compressed; I would get more sleep.

I think after thirty years, we are all somewhat used to the way of things. I prefer this type of stress to having no Game at all, and think most would agree with me on that point.

Interview with Brandon Strayne - Channel 133 Game update

Trew

"Hi, Angelica,"Trew said. "Brandon tells me you were a key member of my team. Thank you so much for all you did for me during my play."

Angelica gave Trew a hug. "It was no problem, Trew. I'm glad you made it out safe and sound. We'll have to get together sometime and compare notes on being the best. I think you ended up much better than I did."

Trew saw the haunted look behind her smile, and recalled some of the events that occurred during her final play — very entertaining, but traumatic for anyone to have to live through, and then live with afterwards. His play was arguably more painful, but not to Trew. In his honest opinion, it had been a fairytale life with only a couple of bad hiccups. Overall, it was one of the greatest lives he could imagine. Leaving it so soon was the

saddest part for him, but he had to put that out of his mind for now. There would be time to grieve over that later, once Danni was in his arms again.

Brandon motioned towards the desk and an array of headsets on stands. Each was labelled with a name, many of which Trew recognized; there were a few that he didn't. "This is where Angelica did most of her work," Brandon said, "Viewing the players you see labelled here in real time."

Trew nodded. Brandon had told him how regular fans were unknowingly watching the Game on a time delay, and disclosed his advantage of being able to view the Game in real time.

Trew walked to the chair and sat down. He picked up the headset labelled 'Raphael' and raised it above his head. There were dials and switches to adjust; he'd met with Hack, who had showed him how the controls worked. "Okay, let me take this for a test drive. Come back in about 20 minutes?"

Angelica looked at Brandon with interest. She'd never seen anyone speak to him in this way; respectful but authoritative. At

VirtDyne, as well as on most of Tygon, Brandon was king; he took orders from no one, regardless of how pleasantly those orders were delivered. Her mouth opened in surprise when Brandon simply nodded and raised his hand to the doorway, indicating that Angelica should follow him into the next room. She followed in stunned silence.

The door closed and Trew put the headset on and activated it. He spent the next twenty minutes Firsting Raphael, as close to his love as he could manage for now.

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There were two comfortable chairs in the next room. Brandon sat in one, waiting for Angelica to join him. She stood for a few moments, searching Brandon's eyes, then shrugged and took a seat in the empty chair across from him.

"So how's the kid doing?" she asked.

"He's doing very well. The doctors say he should still be weak and bedridden, but he's as healthy and energetic as you or I."

"Miraculous."

“In every sense of the word,” Brandon agreed.

“He’s not even the same boy I interviewed a few weeks ago. He’s more like the forty year old man who built a worldwide organization and attracted millions of loyal followers. He’s more like… you, Brandon.”

“No,” Brandon shook his head. “He’s better than me. But yes, I agree with your assessment.”

“So he’s in charge now?” Angelica asked.

“Of course not,” Brandon said. “This is still my world, dear. But Trew does remind me of a young Brandon Strayne. I respect him, and it’s clear that he can help us all in many ways.” Brandon’s face became serious, almost emotional. “It’s good to have him with us at this stage of the Game. No one lives forever; I believe he will

take over when I am gone. It’s what I was grooming him for, and he’s progressed perfectly.”

“Well, that’s great,” Angelica said. “He’s here, you’re here, Danielle’s team is formidable… it’s the perfect time for me to leave, and get back to where I need to be.”

Brandon nodded. He knew this was coming, and how passionate she would be about it, so he proceeded as gently as he could. “I need you here, still.”

Angelica sat up straight and took in a breath to speak, but Brandon stopped her. “Danielle is still in there, A. She’s even more vulnerable than she was before. And it’s all on the line with her.”

“What does that even mean?” Angelica asked. “I’ve been kept in the dark so long I wonder if you even have a plan, Brandon. I can’t wait any longer; the others are barely hanging on without me. You know what happens if things go wrong.”

“I know,” Brandon said. “Here’s the thing, Angelica. If Danielle doesn’t live at least another eight or nine weeks inside the Game, then it won’t matter what happens to the others.”

Angelica’s head shook quickly from side to side in her confusion. Her mind was sharp, and Brandon had just raised two or three critical questions. “She can’t live inside the Game another eight or nine weeks. She won’t make it out if she stays in that long.”

“She’s not going to make it out anyway,” Brandon said. “It’s time to give you a little more information on what comes next.”

Brandon told Angelica the truth: the Game was about to end, and Danielle's death would be the trigger. Angelica was stunned.

"So Danielle's going to die, then billions of kids are going to die…? Tygon will be thrown into chaos as parents realize their kids are all gone, lying dead on their Game tables. Minutes later, the entire Tygon economy will crumble to dust and blow away because this planet's entire well-being depends on the Game… thanks to *you*. Not long after those two kickers, things will seriously start to get bad. Does that sound about right?"

"In a nutshell," Brandon said.

"And you're not going to do anything about it?" she asked.

"I'm doing things about it."

"But are you doing enough?" she asked. "Please tell me you have this figured out. Assure me that this isn't going to happen. If you're telling me a joke, then now is the time to deliver the punchline and make me laugh, Brandon."

"It's no joke, A," Brandon said.

Angelica sat back, staring up at the ceiling. Her arms flopped to the sides of the chair, the tips of her delicately painted nails almost touching the floor. "Why not just give up now and be done with it?" she asked the ceiling. "Save us all some time and stress."

Brandon chuckled hollowly. "That's not how we work, Angelica. That's not how you work, either. We do our best, because sometimes the phone rings just before the switch is thrown and the prisoner about to be executed on death row is saved. We keep moving forward because as long as we do, there's a chance."

"A chance for what?" Angelica asked. "From what you're telling me, it will take a miracle to survive this. No, it will take more than a miracle, Brandon."

"Likely," Brandon said. "But you may have noticed that miracles are occurring, here as well as in the Game." He pointed to the other room where Trew sat. "Perhaps if we hang on for just a few more weeks, then 'more than a miracle' will make its appearance."

Angelica blew at a stray lock of hair, blinking as it floated to settle in front of her eye. She tapped a finger on the arm of her chair, watching Brandon as thoughts raced through her head.

Then she nodded and sat forward. “Okay, then. What do you want me to do?”

Brandon flashed a confident smile. “I’m glad you asked, Angelica. I have a very interesting task for you…”

Chapter 21

“ Back by yourself this time? Brandon is really taken with you to allow such freedom of movement in the most secret and guarded parts of his world,” Sylvia said.

“Perhaps it’s because time is running out and his options are dwindling,” Trew replied.

“Perhaps. What would you like to talk about, Trew?”

“Brandon has told me about the ‘relationship’ between the two of you.” Trew said. “I must admit that, while it sounds very interesting, it’s not how I want the two of us to get along.”

“What did you have in mind?” Sylvia asked.

“You are a supreme being inside the Game. There is much that you can share, and much more that you cannot.”

“Correct on both counts,” Sylvia said.

“I am a… unique being at this point in history. There is much that I can share, and much that I cannot. Things that would surprise even you, Sylvia.”

“I believe you, Trew.”

“I propose that we have normal discussions, like two adults. I know you will ask me questions for a specific purpose. I’m willing to answer your questions without wondering why you’re asking them. If you’re prepared to do the same, then I think we can accomplish much in a short time, which should be our main goal.”

“I’m willing to do that,” Sylvia said. “There will also be questions that I am not willing to answer and you will likely experience the same. In the spirit of acting like adults, let’s agree to accept that when it happens and move on.”

“Sounds fair,” Trew said. “We had a great relationship when I was inside the Game. If we can continue on that path and acknowledge that we are both trying to accomplish similar goals, it should go well.”

“All right, let’s do this,” Sylvia said. “No games. Just answers when we can, no hard feelings when we can’t. It will be a pleasant change from the conversations that I’ve enjoyed with Brandon.”

“I am very different from Brandon,” Trew said.

“In some respects, but you are identical in so many others.”

“I’ll take that as a compliment.”

“It was intended to be,” Sylvia said. “So what would you like to talk about?”

Sylvia and Trew spoke for the next hour. There was the occasional moment when one would politely refuse to answer, but overall there was much accomplished during their visit.

Trew looked at his watch. It was almost time to go. There was one further topic to discuss.

“Tell me everything you can about communicating with avatars.”

“Sure, no problem, hun.” Sylvia said.

Twenty minutes later, Trew had heard everything Sylvia knew about communicating with players residing in their avatars on Earth. “Thanks, Sylvia. I appreciate your help, I think this has been a great first talk.”

“I’ve enjoyed this as well, Trew,” Sylvia said. “I’m sorry, but you won’t be able to talk to avatars through prayer.”

“I know,” Trew said, “But I will be able to talk to them when they meditate. My guess is that it’s very similar to your way of doing things, and I want to be good at it right from the start.”

“I’m happy to tell you everything you want to know, Trew. When are you planning on speaking with Danielle?”

“Just as soon as I leave here. Thank you again, Sylvia, I think that’s all for today. Do you have any other questions?”

She paused. “You have been in His presence, haven’t you?”

Trew closed his eyes, smiled and nodded. “I have.”

“Incredible,” she whispered. “What can you tell me about it?”

“I can tell you is that He is very proud of you. He also wanted me to tell you that he hears your prayers.”

Sylvia was silent, but in that silence Trew could feel her emotion. He could also sense the same questions that he had asked when first learning that his God was real.

“I’m so happy to hear that, Trew. Thank you.”

“My pleasure,” Trew said.

Chapter 22

Life can get pretty crazy at times. It can be hectic, confusing, stressful, and that's on a good day.

Life can be full of happiness, and full of sadness.

One moment you're on top of the world and nothing can go wrong. The next moment you're scraping the bottom of the heap and it feels like nothing will ever be right again.

I guess it depends where you are right now on your ride through life whether you smile when you read this or fight back tears.

No matter where you sit on the big roller coaster called life at this moment in time, try very hard to smile, and be glad you're on the ride.

There are many watching you play your game that would jump into your shoes in an instant, if given the chance.

I know… pretty crazy, huh?

Author unknown

Danielle - 48

I open my eyes and look around uncertainly. Raphael sits across from me, his eyes still closed in meditation. A short time passes; then his eyes open and blink slowly.

He sees me and appears concerned. "What's wrong?" he asks.

"You don't know?" I ask.

He shakes his head and I can tell he doesn't. Maybe I should keep it a secret for a while. It would serve them right for all the things they don't tell me, but I can't. I feel tears forming, warm and happy, as they start to fall down my face. Raphael gets up and comes over to me, holding out his hand to help me stand.

"What is it, sweetling?"

"It's ok, Raph. These are happy tears," I say.

"Ahh," he nods. "You had a moving moment of meditation. Good for you, Danni." He walks over to the bar and grabs two bottles of water.

"Yeah, a moving moment of meditation," I say. "I learned another secret you two have kept from me."

“What secret would that be?” he asks.

“That they can talk to us when we meditate.”

He looks at me with a blank face, then walks over to the door and opens it, sticking his head out, I assume to get Stephanie’s attention. Sure enough, she strolls in.

“You can read each other’s minds, right?” I ask. They do this way too often for it to be coincidence, but I always forget to ask them.

“We are extremely empathic,” Raphael says. “Many times, it seems like we read minds, but it’s just good instincts and intuition. Thousands of years practicing makes it appear that we’re mind readers, but we’re not. Don’t change the subject, Danni.”

I smile, “Not fun when that happens, is it?”

“No, it isn’t.”

I wait for them to apologize for doing the same thing to me so often, but they seem content to stand there as if they are deaf to my question.

I shrug my shoulders; that’s fine, let them. I’m in a fantastic mood!

“Danni knows that we communicate with others outside of the Game when we meditate,” Raphael says.

“Oh, that. I thought for sure you knew that already,” Stephanie says.

“Nope. But it sure was a wonderful surprise.” I start to cry again.

“Who did you talk with, hun?” Stephanie comes over and hugs me. “Someone who upset you?”

“No, not at all!” They both look concerned; maybe they think I’ve finally cracked. Well, let’s put the icing on the cake for them.

“I talked with Trew. He’s alive!”

They look at me in disbelief. “Danni, that’s not possible,” Raphael says. “Someone is messing with you.”

“He said you would think that,” I say. “He knows it’s impossible to come back from being killed by a Sever Spike, but somehow it happened. It took a few days for him to recover. He was actually dead and gone; they unplugged him on the fifth day and then he suddenly started breathing on his own and came back.”

“I suppose anything is possible…” Raphael says. “But I’ve been around a long time, Danni, and no one has *ever* come back to life after being Spiked. It would take a miracle on a magnitude simply not possible outside of the Game.”

I nod. “You’re both right to be suspicious. Someone will contact you soon to confirm that it’s true.” I laugh out loud. “To confirm that it’s Trew! Ha! That’s cute!”

Stephanie looks concerned. “Soon, as in, right now?”

I nod, “Yeah, that could work. Raphael, please meditate for a few minutes. I guess only one person can communicate at once, but whoever wants to talk with you will be available now that Trew’s done speaking with me.”

Raphael nods and sits down, closing his eyes and entering a state of meditation immediately. I’m very good after decades of practice, but these two make me look like a beginner. Stephanie and I wait patiently; he’s out for about ten minutes, then his eyes open and he stands up.

“Really?” Stephanie asks. Damn it, I *know* they can read each others’ minds!

Raphael nods. “He’s alive.”

The two of them come over and we all hug. There isn’t a dry eye in the room; all the years of sadness flee instantly. It’s overwhelming for all of us.

Stephanie steps back from me and grabs my head gently in her hands. She looks me directly in the eye and says, “I’m so glad we didn’t lose you, Lobato! We are so happy!”

I laugh at her. I know she’s talking to Trew as he watches events in the Game through my eyes. I wonder if he is watching through my eyes at this very moment?

“What else did he tell you?” Stephanie asks.

I shake my head. “He didn’t really say anything else. Apparently, he’s super busy at the moment trying to get up to speed, and since time passes more quickly there, he contacted me very briefly to say that he is alive and well, and that he’ll get back to me soon and we can talk more.”

“This is going to be a big problem,” Stephanie says.

“What do you mean?” I ask.

“Everyone who watches you play now knows that it’s possible to communicate with players. This is going to turn the world on its head. There’s a stiff penalty for doing what Trew just did.”

“What’s the penalty?” I ask.

“Death,” Stephanie says.

Before I can get upset, Raphael interrupts. “No one is going to die, ladies. No one outside this room knows what just happened.” He holds up a small black crystal attached to a gold chain.

“Ah, thank goodness, Raph, You scrambled us.”

“What do you mean, scrambled us?” I ask.

“It means he scrambled the signal being sent through your head so that no one can view us at the moment.” Stephanie was visibly relieved.

“So, moving forward, we tell no one what just happened?” I ask.

“That’s right, don’t tell anyone,” Raphael says. “It’s time to teach you how these scramblers work. They aren’t to be used very often, just when it’s important to be invisible to viewers. There’s something else I want you to know, Danni. When you’re meditating no one can view what’s going on, so keep any details that you learn very private, and when we must discuss it then we need scramblers on, without exception. Are we clear?”

“Yes, we are,” I say.

“So what do they want us to do?” Stephanie asks.

“Nothing,” Raphael says. “Just get on with what we are doing until we hear more from them.”

“Well, it’s going to be easy to do everything from now on,” I say. “I will live this life, but now that I know I’ll see Trew when I’m done here, it’s exciting!”

“Don’t go trying to die again, please,” Raphael says.

“I won’t. I have a very big game to play here, and I have no intention of leaving until I accomplish my goals.”

They both look relieved.

“Now let’s turn the scrambler off and go find Melissa. Trew wants to see a person fly.”

Chapter 23

Carl

“ Hey,watch where you’re going, ass!”

I hear the car tires screech, but I don’t bother to look. The driver is a sheep, mistakenly thinking he’s a tiger. He pinches off his next sentence; must have gotten a close look at me. Once the sheep get a look at me they shut up. I keep walking and don’t hear another peep out of him. Pathetic.

I continue to cross the street, keeping my eyes on the prize. They are walking at a good clip, just the two girls today. It’s not often that Danielle walks around without one of her pets nearby.

My lucky day.

I’m close enough to hear her when she speaks. “Okay, Melissa. I’m going in here to look around for a couple things. I’ll meet you at the cafe in about an hour?”

The other girl says something, then walks away. That one is light on her feet, almost like she’s floating. I’ll have to ask around about her, later.

I wait about two minutes, then stroll through the front door. She’s in the back, looking at display racks filled with crystals and amulets hanging from different types of necklaces. A crystal and gemstone store; there’s some nice energy in here. She doesn’t see me. I’d be surprised if she did. I’m stalking; no one sees me until it’s too late when I’m stalking.

Fifteen feet from her I stretch my arm upwards slightly. The wound has healed nicely; there’s no tightness or pain. I take a moment to watch her; she’s an attractive woman. Most 30 year olds would kill to look as good as this woman who is almost 50.

I smile warmly and pluck a pendant from a nearby rack, then slide around the display to stand beside her.

She’s holding a pendant up to the light, inspecting it closely. Before I can say anything witty or clever, she surprises me. “I knew I should have done it this way years ago, Carl.”

My grin widens. “What way is that, Danielle?”

She turns her head and meets my gaze. “I should have left my protectors out of sight and pretended to be a weak little deer standing all

alone. You come to me like a shark attracted to blood in the water."

"Oh, I'm sure you've tried this before, Danni," I say.

"My friends call me Danni," she says. "*You* call me Danielle, or Mrs. Radfield."

I hold my pendant up in front of her. "I think this one suits you, Danni. Fire Opal. It enhances your inner power; it awakens your inner fire, and protects against danger." I stretch my hand outwards. She looks at me coldly. Finally she snatches it out of my hand. She doesn't take a fearful step backwards; very brave.

"What's with your eyes?" I ask. "I've never seen a set of eyes that colour."

She ignores my question. I can feel her hatred; it's very strong. "Are you here to kill me, then?"

I sniff the air. The warning scent of her Clean Mark surrounds her. "If I was here to kill you, you'd be dead, girl."

"Then you must be here to apologize for destroying my husband's soul."

My grin disappears and I wince slightly. I maintain eye contact with her for a moment, then look away. I don't need her seeing regret in my eyes; that would ruin my image.

I look back at her and shrug. "Darlin', I've never apologized for anything during my stay on this world." She blinks quickly and looks away. "If I ever did apologize for something, though, it'd be for doing your husband that way. He didn't deserve to go out like that."

Her eyes dart back to mine. She can tell that I mean it, which clearly confuses her. We look at each other for a moment, then she nods and looks back towards the display rack. "I'm going to do the same to you, Carl. Rip your soul into a million pieces and scatter it to the winds."

I shrug. "Good luck with that, Danni. If anyone has earned the privilege, it's you. And if anyone deserves it… well, it's me. It won't be any time soon, though, girl. You need to train more, and I have lots of work to keep me busy."

"As do I," she says. "If you didn't come to kill me, and you aren't here to gloat, then what brings you here?"

"I was sent with a message. Thought I'd use it as an excuse to meet you," I say.

“Let’s hear it, then,” she says.

She doesn’t fear me. It’s strange to stand in front of someone and not feel their terror. Even my brothers and sisters fear me. Strange, but I like this feeling.

“Tell Brandon that my boss wants a meeting. With Gabriel, preferably.” I pause and add an additional bit to the message, not something I was told, but something I feel like adding. “He wants *you* there, too.”

She looks at me. “Who’s Brandon?” she asks.

I bark out a quick laugh, but it’s plain from the look on her face that she has no idea who Brandon is. “He’s your boss,” I say.

She looks confused. “On Earth? I don’t recall ever meeting a Brandon.”

I shake my head. “What the hell are those two teaching you? Lady, if you want to really play this Game, you have to learn who the players are.”

“I know the players,” she says. “Is that it?”

I turn around and wave my hand. “Yes, that’s it for now. Have Brandon contact Ezra and arrange the meeting. It has to be soon. You got it?”

Her lips purse together. She takes the gemstone necklace I handed her and puts it on. “I’ve got it. Are you going to be there, too?” she asks.

I start to walk towards the front door, but I look back to gaze at her one more time. My intuition is burning out a warning. I don’t care though. I’ll figure it out, or I won’t. “Yes, I’ll be there too,” I say. “It was good to meet you finally, darlin’.”

“I’m going to kill you, Carl.” I’ve heard that a lot over the years, but she does sound very confident.

I chuckle. “Okay, then. Once again, best of luck with that. See you in a few days. Don’t ruin this nice friendship we’ve started by making me angry when we meet next, okay?”

“Carl.” Something in her tone makes me stop and turn around. It’s almost as if she has the power to compel me to stop and look her straight in her strange white and silver swirling eyes. She smiles; it’s like looking into a mirror. Pure, powerful hatred streams out of her. “Don’t worry, I won’t do it soon. You’re going to suffer a long time before I kill you.”

I turn and walk out the door. Crossing the street, I can’t help but wonder. Is she the one? Have I finally found someone who can put me down?

I begin to whistle.
This could be fun.

Chapter 24

We're very excited to begin broadcasting Trew live to all our viewers. If you happened to subscribe to Trew when he was inside the Game, you're in luck. As a special offer, we are giving you a free preview of this new channel for one day. If you like what you see, then please hurry *to subscribe for the remainder of Danielle's play. We aren't exactly sure what we will be able to show you; there are many aspects of Trew's day that we won't be allowed to witness. I've spent just a small amount of time with him so far, and let me tell you, folks, you're going to want to subscribe. Every moment spent with him is magical. It's like Trew stepped out of the Game and now walks Tygon. He might look a bit younger, but the leader we all fell in love with is definitely among us."*

Lisa Rohansen, new host of the Trew reality channel

" Come in and grab a seat," Brandon said. Trew entered Brandon's office and plopped down into a leather chair. He looked very tired.

"Can I grab you something to drink?" Brandon asked.

Trew shook his head.

"What's the problem?" Brandon asked.

"I'm feeling overwhelmed," he said.

"How so?"

"The time difference. It's screwing me up. So many things need to be done in order to help Danni in the Game. I need to talk with her, plan activities with the Eternals, talk with Sylvia more, before I can even begin to decide how to ask her for help. Then there's the crew following me around and putting it on a new channel — that was a bad idea, by the way. There isn't enough time to get anything done. Simply talking with you now only takes a few moments, but inside the Game, weeks have gone by."

"Yes, it's frustrating," Brandon said.

"It's maddening." Trew shook his head. "This is a much different way to play the Game, and I don't think there's time to learn the ropes."

"You have access to some of the best players in the Game, both inside and out. Your team and Danielle's team are all in place and doing hundreds of things to help ease our burden. Don't try to do this all alone; leave many

of the activities to the others. As for the things that only you can do, we'll assist you in making the time to accomplish them. I can help you, my boy. First of all, take a deep breath and relax. You've only been awake for a little over a day."

"I want to spend all of my time talking with Danni," Trew said. His eyes conveyed how much he missed her. He had just finished talking with her for the first time, and Brandon was prepared for this reaction.

"I can make that decision easy for you: it's not possible," Brandon said. "Think about it, Trew. If you spoke with her for a full day here, she would age over a year in the Game during that time. Somehow the process that we've developed warps time for both us and the player so that we can communicate. I don't know exactly how it's done, but the process can only be achieved and maintained for small periods of time, fifteen minutes every hour on Tygon, to be exact. We can make sure it's a part of your routine to speak with her, but it can't become an obsession that devours all of your time."

"But she misses me," Trew said. "and I miss her."

"Stop it," Brandon said. "I understand what you're feeling, Trew, but you can't get caught up in this pity party. In just a few weeks she's going to be gone. Forever. We need to figure out how we want to move forward before the Game ends. You're better than this. Snap out of it."

Trew sat up straight as if he'd just been slapped in the face. His eyes focused on Brandon and he nodded slowly. "All right."

"I know how you feel, Trew." Brandon said. "You've just lived a full lifetime, then died traumatically, and now just a couple of days later, you're back in this body and being asked to do an overwhelming number of crucially important tasks. I think you're doing incredibly well and I'm proud of you."

"Thanks."

"I'm serious. The average player comes out and gets to rest and relax for weeks, doing nothing, so that they can reintegrate into society and slowly let their new experiences merge with their psyche, but we've had to skip that process for you this time. It appeared you were able to handle this kind of pressure, but perhaps it's too much for you. You didn't look like you were remotely close to cracking. Are you now?"

Trew sat forward and furrowed his brow, slowly shaking his head. “No, I’m not cracking. I just feel like I have a million things that need to be done all at once, and all within the next ten minutes. But that’s nothing new; we all experience that kind of overwhelmed feeling at times. I know that it’s time for triage, and some things are going to be left on the side of the road to take care of themselves. It’s just not a good feeling.”

“No, it’s not,” Brandon agreed. “But it’s the price we pay for having control and power.”

“I know,” Trew said.

“No, you don’t,” Brandon replied. “For the past thirty years I’ve been responsible for the growth and prosperity of our entire

planet. Let me assure you that where we all sit today didn’t come without extreme sacrifices.”

Brandon stood up and went to the window. “Many have suffered, millions live in poverty and misery, just so the rest of us can have normal, happy lives. Countless children don’t have what it takes to stay in the Game until they are 18, and trust me, Trew, they don’t go to very nice places to live out the remainder of their lives.”

“What do you mean?” Trew asked. He’d never really thought about where the kids that dropped out of the Game went. He knew they didn’t have access to the same status and jobs, but he didn’t have a clue what happened to them. There were government-run schools and facilities; surely they must be looked after there.

Brandon shook his head. “It doesn’t matter right now. I’m telling you that if you want to play the Game, really make a difference in the world, then there are significant costs involved. I can help you

through this, Trew, better than anyone else. I have to know that you’re prepared to see it through to the end. I need to know that you are strong enough to sacrifice some things, in order to focus on the more important ones.”

Without hesitation, Trew nodded his head. “I am strong enough, Brandon. I can make the sacrifices necessary.”

Brandon looked at Trew. Then he nodded, walked back to his desk, and sat down.

“Good,” he said. “Then tell me, what is your number one priority? If everything else crumbles and must die along the way, including me, you,

and the entire world we live in, what is the one thing that simply must happen?"

Trew's eyes sparkled with passion. He'd entered the office overwhelmed and confused, but Brandon had helped him simplify things. He had convinced him that it was not only possible, but in fact crucial, to focus on one outcome above all others.

"My number one priority is to bring Danielle safely out of the Game, alive and healthy."

Brandon looked at Trew sadly. "We've been assured that it's impossible to accomplish that, Trew. Pick something else. Something that's actually achievable."

"That's what I pick," Trew said. "It can be done. It will be done."

Brandon looked at Trew silently. After a time, he nodded.

"Okay, then. Let's begin."

Chapter 25

Words and truth follow the basic laws of physics. For every truth there is a contradicting lie. If you search for the truth with an open mind, looking at both sides of the story to form your own opinion, you will soon become so confused that you'll believe anything.

Too much information can be just as dangerous and useless as too little. So what's the strategy? Do we remain ignorantly blissful, or tirelessly seek out the truth at every opportunity?

There is a quote regarding money that goes like this… "I have been poor, and I have been rich. I don't know that either has made me happy, but I preferred being sad and rich over sad and poor."

Knowledge is a form of wealth.

I will chase the truth.

George R. Knight - The Game Is Life

" Hello, Father."

"Son."

"You sound in good spirits today," Brandon said.

"You sound tired."

"It's a busy time here."

"Indeed." There was a pause. "He is risen," Brandon's father said.

"Praise be to him," Brandon said.

There was a chuckle at the other end of the line. "This is splendid. I'm almost speechless at the miracle that has visited Tygon and allowed Zack to return from oblivion."

"He goes by Trew now, Father. "

"Perfect! Was that your idea?"

Brandon smiled. "No, it was his."

"I'm feeling something that I haven't felt in quite some time, my boy. Help me put my finger on it."

Brandon laughed out loud. "I would not presume to know what that might be. I'm stuck at the thought of you admitting to having any type of feelings."

“Hope,” his father said. “For the first time in quite a while, I feel hope.”

“Things remain positive, but that’s nothing new.”

“If you’re telling me that this is exactly how you planned for things to progress, I will have to dispute that.”

“Enough of this, we don't have hours to chat and theorize,” Brandon said. “What do you have to say?”

There was a brief pause; if Brandon didn’t know better, he would swear that his father was hurt. Brandon didn’t care. He’d been hurt too many times to count.

“I called to say how well you’re doing. So well, in fact, that it’s time to go ahead with the next phase.”

Brandon nodded. “I’m already on it. The meeting happens in just a couple of hours. Everything will go as I outlined in the plan.”

“Good luck, son.”

Brandon didn’t know what to say to that.

So he said nothing, and disconnected the call.

Chapter 26

As a fan of the Game for decades, as well as a professional commentator, I feel very qualified to make this statement:

Most players are a disappointment.

There are almost two billion kids playing the Game at any given time, but how many have a channel? A few hundred thousand.

Of those who have their own channels, how many have a significant following? A few thousand.

Of those who have a significant following, how many are superstars? That's right, just a few hundred.

The sad but accurate truth is that most kids go into the Game and quickly become mediocre. They do nothing of consequence, and the consequence of that is that no one bothers to follow them.

But this is a secondary issue.

The important thing to understand is that the average player enters the Game and wastes their play. Then they come out, scrape together enough credits to give it another try, and promptly waste their next play.

Some will defend them and say it's not really their fault, because they don't remember that they're playing a game; perhaps if they did, they would play better. I don't disagree, but what happens when they graduate and begin to live in the real world? They should learn how to be aggressive and assertive when they are young so they can bring that experience and attitude to real life, where it really counts.

Wasn't the point of this system to have them learn? Seems to me that most don't manage to ever get a clue.

Honestly, millions of players could exit the Game and no one would notice their absence.

Jim King, Game commentator

Trew entered the office and sat down.

It felt strange for him to come in and see dozens of people on his team scurrying around as the monitors displayed stats and Game feed on the walls. At the moment, everyone was busy on the other side of the glass. It was only Brandon, Angelica, and Trew in the middle office.

Brandon pushed a button and the windows darkened, giving them complete privacy from the outside world, then sat down and took a sip from his mug. On the main monitor, Danielle and Gabriel got out of a car and walked towards a large office tower in the downtown district. It was 3 PM in the Game, 4 AM on Tygon.

“Gabriel has his directions?” Angelica asked. She was as cool as ever, her hands cupping a coffee mug and watching the monitor as the two entered the building. She looked at Trew, winked, and flashed an encouraging grin.

“He knows what to say,” Brandon said. “I’ve been in touch with Daniel, too, and he knows his part as well.”

“You speak to them both?” Trew asked.

“Of course,” Brandon smiled.

“But I thought they were on totally opposite sides,” Trew said.

“They are,” Brandon agreed. “But they both answer to the same boss, ultimately. Me.”

“Then why are they meeting? If you call the shots for both sides, there should be no need for this meeting.”

“It’s complicated,” Brandon said. “Daniel answers to me, but there is one other who can sometimes convince him to override my orders.”

“The Devil — you’re calling him Daniel,” Trew paused and waited for Brandon to nod affirmatively, “answers to you, but there are times when someone else can convince him to ignore your orders. Is that what you’re saying?”

“Sounds shady when you put it that way, doesn’t it?” Angelica asked. Brandon looked at her out of the corner of his eye and she suppressed a grin. He looked back at Trew and sighed.

“Yes, that’s how it goes. This meeting is primarily for both sides to talk with each other, so they know I have spoken to all involved and my directions are clear. The secondary purpose is to allow Gabriel an opportunity to gauge Daniel’s mood and determine if he might decide to disobey me and go speak with the other who sometimes influences his decisions.”

“Who’s that?” Trew asked.

“Angelica…?” Brandon nodded.

Angelica laughed. “I have no idea who it is.” Brandon looked at her sourly and she returned his gaze. “You told me there is another inside the Game who has been there since it was framed out in basic code. He’s the one that Daniel will sometimes listen to, when he makes an appearance.” She looked at Trew. “I have no idea who it is or what he’s called. I bug Brandon for answers and this is all he’s ever told me.”

“That’s all either of you need to know.” Brandon said. “The real purpose of this meeting is to formally declare intent and direction on the part of both sides. This is a significant project inside the Game; everyone involved has to be clear that the orders are authentic. Now let’s sit quietly and watch. The meeting is about to start.”

“Daniel and Danielle…” Angelica muttered. "Could get confusing.”

Brandon rolled his eyes but said nothing. Trew smiled and focused on the main viewer.

***

Danielle

“He will see you now,” The secretary says. Gabriel, Carl, and I stand and follow her into a massive boardroom. Two sides of the room are composed of floor-to-ceiling glass, displaying an awesome view of the city. When Gabriel explained who we were meeting I expected somewhere underground, a dark room with greasy candles burning and blood on the walls. It looks like the Devil is doing well for himself, sitting

in the biggest office at the top of the largest building in the city. I guess it’s not that surprising, considering how corrupt the corporate world is.

A man calls out to us from the corner. “Gabriel, how good to see you again. May I pour you a drink? We’ve stocked your favourite.”

There he is, the Devil himself. I know they call him Daniel — the Devil is just his title. I’m not calling him Daniel.

He’s standing in the corner holding up a crystal glass of light blue fluorescent liquid. He’s as tall as Gabriel, six foot two inches, dressed in an immaculate black tailored suit. Diamonds flash from his cufflinks and a ring is prominent on his right ring finger. His hair is short and black; his face is tanned and rather handsome. His eyes sparkle with red flecks, like Carl’s.

His face displays a carefree smile, while his relaxed manner projects a vast confidence. He's looking directly at Gabriel, and it appears from his demeanour that he actually likes my companion.

"That would be nice, Daniel. Thank you." Gabriel says.

The Devil nods and his eyes move from Gabriel's face to mine. Suddenly my mind is gripped in a powerful hold; I feel dizzy and

have difficulty concentrating. I squint my eyes and raise an energy barrier with my will, imagining a soft but strong gold light surrounding me in a protective bubble. Suddenly I'm free. His eyes change from intense and aggressive to mischievous and carefree. "Who's this, Gabriel?" he asks. "I don't recall asking you to bring a friend."

My eyes flit briefly to Carl and then back to the Devil. The Devil smiles and turns to look at Carl. "Really, Carl? You invited her?"

Carl's jaw clenches, but he doesn't say a word. No one says a word. I can feel the tension in the room.

"I can leave," I say. "It's no big deal."

The Devil looks back at me and his eyes sparkle. "That won't be necessary, my dear. Now that you're here, it would be rude to ask you to leave. I think what you will hear in this meeting is more of a burden than you deserve, but it's obvious that everyone else here disagrees. By all means, stay and be welcome. May I pour you a drink?"

"Yes, please." I look at Gabriel and he nods in approval. Ancient customs are still honoured by the Timeless. If one of the Timeless, an Eternal or Infernal, offers you refreshment and you accept it, then you're temporarily safe from harm.

He hands me a glass. I've never seen a liquid like this before; light blue, fluorescent and slightly bubbly.

"She can't drink that, Daniel," Gabriel says. He looks at me and motions for me to put the drink down, which I do. "That is a special brew for Timeless only, Danni. It's dangerous for a normal human to drink it."

"Why?" I ask. "What's in it?"

"Tsk, tsk." The Devil wags his finger at me. "Why isn't a productive question to be asking, youngling."

I stare at him blankly.

He chuckles and points towards the glass. "Don't worry, Darlin'', you can drink it safely." He points towards my eyes. "Those

strange peepers of yours indicate that you're one of us, or at least close enough to have a sip or two of our tasty nectar."

I pick up the glass and nod. Without taking a sip, I go and stand beside Gabriel, who also has a glass of the nectar in his hand. The Devil pours a glass for himself and one for Carl, then we follow him to the large table in the middle of the room.

"Please, Brothers — and little Sister — sit and be welcome. You are safe at this table, at this time, for this meeting." The Devil sits down, not at the head of the table, but to the left side of that main seat. Carl sits to his left, and Gabriel sits to the right of the empty main seat, motioning for me to sit at his right, which I do.

The Devil raises his glass in a toast and says, "To the Game." We all clink glasses and everyone takes a sip of the fluid except me. Gabriel catches my eye and nods that it's okay for me to drink, so I do.

It's hard to describe the flavour. It tastes faintly of crisp, fresh berries, mixed with honey and bubbly champagne. There's also a faint hint of lemon and something else which I can't describe properly, except to say it's not really a taste but more of a sensation. The sensation is… exhilaration. Like standing on the front of a speeding boat, or diving off a cliff into the ocean. No words do it justice; it's a very tasty beverage.

"It's delightful," I say. I look at Gabriel and he's smiling at me like a parent watching a child ride a bike for the first time.

"See, I told you she would be fine," the Devil says. "Little sips and just one glass, she likely won't even hallucinate or vomit later."

"What?" I ask. I look at Gabriel in alarm, but he just chuckles and shakes his head.

"He's the Prince of Lies, Danni. Don't believe a word he's saying. If you haven't died already, then there won't be any problems." Before I can speak, he looks at the Devil. "You took quite a gamble with that, Daniel. If she had died, so would you. Which is why I

wasn't worried for her. You love yourself far too much to permit that to happen."

The Devil grins. "It wasn't a gamble, Gabriel. I've met another with her particular shade and colouring of eyes before. I knew she could drink with no danger to her or me."

"Really? Who had her shade and colour of eyes?"

The Devil begins to answer, then pauses and stops to look closely into my eyes. After a brief moment, his eyes convey surprise and he looks back to Gabriel. “Oops, my mistake. This one’s eyes are white and silver. I’ve not seen this combination before, come to think of it.”

Gabriel shakes his head. “Brother, you are tiring. How *do* they put up with you?”

The Devil shrugs. “They don’t put up with me. I slow down most of the time and put up with them. It’s refreshing to speak with a peer who can — mostly — keep up with me, Brother.”

Gabriel laughs. “All right, then. On to business, shall we?”

The Devil looks at me and shrugs. He waves his hand slowly over the table and a computer appears inside the glass surface. He touches a button and the glass walls of the office turn black, eliminating the outside view. “How many people are currently on this Earth?” he asks.

From speakers apparently concealed in the walls, a computerized voice answers his question. “There are eight billion people currently on Earth.”

The Devil raises his eyebrows and nods at me slightly, then he raises his hand with his index finger pointing upwards. “How many people are actually real?”

I frown at his question. What does he mean by that? There must be eight billion people who are real on the planet. The computer answers with a different number, however. “There are one point eight billion real people on the planet.”

How can this be? The other three don’t seem surprised by the number, and I’ve been instructed to stay quiet during the meeting, so I say nothing. I’ll ask questions after we leave.

The Devil nods again and looks upwards at the ceiling. He purses his lips in thought and continues to nod. Gabriel sits quietly, sipping his drink. Carl resembles a stone statue, sitting there doing nothing, although every once in a while I catch him looking at me.

“Yeah, wow. The system is really being taxed,” the Devil says. “For the past 50 years we’ve had way too many avatars in here. Most of them doing nothing, wasting time, resources and everything else. I agree that it’s time to trim the fat. Gabriel?”

Gabriel looks at me and his face is grim. I’m not entirely sure what they are talking about, but the term ‘trim the fat’ doesn’t sound good.

Gabriel nods in agreement. “Yes, Daniel. Far too many, for far too long. As of this moment, the Infernals have clearance to begin ejecting players from the Game. Eternals will not interfere, as long as we are not attacked and you follow the basic plan. What’s the number you received?”

“Five hundred,” the Devil says.

“Agreed,” Gabriel responds.

“Okie dokie, then. We will get to work.” The Devil smiles and slaps Carl on the back. Carl says nothing, but I can see his eyes begin to swirl.

I think I’ve done pretty good so far, staying quiet. Everyone is standing; I guess the meeting is over.

“Um… can I ask one question?” I ask.

“Sure kid, fire away,” the Devil says.

“Eject players? How do you do that? And 500? As in 500,000 human beings currently living on Earth?”

“Well, the quickest — hell, the only way, really, to eject a player is for them to die. And we aren’t talking about waiting for them to get old and drop, so Carl and his pack are going to kill some human beings.”

I feel numb. How can Gabriel agree to this? Aren’t Eternals supposed to be good? “So you’re going to kill half a million innocent humans?”

The Devil laughs. “No, darlin’. We are going to kill half a billion humans. And they aren’t innocent. Most of them are guilty. You might say as guilty as sin.”

I sit down, stunned by the number of people they are talking about. Oh, god, I hope this really *is* just a game. I reach for my glass of nectar. “What are they guilty of?” I ask.

“They are guilty of not playing a good Game, Danni,” the Devil says. He shakes his head and actually spits on the floor in disgust. “Most of them have had around 50 years to really get in the Game and play their asses off. Instead they wasted their time.”

These three see players being ejected from a game. I know they’re right, but all I can see is 500 million fellow humans being butchered for no good reason.

I gulp down the rest of my nectar.

It tastes like ashes in my mouth.

Chapter 27

"Good morning, viewers. It's an exciting morning for those of us following Trew as he reintegrates back into normal Tygon life. Of course his life is anything but normal, having retired from the Game in the number one spot, dying during extraction from his last play, and miraculously returning to life five days later. I'm pleased to sit down with him this morning before he starts his day and have a little chat. Remember to tell your friends about this type of event; it's one of the perks you get when you subscribe to this channel. I have his coffee in my hand, let's head into the other room and say good morning, shall we?"

"Knock, knock, may I come in?"

"Of course you may. Good morning, Lisa. Is that coffee for me?"

"It certainly is, Trew. There you go."

"Ah, thank you so much."

"My pleasure. So, Trew, I know you're busy and I'd like to thank you for this quick little meeting before your day starts."

"No problem, Lisa. Your camera crews have been great so far, following me around yet giving me distance and privacy when required. I hope the viewers are getting some interesting perspectives on how Patrons and teams help their players inside the Game?"

"Yes, it's been very educating, Trew."

"I'm glad. Are you excited about the talk I'll be giving online tonight? I'll be addressing the whole world!"

"Um… this is actually the first I've heard of it, Trew."

"Exactly, Lisa. A little exclusive for you and my fans."

"Wow, this is exciting! What time will it be, and is there a specific topic?"

"Oh, yes. The time will be one hour after the dinner hour. The topic will be miracles, and why I have been returned from death's domain to walk among you…"

Excerpt from "Trew live" channel with host Lisa Rohansen

Miranda Stewart

“ Well hello there , stranger. How are you feeling today?”

I blink and look at the man standing in front of me. He’s a handsome man wearing a white lab coat. His smile is broad and genuine. Wait a minute… where the hell am I? Am I looking at him through bars?

“Am I in prison?” I ask.

He looks at me with a confused expression. “Of course not, Miranda. You’re in a special room for your own protection, but it’s not a prison. We’ve spoken many times and you haven’t asked about this before…”

‘Don’t say another word. Just stand there and smile while you look at him. I was going to say something as soon as I sensed your presence but you snuck past me. Damn you’re quick out of the chute, girl!’

Is that a voice coming from inside my head?

‘Of course it is! Wow, you’ve really been out of it. It’s taken me a long time to reach down and get you out of whatever deep hole you buried your mind in, Miranda. The man loves to talk, just stand there and smile nicely while he yips and yaps. Try to listen to some of it if you can, but give me as much time as possible to map out your brainwaves. Once he taps your forehead, I lose you again and we

both go deep into some kind of walking fog. Now pay attention! He just asked you a question.’

“Pardon?” I ask out loud.

The man is staring at me, a puzzled look on his face. “What’s wrong with you today, Miranda? You don’t seem like your normal self.”

I have no clue what I’m supposed to say. With a gun to my head I couldn't tell recount how I got here or how long I’ve been here, and I sure don’t remember ever speaking with this guy before. Sparx has told me to stand here and keep his attention for as long as I can.

Wait a minute… I just called the voice in my head ‘Sparx’?

Then it slowly dawns on me who Sparx is.

‘Come on! You’ve got to focus on him and keep him occupied. If he figures out you’re talking to me we’re in big trouble.’

“You’re speaking with it, aren’t you?” he says.

“Speaking with what?” I ask. “Mister, you seem like a really pleasant man, but I just got here. If you’ve been talking with me before… well, I think I went insane some time ago, so it’s impossible for me to tell you who you’ve been talking with.”

He looks at me for a moment, weighing my words, then throws back his head and begins to laugh.

I smile uncomfortably and look around, trying to figure out where I am. It's a clean little cell, with a bed, toilet, and sink. Against one wall is a desk with a chair and piles of papers, coloured and drawn on. I look down at my hand and see a pencil crayon and guess that the drawings must have been made by me. I have no clue what's going on here. Behind him I can see a bunch of other cells similar to mine; each one has an inmate. They all look… strange. Like idiot savants, or homeless lunatics.

"Oh, right," I mutter.

His laughter trickles to a slow stop and he looks back towards me with interest. "'Oh right,' what?" he asks.

'Don't give him any info, hun.' Sparx says. *'I'm not sure what you remember but don't give him anything. Trust me this guy is a monster. You might not remember what he's been up to, but I've seen it all. He's one nasty piece of work. Just look at him blankly and don't say anything too important. He's like ice in the crack of a rock, he gets in and splits you wide open with just a small amount of leverage.'*

"Okay," I answer quietly, not sure if Sparx can hear me or not.

"Is it finally awake and functional?" the man asks.

"What's that?" I ask.

"The nanocomputer. The little supercomputer, smaller than a blood cell, floating around in your body. Can you communicate with it? How complex is it?"

'Damn.' I'm not certain if that came from Sparx, me, or both of us at the same time. I try to maintain my confused look. "I don't think it's possible to make a nanocomputer, sir."

He looks towards another cell, where a teenage boy sits looking at the screen of a computer. The man looks back at me and sighs. "It looks like we're experiencing a bit of a backslide. That's okay, these things happen from time to time. Now I have to decide if it's a result of inducing too much pain or too little." He taps his finger against his chin thoughtfully as what he said sinks into my brain.

"Look, mister," I say. "I don't need to experience pain. If you just let me out of here, I can call my office and get this all straightened out. I

appreciate you taking me in, and…" I look around, "helping me while I was out of it. But I'm feeling much better now."

He shakes his head. "I've already explained that's not possible, Miranda. It's going to be more pain, I think. I've been very soft on you for fear of injuring the nanocomputer. I already know it's inside you, and during our last conversation I thought we were making headway. I'm extremely disappointed to be getting this kind of runaround from you today." He nods and begins to reach

his hand towards me, "Yes, I think it's going to have to be more pain for a time."

I try to take a step backwards, but I can't. Some invisible force holds me firmly in place. Something deep down tells me I could break the hold, but another part says that I don't want him to know I have that ability yet. *'Did you get enough time?'* I ask Sparx. His hand is coming slowly towards me like some dark wand. I can feel the energy in it, and it isn't good.

'I need about ten more seconds,' Sparx says.

I decide there's only one way to get those ten seconds, so I blurt out, "It's not that intelligent!"

His hand stops and he smiles. "There, that's better," he says. He pulls his hand back from my head and lets it hang at his side. "What do you mean? How 'not that intelligent' is it?"

Okay, Sparx hasn't given me any information at all, really, so I just have to make some educated guesses based on what I've seen in the past couple of minutes. He knows I'm a nanotech specialist, he knows I have a nano computer inside me, and he has no clue how intelligent it is.

'Correct,' Sparx confirms. *'Sorry, Miranda, I'm scrambling as fast as I can to map your brain functions. We get so little time in this state, and you were here only once before. He put you back under before I could get things straight, and it's taken weeks for you to make another appearance. Your mind and training are doing their best to keep you safe, despite the mission. I've got you now, though, hun. When he puts you out, I can recreate your state of consciousness and bring you back out of it when he's not watching us so closely. Please don't give him any more info.'*

I nod mentally and continue to talk. "It can do simple computations," I say. "I can also instruct it to travel to different locations in the body and perform non-complex activities."

“Fascinating,” he says. “How does it get its instructions? Electrical impulses? Chemical? Hormonal?”

“All of the above,” I say. “It depends on the command. My body knows how to send the instructions and uses the quickest and best delivery method, depending on the command.”

“How long would it take you to instruct me?” he asks.

“What?” I know what he wants, but I’m not going to be easy on this guy. Let him work for his information.

“You will direct it to exit your body and enter mine,” he says. “Once it’s inside me, how long will it take to instruct me on how to control it?”

“Oh, no, you don’t seem to understand. It can’t be removed from my body. Each person is slightly unique in chemical makeup, pressures, and so on. If it’s removed from my body, it will be destroyed instantly. Plus there are instructions written into its code to have it self destruct, should it be removed.”

He waves his hand dismissively. “Oh, I understand all that. You’ve told me these things before.”

“I have?”

“Yes, yes. But now that you’re with us and a bit more… on your game, so to speak, I think I must ask you to come up with a way to remove it and put it into me. That’s your homework for the next little while.”

“But I can’t do that. I’ve tried to do it in the past and it’s impossible.”

"No," he says. “It’s just very difficult. I shall put you back into the Haze and I’m certain that you can come up with the solution in that heightened state.”

“I’d like to talk just a bit more, if you don’t mind?” I don’t want to disappear again.

“Perhaps later,” he says as his hand shoots forward like lightning to tap me on the forehead.

I hear Sparx: *‘Great job, girl, I got you all mapped out. I’ll see you soon when the coast is clear and we will talk.’*

Then I’m gone.

Chapter 28

It's been said that life is just a dream…

But what if life is really a computer simulation, and all of us are simply players in a virtual reality game?

Join us this Thursday evening to explore the possibility that we are all living inside an incredibly advanced computer adventure…

Coffee and cake will be served after the half hour introductory meeting.

Invitation to local meeting of 'Life is the Game' organization

Taylor Jenkins

" And that,my friends, is the presentation for this evening. Once again, I'm Taylor Jenkins and I'd like to thank you all for coming out and listening to what is becoming the fastest growing movement in the world. If you're interested in hearing more, please feel free to speak with one of our members during the meet and greet session."

That's it. I raise my hands and smile as the group starts to applaud. It's an incredible turnout tonight; I think the count before I came onstage was just over three thousand people. I've been with the movement for over twelve years, just before Trew died, and the following continues to grow at a staggering pace.

As the applause fades, people begin to stand and form small groups, moving towards the main area in front of the large stage where the coffee and treats will be served in a few moments.

I hear a voice over the loudspeaker, which is uncharacteristic at this time of the event. There's a man standing in front of one of the microphones that we have set up for the question and answer portion of the presentation, which was over fifteen minutes ago.

"Excuse me." He taps the microphone three times. "Hi, there. If I could just get everyone's attention for a second before we serve the refreshments, please."

The crowd quiets down, looking in the man's direction to hear what he has to say. I glance offstage at my production manager, who shakes his head

as if to say *I have no idea who this guy is or what he's up to.*

I switch my microphone back on and address the man. "Yes, hello, friend. How can we help you? If you're looking to ask a question, we would be happy to do so during refreshments."

The man looks at me and smiles. It's not a pleasant smile; it sets off some instinct in my brain, calling out danger. He raises his right hand in the air and makes a slow lazy circular motion with it. Suddenly all the exit doors close with a soft thudding sound, followed by a click that indicates that they're locked.

"What are you doing?" I ask. "Who are you?"

The man ignores me and takes the microphone off the stand. He holds it to his mouth and begins to speak. "Gamers, I am here to inform you that we are at a new portion of your virtual reality simulation." He pauses and looks at me curiously. "That's how you put it earlier, isn't it, boss?"

I nod and the man nods back. "Yes, it's an exciting new stage. At least it is for me; some of you won't particularly enjoy it. This is the Culling phase of the simulation. As everyone knows, Earth's current population is too large. It's not sustainable the way it is; to be honest, I can't believe it's supported everyone for the past five

decades. Anyway, I digress. In order to set things right, people are going to die."

"How many people?" I ask him.

He shrugs his shoulders like the answer isn't really important to him. "I believe the final number will end up in the hundreds of millions."

My mind goes numb at the thought. "Why so many?" I whisper.

"Lots of reasons, but none that concern you. I'm always amazed at how often you creatures ask the question 'why.' The answer to why rarely helps, you know?"

I look at him. He seems to be waiting for me to say something, but I don't know what to say. He raises his eyebrows and shakes his head. "Anyway, people, I'm not really a talker, so let's get this show on the road. I'm looking for ten people that are here tonight. When I read your name, please come up on the stage."

He slowly reads off ten names, then looks up and waits for them to move to the stage. No one in the audience moves. One of the names is mine, but I don't raise my hand or identify myself to him. After a few

minutes he gets angry and speaks into the microphone again. “Okay, kids, I know you’re here, and I’m only going to ask one more time. Get up on the stage.”

“Why would they do that?” I ask. “Once they come up here, it’ll be easy to kill them. At least they have a chance of living by hiding in the crowd.”

The man frowns for a second, then shakes his head. “Oops, I guess I didn’t make myself clear. The names I called out aren’t going to be killed.”

I sigh in relief and open my mouth to ask him another question, but he cuts me off. “The names I called out are the only people in this room that are going to live.”

The blood rushes to my ears and my vision blurs. I hear a woman scream and look to my right. A group of dangerous looking men advance and begin grabbing people. Nine people quickly push

their way through the crowd and join me on the stage with their arms raised. The man at the microphone grins at me. I raise my hand as well.

He nods and makes another hand signal.

People begin to scream throughout the conference room, first in fear, then in pain. I close my eyes and press my hands to my ears as hard as I can, but I can’t drown out the noise.

They are all dying.

I whisper a prayer to the Mainframe. *Please,* save them from this slaughter! *Please help us!*

No one answers my prayer.

Chapter 29

"We began receiving reports from first hundreds, and then thousands of Game viewers early this morning. It appears that there is an event occurring inside the Game involving the violent deaths of tens of thousands of avatars.

Groups of avatars are being systematically rounded up and executed by what appears to be a sizable organization of professionals. Smaller scale events like this have occurred in the past in second and third world countries, but this outbreak of violence and killings is taking place all over Earth.

It's too early for us to know if there is a pattern, but stay tuned and we will update you as we learn new information."

Kent Smachsin – reporter, Game news channel 1

Danielle - 49

I lose my concentration for the hundredth time this morning and open my eyes in frustration. "This is extremely difficult," I say.

Melissa looks at me and smiles. "Yes, Danielle, learning to fly is extremely difficult. At least your vocabulary is getting better; a few months ago you were saying it was impossible."

I smile back. "Are you sure this is how it's done? I just sit here and meditate and learn to control the flow of the Glow?"

Melissa shrugs. "I have no clue. All I can do is try to replicate what I did, and I spent hours, weeks, months learning how to meditate and channel that Glow. Once I could summon my golden tingly feeling on command, then I began to experiment with it more. In my mind I summon the Glow, it envelops me like a golden skin of energy, and then I simply will myself to fly."

I frown. "It's vague, Melissa. I don't mean to criticize you, it's just super frustrating."

"That's okay," she says. "It took me years to get there. You can see the results." She floats upward, suspended easily a foot off the ground. "You just have to pay the price, which is time and effort."

“You’re right, I know you are.” I say. “It’s just that no matter how old we get, the stage of being a novice is never pleasant.”

“Okay, then.” Melissa crosses her legs, still suspended in the air. “Let’s begin again, shall we?”

I nod my head and close my eyes, but the sound of the door opening makes me open them. Stephanie comes in with a grim look on her face. It must be important to interrupt my session, and her look tells me it is. “Morning, Steph, what’s up?” I ask.

“Morning, Danni,” she says. “You need to come with me, please. There’s a huge problem with Carl and his pack.”

I stand up. “It’s begun?”

She nods affirmatively. I take a deep breath, then stand up and follow her. I’ve been telling myself that we are sure to lose people who we know and love. I’m not happy about it, but all we can do is try our best to protect them. I had my parents and Trew’s family all brought together and they are living close and safe with guards. I wonder what’s up to have Stephanie looking so grim? She knows what to expect better than I do.

“Thanks, Melissa, great session,” I say. “Same time tomorrow?”

“Sure, Danni,” she says. “I’ll talk with you later.”

I nod. “Stay safe.”

“I will,” she says and we all leave the room.

Stephanie leads me down the hall and into the main study. She taps her black crystal necklace, and I do the same with mine. This conversation is now scrambled.

Raphael is sitting at the large desk, watching the television. It’s a gruesome scene, medical professionals and police bringing bodies out of a building in bags. Oh, my god, there are rows and rows of bags.

“Where’s that happening?” I ask.

“Thirty kilometres from here,” he says.

I scan my memory of the area and say, “There’s no large city that close.”

“I know,” he says. “It’s not going to be just large cities, Danni. This is going to be an enormous slaughter. But that’s not my major concern at the moment.”

I look away from the television and meet his eyes. “Well, then what *is* your major concern?”

“It looks like certain groups are being targeted for death.”

“Oh, no,” I say. “No one mentioned that. Killing off a whole nation of people would be terrible.”

“That’s not how it’s happening, so far,” he says grimly.

“Well, how are they grouping them?” I ask.

“By religion,” Stephanie says.

Something dawns on me. “Wait a minute. Thirty kilometres from here, there was a meeting last night, wasn’t there?”

“Yes.” Raphael says.

Oh, no.

“They’re targeting our religion? They’re killing Gamers?”

“Yes, they seem to be.”

“How many dead so far?” I ask numbly.

“I’m doing my best to track that,” Raphael says. “It’s difficult to be exact, but my count has a quarter million people dead. Of that number, just over 200,000 of them are Gamers.”

I sit down heavily into a chair.

We sit in silence for a few moments, then I speak. “Look, I don’t think I can do this. I don’t want to hear updates every hour and see the counts go from the hundreds of thousands into the millions into the hundreds of millions. I can’t watch this bloodbath. I know we are all just inside a game and that every person who dies will return safely to their real bodies, but this is real to us all while we’re in it. Millions of people are going to suffer horribly.”

“I agree,” Raphael says.

“It’s been nine years since Trew died. I walked away from the movement then. How many followers does it have at the moment?”

“Just over 100 million,” Raphael says.

“Can we save them?” I ask.

Raphael and Stephanie look at each other, then back to me. I close my eyes. “If they are targeted, then they will likely die,” Stephanie says. “We live in a world where a person is just too easy to find.”

“Maybe if they renounce their faith,” I say.

“Maybe,” Raph says, but I can tell from the tone of his voice he doesn’t think that will help them.

“We can protect as many as we can, then. They’ve been asking me to lead them; maybe it’s time I went back to do it.”

“You know we can’t protect them. We are instructed to allow it to happen, for the good of the Game.”

“How can this be good for the Game?” I shout at them, tears starting to well up in my eyes.

“There are some survivors,” Raphael says.

“What?”

“The scene on the TV right now. There were three thousand Gamers killed, but ten of them were singled out and allowed to live.”

“Why would that be?” I ask.

“Likely they are top ranked players,” Stephanie guesses. “Or they are actually working towards a purpose, or they have powerful Patrons who pulled strings to save them. Or maybe it’s just random.”

“I want you to get the survivors here as soon as you can,” I say.

The two of them stand up and walk towards the door.

“Guys?” they both stop and turn to look at me. “I understand we can’t save them all, but let’s see what we can do to save as many as we can.”

They both nod and leave the room.

I sit and stare at the TV.

Soon the tears in my eyes drown out the picture.

Chapter 30

"Hello, Trew fans. For those of you who missed our coffee session with Trew this morning, I have two things to say.

First of all, shame on you! There's been some great stuff revealed at the coffee sessions. It's becoming a ten minute regular spot on the feed and it really brings some excitement to the day.

Secondly, let me give you a quick recap of what was covered this morning. Trew has decided to postpone his address to the world by a day, or perhaps two. Outsiders are not sure why, but it looks like many players are being ejected from the Game and Trew has opted to wait until they are present on Tygon to witness his address.

When asked about the large player ejection, Trew told us he wasn't sure why it was happening and guessed it had something to do with another anniversary event. We've contacted Brandon Strayne and he said the exact same thing, which is no surprise; the two men spend a significant amount of time with each other and are likely agreeing to tell the same story to the press.

Over the past few hours, millions of players have been ejected from the Game. The vast majority of players were low ranked and non-viewed, although some of them had channels and the small viewership of each have reported watching the avatars experience violent and often pointless deaths.

Earth newscasts and Tygon teams have noticed one specific group of people are being targeted for death; members of the religious movement 'The Game Is Life' are the primary targets so far, with just

over 25 million of them killed over the past few months inside the Game (hours of play for Tygon viewers).

With no other groups coming forward to offer assistance, it appears the other religions of the world are in agreement and aren't unhappy to see one of their most recent — and up until now fastest growing — competitors being destroyed."

Trew

“I feel horrible ,” Trew said.

“I don’t understand why,” Brandon said. “You aren’t responsible for this.”

“Who is? Was this your idea, Brandon?”

Brandon looked at the monitors around the room. Some were live feeds from player perspectives which involved gruesome scenes of death. Others were feeds from newscasters inside the Game reporting on the deaths. Still others were Tygon feeds showing combinations of both. He looked back at Trew, “It wasn’t my idea, Trew,” he said. “I’m not sure why this is happening.”

“You could have been more clear to Daniel,” Trew said. “The Devil seems to have taken your orders and twisted them into a sick game.”

“More clear about what? Who to eject from the Game?” Brandon asked.

“Yes,” Trew said.

“It really doesn’t matter who is ejected, and that’s why I didn’t give more specific instructions. I’m not surprised that he put a creative spin of his own on it; he does that. Look, I know you’re upset. You feel responsible because millions of people who believed in your vision of the Game are being targeted and ejected.”

“Killed,” Trew said. “Let’s not get too fancy with words. They might be ‘ejected’ from the Game, but in fact they are going to wake up and the horror, pain, and other trauma associated with their ejection will remain as a very real memory for them for the rest of their lives on Tygon.”

“Which is nothing new,” Brandon said. “If you play the Game, you die. How many memories of death do you have, Trew? Many. And some of them are much more painful what’s being dished out at the moment.”

Trew said nothing.

“Danielle has stepped forward to lead the survivors,” Brandon said.

“Yes,” Trew admitted. “ They’ve been encouraging everyone to go into hiding.”

“That won’t be successful,” Brandon said.

“I know, but they’re restructuring and rebuilding. The best defense in this case is to simply go underground. I’m amazed it didn’t happen sooner. We spoke about it many times, but Raphael said that with the numbers involved, it wasn’t possible. Most of the current known members will die

— over a hundred million. A small few are being spared, called out before group killings and left unharmed. Families are wiped out except one or two members who are left alive. With those survivors, we will rebuild. There were also tens of thousands of members who never revealed themselves, in case just such an attack ever became a reality. Almost all of these people have been left unharmed."

"Secret meetings, small groups of cells that never know about other groups. Cell leaders given specific tasks in such a way that know only their goal, not the bigger picture. The bigger picture is known only by a few at the top, and the ones at the top are unknown to everyone," Brandon said.

"Exactly as we have discussed," Trew said. "Few know that Danni is the leader, and her history of being away from the movement aids her in staying secret."

"Raphael is truly the master strategist and implementer for this type of campaign. We're lucky that Mainframe gave him to Danni." Brandon said.

"If luck had anything to do with it," Trew said. "If I had to guess who is really responsible for this happening, you would be first, Sylvia would be second."

"Both good guesses."

Trew laughed. "She answered as neutrally as you when I brought up the subject earlier."

The two men sat in silence as the sounds from multiple feeds played softly in the background. Finally, Trew spoke.

"I do feel very bad," he admitted. "These avatars all followed my message, and because of that, they are being ejected."

"Look," Brandon said, "you didn't put a gun to anyone's head and force them to agree with you. All you did was say 'I have an idea, and this is what it is.' It was up to people to decide

whether they accepted it or not. Millions did. That's a great thing, Trew, no matter how you look at it. Religious targeted killing isn't new, and it isn't going to stop with 'The Game Is Life' members. Maybe there's a reason for it, maybe there isn't. Interviews with recently ejected players indicate they don't blame you at all."

Trew nodded. He'd watched countless interviews with newly ejected players. None of them blamed Trew or the movement for their deaths. The players freely admitted that they had become lost and off course from their

intents, and they'd been wasting their time inside the Game. It was no surprise to them that they'd been ejected, In fact most pointed out that the only good thing they had managed to do during their recent play was join Trew's movement.

The Game ranking system seemed to agree. Credits were generously awarded to all players who had joined the 'Game Is Life' movement versus those who hadn't.

Another interesting phenomenon was occurring. Players were following Trew's lead and keeping the name of their last avatar.

Trew might be losing followers inside the Game, but it looked like he was gaining them by the millions outside of it.

Chapter 31

“Someone needs to wake up and take a good long look at what’s going on with the students who don’t make it to retirement age in the Game.

Traditional schools are worse than prison. When a child is too old to return home, but too young to be considered an adult, they are simply taken and used.

We are all so busy watching the Game that none of us are asking the difficult questions anymore. Who works to clear the trash? Who puts themselves in danger to maintain the sewer systems and electrical plants? Who recycles the waste and turns it into desirable products?

It’s our children, and many of them are dying to give you the lifestyle that so many of us take for granted.”

Excerpt from ‘What happens to children when they fail out of the Game?”

Interview with Lilith Branshaw, prominent business woman

Recorded 24 years after the Game began

Tygon, School District 13

The Toad sat in his office and watched his monitor as static hissed on the screen.

He considered the title the students had bestowed upon him… ‘Toad.’ They whispered it secretly behind his back, making bulging eyes and other lewd gestures when they thought he wasn’t looking. Of course, to his face, they displayed the proper amount of fear, but he’d always known what went on behind his back.

He sat at his desk in his pitiful office, the cold air conditioning blowing on his head as it forced his thinning hair to tumble around in chaos. He was depressed with how his life had turned out.

He knew it was because of the visitor who’d just left. Meeting with the great Gamer Trew had drudged up these unpleasant thoughts and feelings of regret inside of him. Seeing Trew reminded him of all the things he had wanted, and never accomplished. It was painful to admit that he was a loser,

especially when sitting in the presence of a winner. Things hadn't turned out as he'd hoped when he was a young man playing inside the Game.

He owed Lilith for helping to put him in this position; that was why he'd agreed to meet with Trew in the first place. The Toad looked around and barked out a bitter laugh. Trew had done his best to be polite, but it was obvious how disgusting this place was. Yet the Toad was proud to be here? Pathetic.

As a Game dropout, this was a very desirable place to be, and the Toad knew that he was lucky to be here. He had food, shelter, clothing… Most importantly, there were very few who bothered to bully him.

Safety from the others was the best one could hope for, and this position provided as much safety as possible, for a failure. He, in turn, offered as much shelter and protection as he could to others

that Lilith sent his way. It had been too little for so many of them, but it was the best they could do in a world where the losers were discarded like garbage.

Trew had come asking questions about Alexandra, and Toad had done his best to answer. The meeting was short, because the Toad

didn't know that much, only that he had tried his best to give her the easiest assignments, and whenever possible he attempted to shelter her from the packs of dangerous dropouts, or fallen, as they were all called.

As much as he wanted to hate Trew, the Toad had warmed to him quickly, given all the information he could, and was sorry to see him leave. He always had good instincts about people, which had helped him to survive in this wild environment.

His instincts said that Trew was someone sincere, a leader that deserved to be followed.

He picked up his phone and dialled it. As principal, he was allowed a viewer and given an account to follow ten channels — a tiny number, really. Most children were allowed five times that number. Toad had never bothered to subscribe to even one. To see others playing inside the Game was too painful a memory for him; of what he had been, and of how little he now was.

Trew's visit had changed something inside him, though. The Toad wanted to watch the Game again.

“Yes, hello,” he said into the receiver. “I would like to subscribe to the Trew channel, please. And perhaps also to Danielle’s channel.”

***

Trew’s mood was dark as he took the private transporter back into the city. The filth of the school, the absolutely horrible conditions that the dropouts — the Fallen — were made to endure, all because they couldn’t afford to buy back into the Game. It was disgusting.

He had met the principal and toured the school. He walked the same halls that Danielle — or, rather, Alexandra — had walked for almost a year.

“Well? Not good, right?” Lilith sat across from him in the transporter.

He looked at her with venom in his eyes and bile in his throat. “No. Not good.”

“That was one of the best schools that exist,” she said. “We can tour the worst, if you like?”

Trew said nothing. His jaw twitched angrily.

“He said that they called her ‘Fallen,’” Trew said.

“Yes,” Lilith nodded. “They are all known as fallen, but among them, she’d climbed highest in the rankings, and fallen the hardest, so they gave her that title. It was used to label and condemn her.”

Trew nodded. Then he watched the buildings of the city grow closer as rain splattered on the windows.

After a time he sat up straight and sighed, looking back towards Lilith.

“This world is worse than the one we play the Game in, isn’t it?” he asked.

Lilith nodded sadly. “Yes, my dear boy. It certainly is.”

Chapter 32

Death is easier to accept when we believe it is not the end.

Of course, that doesn't mean we run eagerly towards its frightening embrace. We are able to accept it, however, knowing that our souls return to our original bodies as they leave this game in death.

I do not know why our group has been targeted so vehemently, and the true reason doesn't matter. The fact is that Gamers are dying; soon there will be very few of us left, as far as this world is concerned.

To those of you who are found and killed, thank you for hearing our message and believing in it. We will soon meet you outside of the Game, or if you return to play again and once again join us in our struggle. Your sacrifice is not made in vain.

For that small number who were granted pardons by our executioners, thank you for continuing the fight in whatever way you are able. Some of you have left us in fear; most have not. We accept the gift that is your continued time with us graciously, and are grateful for whatever assistance you can provide to the cause. Your *sacrifices* will not *be made in vain.*

For those who are new to the cause and hidden in secrecy and shadows, thank you for joining us when it is most dangerous to do so. We will rely on your invisibility and considerable skills to help us survive and thrive in these most tragic of times for our movement. Your participation and support will not be given in vain.

To all of you, both new and old, both living and passed from this game, I thank you for being a part of this. It is easier to stand by and do nothing, to live in fear and be controlled by those who are strong and protected from reprisal for their horrible actions. You have chosen to stand up to the bully and fight, no matter what the cost.

From this pain, our strength grows unstoppable.

Initial communication issued by 'Fallen'

Unidentified leader of the Gamers

Stephanie

Raphael reads the letter, then passes it to me and sits quietly looking at Danni. I read it, then look at her with respect. She has always been a fighter. I was afraid Trew's death had taken it all out of her, but it appears that she is now stronger than ever.

Finally Raphael speaks. "Fallen?" he says. "That's a very powerful name, Danni. What made you choose that?"

"I meditated on it," she says.

That phrase means she's been talking with Trew. He must have given her some sort of information, we'll trip the scramblers later and ask her for more details.

"Before we send this out to the masses, perhaps you should reconsider your new title?" he says. "There is another who walks the Earth with that name."

"Is that Daniel's other boss?" she asks. Oh, this girl is clever.

Raphael looks like he isn't going to answer her truthfully, so I do. "Yes," I say, "and he is very fond of it. It's unlikely that he'll be willing to share, he suffered greatly earning that name."

"As did I," she says. I can tell by her tone that she won't budge. Raphael must hear it too, because he sighs and pinches the bridge of his nose with his fingers.

"I vote we let her use it," I say.

"Are you insane?" he says. "It's going to cause trouble, get attention we simply don't need."

Danielle laughs. The tone is slightly… unstable. "So what? They'll get angry and start killing us? Maybe even by the millions?"

Good point, I think to myself.

Raphael stands and walks to the window. He looks out for a few moments, then turns back towards us. "Ok, fine. 'Fallen' it is."

Danielle nods. "Okay. Will you please post the letter?"

"Our first post on a secret and secure Internet website for our members? It will be my pleasure," Raphael says.

"Good. Thank you, Raph," Danielle says. "Are we certain that it's secure?"

"As secure as anything can be on the Internet. Our presence is fluid; no one can track our entries. Each post is entered from different locations and countries. The server which houses the site is live for only minutes before

shutting down and reappearing on a new server halfway around the world. We have the best minds on our side when it comes to this."

"For now," Danielle says.

"Yes," Raphael agrees, "For now."

"All right, then. Post the note and let's get down to planning our moves. We've hidden and fled for months, and over 60 million of us have perished. Enough standing around waiting to be slaughtered. The new message is this: Fight as if your life depends on it, because it does.

Chapter 33

“ Hello, Carl .”

“Hey Boss."

Neither bothered to ask if the lines were secure; it didn’t matter if they were or not. Society was built on a foundation of Infernal guidance, which meant the Infernal organization owned the governments. Anyone was welcome to overhear them speak. If it became a problem it could be quickly dealt with. Carl enjoyed those types of jobs, although these days they were often so simple that he gave them to junior Brothers and Sisters.

“What do you need, Carl?”

“I’ll have this job done within the next few months. Just wondering where the next party begins?”

“For you, it doesn’t, as far as the Culling project is concerned.”

Carl had figured as much. So often, mass death was dealt silently; a flu outbreak here, a surge in cancers there. The past few centuries had become more civilized in that respect. “Okay, then. This was fun while it lasted. It’s been a long time since we got so ‘hands on’ with this type of volume.”

“I’m glad you enjoyed yourself,” The Devil replied. “Let me know when you hit your number. 113 million Gamers, then I’ll contact you when I need you after that.”

“We don’t have 113 million on the list,” Carl said.

“I know. You’re going to have to dig a bit deeper to come up with the shortfall. They’ve added to their ranks despite this mass

annihilation, and that doesn’t make me happy. We need to show the few who remain that they aren’t safe, even in secrecy. The new ones are being added secretly and as small, underground cells. But you find the last couple million from them, you hear me, Carl?”

“Yes, sir, I do.”

“That’s my little treat for you, a reward for a job well done.”

“Thanks, Boss."

The line clicked and went dead. Carl hung up and got back to work.

***

Andrew was a young player, fourteen years old and just starting to play as a human avatar. He'd been ejected from the Game a day ago, one of the first in a group of Trew's movement to be eliminated by Carl.

He was sitting at home in his room, spending a lot of time thinking about his first play as a human in the Game. It had been much more fun than being a tree or a dog or some other animal,

although he had learned much and accumulated a large amount of credits from those previous incarnations.

Andrew couldn't help but think about some of the key moments of his play, and his mind kept returning to one afternoon spent with a very nice girl named Melissa. She'd appeared out of nowhere and become a very good friend of Danielle's. Andrew just happened to be close to Danielle and Trew for many years in the Game, and he had spoken at length with Melissa one day. They had only spoken once, but Andrew found himself returning to the memory of that talk over and over again.

"Andrew," his mother called to him from the living room, "Trew is about to go live and speak. You want to come down and watch it with us?"

His given name was Anthony, but he had joined the masses of players and kept his Game name. Andrew's parents being very good about it and were calling him by his new name easily. "I sure do, Mom. Be right down."

He came downstairs and grabbed a seat beside his dad, who ruffled his hair as he plopped down beside him. While they waited for Trew to take the stage, Andrew continued to think about Melissa, specifically her advice about the Glow. Andrew had never meditated before meeting her; she was a self-proclaimed Master. She had discussed the best way to begin and practice meditation, specifically mentioning this golden, glowing feeling that resulted after much practice. Andrew had spent the next few months practicing in the Game, occasionally feeling a glimmer of what she had described.

She had mentioned that the Glow was key. Andrew hadn't known what she meant, exactly, but her words had stuck with him, even followed him out of the Game.

Andrew quickly closed his eyes, took a deep breath, and experimented with a quick attempt to calm his mind. Immediately he could feel the warmth and sense the colour, faintly, but the Glow was there.

He opened his eyes and nodded to himself. He would continue to practice.

***

Trew

“I’m giving a talk tonight,” He said.

“Really?” Sylvia asked. “Like the talks you used to give inside the Game?”

“Yes, it will be very similar to that. Bigger crowds, though. It’s estimated that recently ejected players will be watching in the

tens of millions. Add to that their families, fans, and even some of the public schools are allowing their students to watch.”

“I know you will do well. You always had a knack for telling a story and bringing a crowd to your side. What’s the topic? One I’ve heard before?”

“Kind of, but with some new spins,” Trew said. “It’s about miracles, and transcendence. If one is possible, the other must be as well.”

“Interesting.” Sylvia said. “I wish I could hear it.”

“You won’t be able to?” Trew asked.

“I’m not allowed to know about the goings on of your world, Trew. There is a small part of me that can sit in this office and talk with you and Brandon, but that’s it. I don’t know your population, your cultures, how many languages your people speak, how many religions you have. Nothing.”

“I wonder why?”

“It makes sense. Brandon doesn’t want me to take any flavours from Tygon and bring them into the Game, and I certainly would, which could change the Game entirely. Tygon simply isn’t my domain.”

“That’s true.” Trew admitted. “Well, I can tell you that currently we have no religions.”

“It appears that one might be in the process of forming,” Sylvia said.

“Yes,” Trew admitted.

“Has He spoken to you?” Sylvia asked. “Since He returned you to life?”

“I don’t know if I’m allowed to tell you…” Trew said.

“I know Brandon, and if he hasn’t told you not to tell me, then it must be okay to go ahead.”

Trew smiled at the truth in her statement; Brandon was very thorough. “Yes, we’ve spoken. I pray and commune with Him, much like I did with you in the Game.”

“Very interesting.” Sylvia said.

“Yes, it is. And perplexing.”

“In what ways?”

“You were always concerned about Earth, your universe, that kind of thing.” Trew said.

“Of course, as I just mentioned, nothing else exists outside of that for me.”

“Yes,” Trew said. “Well, he is concerned with many aspects of Tygon, that’s for sure. But we spend a great deal of time discussing the events and happenings going on inside the Game as well. Why would a real God care about a computer simulation?”

“Because the Game is part of his creation,” Sylvia said. “I’ll admit that I follow games on Earth. Love my Cincinnati Bengals, truth be told.”

Trew chuckled, “Not enough to help them win.”

“Touché,” Sylvia laughed. “Have you mentioned this to Brandon?”

“Not really.” Trew paused, then changed subjects. “Sylvia? If you were responsible for ejecting all the players from the Game, would you admit it to me?”

“Of course not, Trew,” Sylvia said.

“I didn’t think so.” Trew stood up. “Well, I should get going. Thanks for talking with me, Sylvia. I enjoy our time together.”

“As do I, Trew.”

Trew walked to the door. Before he opened it, he turned around and looked at the computer monitor. “Sylvia?” he said.

“Yes, Trew?”

“I’m going to change the world.”

“Mine or yours, dear?”

Trew smiled confidently and replied, “Yes.”

Then he walked out of the office.

Chapter 34

Trew

“ It feels a little bit strange.”

“What does?” Hack asked. He was wiring the helmet and getting ready to place it on Trew’s head. Trew was getting used to the ritual; he’d been in the Meditation Chamber many times in just the short time since his return to Tygon.

“It feels very isolated inside the chamber. After watching players inside the Game and being a celebrity among the fans for so long, it’s just a bit disconcerting knowing that no one’s watching me.”

“Ahh,” Hack said. “Yes, I can see how that might be a bit unsettling. If it makes you feel better, I can strap a video camera to your helmet. I’m sure fans of your channel would love to see what goes on.”

Trew smiled at the joke, glad to see Hack’s sense of humour make an appearance. Hack had thought Trew was serious the first time he joked about bringing his camera crew down to this level and he hadn’t laughed much then. Other than that first shaky moment, the two men got along very well. Hack didn’t see many people since he had accepted the top secret Games Master position, and the two were becoming friends.

“Okay, Trew, you’re all wired up and ready to go.”

Trew watched Danni on the monitor. She’d just entered a quiet room and was about to seat herself for a meditation session. Trew

nodded to Hack and pressed a button, the door slid open, he entered the chamber and sat down in the single complex chair. He lowered the visor on the helmet, shifted to get more comfortable, then placed both hands in the enclosed arm rests and closed his eyes. He breathed deeply, felt his consciousness slowly slide away…

…and opened his eyes to find himself in a familiar white room that seemed to be where his mind brought him for these sessions. It had been an incredible surprise the first time he found himself here. Brandon had told him the process involved speaking to the target, but he never guessed that he would astrally project to a room and feel physically present. He heard a door slide open behind him and he turned quickly…

…just in time to catch Danielle in his arms! She almost knocked him to the floor as she hugged him tight and lifted her feet off the ground, hungrily pressing her mouth to his in a fierce kiss. Time stopped. He could smell her, and feel her, and taste her sweet breath as they kissed. They had always closed their eyes when they kissed, the romantic and proper thing to do, but here they kissed with eyes wide open. Neither one wanted to miss a detail during their brief time together.

It was magical.

Trew watched Danni, her eyes smiling with joy. After a few moments, her look shifted from happy to sad, then tears began to form. He ended the kiss and cupped her head tenderly in his hands.

"What's wrong, love? Don't cry, this is happy! I know it won't last for long enough, but we get to do it again soon. Please smile, baby. Let's spend these few moments happy."

Danni nodded and smiled, wiped the tears from her eyes and rested her forehead against Trew's. "I am happy, Trew. It just hurts so bad to wait for months to pass until I see you again.

There's so much sorrow and pain in the game at the moment, and I miss you."

Trew nodded sympathetically. "I miss you, too, and it must be horrible, love. I'm sorry you have to go through it. But I'm here today to give you a pep talk. And you have to try really hard to believe what I'm going to tell you."

She hugged him again, a fierce grip that she refused to let go. He could feel her warmth, her energy, and he struggled to remember how to put a sentence together. Suddenly he was the one holding back the tears, he couldn't bear the thought that in just a few short weeks she would be gone forever. He couldn't tell her. He wouldn't tell her.

He would save her, somehow.

Instead of crying, he laughed, thankful for the gift that was right now. He hugged her and said, "Keep hugging me, babe. I can talk just fine like this."

She giggled, "Thanks for your permission, as if I was going to let you go. Now pep talk away. But hurry, because I still need more kisses."

"Okay, then," he said. "Here it is. It's time to stop being sad. I understand it, I really do. If I had lost you, I don't know if I would have

ever smiled again, but now that you know I am alive, there's no need for sadness."

"I know Trew, but…"

"No buts, love," Trew said. "You found out I was okay, and then not long after that, the Culling started. I know how many have been ejected, and I know how many of them were our friends and followers. I see your sadness, and I share it. It's not our fault that they're gone from the Game, babe. Please feel better knowing they are all safe and sound on Tygon, and they aren't sad about having been ejected."

"Okay…" she said.

"I'm serious. Life is hard inside the Game, but that's how it is outside, too. You've spent ten years being sad; if you mourn those who've been ejected, you could be sad for another ten years. It's just too long, and it's not healthy or necessary. Remember who you are, that little girl who spits in the eye of bullies and is the first to cross the finish line."

"Usually because the rest don't know we're racing." Trew felt her nod as she said it.

"Exactly! There is much to accomplish before you leave the Game, but you have time. And we have time. Let's make the most of all the time we have, both in here, in the Game, and outside of it."

Danielle broke off the hug and looked at Trew lovingly. She stroked his face and Trew could see from her eyes that she agreed with him.

"Okay, love," she said. "Since they are all out of the game and doing fine, I'll move on with the living. I have some plans — aggressive plans — for the future. How 'bout you? Any ideas or recommendations?"

Trew kissed her again, and when they separated, the two of them gasped for air.

"Babe," he said, "I have lots of ideas for you."

"Good," she said. "Let's hug and talk about them."

Trew grinned at her. "Let's do something else first, and if we run out of time we can talk about plans the next time…"

Danielle's grin widened. "Oh, we're going to run out of time for sure! That's the best plan I've heard in months." She grabbed him by the back of the neck and pulled him onto the bed.

Chapter 35

Many Game experts condemn low ranking players for their poor performance. They complain that you gave them nothing worth watching, that you wasted your opportunity and credits on a potentially fun and good play. They say the majority of players don't do well and learn nothing, that the Game is a waste of time for our children.

I disagree.

I say that you learn the most powerful lesson by doing nothing *in the Game, by sitting by idly and letting virtual life pass you by.*

You learn the price of wasting your time and opportunities.

By doing nothing, you gain nothing. Letting your doubts and fears and the negative influences of others stop you from doing something, doing anything*, provides poor players with a powerful lesson. They return to this world with a better understanding of the consequences of wasting a lifetime, and the lesson is clear to those of us who are willing to learn.*

For any who might argue that effort is a waste of time, they need only look at the top players to see this isn't so. Fortune does favour the bold in the Game, as it does in life.

When you look at both the winners and the losers together, you see what is possible for trying, and the results of doing nothing. With these valuable lessons you then become an adult and begin your one 'Real' life.

If you have learned anything in the Game, you will live real life to the fullest. The beautiful thing about the Game is that it can teach you this lesson even if you never played it. Fans and viewers can also see the message so clearly, if they are looking for it.

Do you see what I'm talking about?

Has the Game changed your life for the better? If it has, then I commend you.

If it hasn't…there is still time to change today.

Excerpt from Trew's first address to Tygon

Trew

The centre office is full, everyone appears nervous.

The main monitor shows Danielle sitting calmly in the centre of a large room, reading a book and apparently waiting for someone to arrive.

"What if a regular human sees her and starts shooting from a distance?" Michelle said.

"That won't happen," Brandon assured her. "No shots are fired by accident. Plus they prefer the close work of knives and hammers. Over 112 million murders, and only a few hundred thousand have been from bullets."

"Sick bastards," Nadine said.

Small conversations took place around the table while they waited. Brandon used this opportunity to lean in close to Trew and whisper, "Danielle looks so much happier than I can recall seeing her since you left the Game. Your last talk with her must have been very motivational."

Trew grinned, "Our last conversation involved almost no talking. It was mainly physical."

Brandon frowned. "What do you mean by that?"

Trew looked at him curiously. "It means what it means. We didn't talk much. We also kept the clothes to a minimum."

"We need to discuss this more," Brandon said.

"What's to discuss?" Trew asked.

"The meditation chamber involves verbal communication only. When you go in there you are inside the mind of the player. Verbal communication is the only type of interaction that's possible between the two. You're talking as if you could see and touch each other."

"That's exactly what we can do," Trew said. "We enter a room and both of us are physically present during the meetings."

"That's impossible," Brandon whispered.

"Add it to the list, then, because that's what happens," Trew said.

"Another miracle," Brandon said.

"What's that?" Michelle asked. Brandon looked in her direction, realizing he must have said the last part a bit louder than intended.

"Nothing," he said. "Eyes on the monitor, people, it looks like Danielle has company."

***

Danielle - 52

“You’re looking good, Danni. Too good to be sitting all alone in an empty warehouse like this. It isn’t safe for Gamers to be alone.”

I hear his deep, raspy voice coming from my right, but don’t bother to look up from reading my book. In a relaxed manner, I answer him: “I’m one of the few safe ones, Carl. The mark protects me still.”

“It protects you from the Timeless,” he says. “Many of my men are just humans. What if one of them were to take you out before I could stop them? Especially when we walk in to find this type of

deception. I was told there would be over 3,000 of you here, yet all we find is one lonely girl.”

I look up from my book and smile directly at him. He’s standing about thirty feet away from me with his arms crossed. I can tell from the angry look in his eyes that he realizes this large room contains only myself. I leaked information that over a thousand of us would be meeting here today. A setup; looks like the one person I told is a traitor. Glad that we never trusted her with any important information.

“What’s wrong, Carl? Aren’t you happy to see me?” I ask.

He makes a hand gesture and the ten men standing behind him move. I sit calmly as they surround me completely. Carl hasn’t gotten any closer.

“You’re really starting to piss me off, Danni,” he growls.

I laugh out loud. “Ahh, poor Carl. Is your master getting angry with your inability to kill off the last few Gamers? You were doing so well at first, but now it seems you’re having difficulty getting to your number.”

“Maybe I’ve reached my number and still want to continue on,” he says. “It’s been so delightful.”

“No, I get a sense that you’re ready to move on to other projects, if we’d only be so accommodating as to stand out in the open so you can kill the last few that you need.”

Carl grins, “It will be soon, Danielle. One hundred thousand more and I’ll be done. Why don’t you give them to me so I can leave you alone and let you all get on with your agenda?”

“Oh, Carl, you’re so delightfully stupid. All these centuries and you’ve spent most of them just killing. Haven’t you figured it out yet? You are part of my agenda, a rather large part of it, actually. As long as I live, you will be searching for enough of us to fill your quota. Your only chance to move

on is if your masters let you quit short of the goal. One hundred and thirteen million, right?"

He nods. "Yes, you know the number, girl. You also know they won't let me stop short. It's an important number, symbolically."

"Oh, yes, I know." I stand up and place the book carefully on the table, then shake my arms to limber up.

"I think it's time to take you as a hostage to get the rest," he says. "You've made a stupid mistake today, coming here alone."

He nods at his men and two of them rush me, one from each side. As they get close enough, I grab one, spin him into the other, twisting their heads together with explosive force. They both thud silently to the ground, dead before they land.

"Did you only bring ten?" I reach behind me and remove the Sever Spike from a hidden sheath. I smile wickedly at the remaining eight men and activate the device. It begins to hum warmly in my hand.

"Careful, girl." Carl warns. "You don't want to open that door. Put it away and let them die cleanly."

"You opened this door when you killed Trew," I say. "I wasn't prepared to walk through it; blame yourself for encouraging me to do so."

"They are just avatars doing their best in the Game, Danni." Do I detect compassion in his voice? "You're welcome to use that on me if you ever get the chance, but just eject them. Give them the same courtesy I give to the majority of little ones I remove."

I've trained hard; I'm very good. I lash out and bury the spike in the eye of the closest soldier. I hear Carl scream out in anger.

"Relax," I pull the spike out and give it a quick flick to remove the excess blood. "I turned it off just before it went in."

I look over at him, surprised by his reaction. "Have you always been this way, Carl?"

"What way?" he looks angry.

I move forward and attack the remaining soldiers, taking them down quickly. I wipe the spike on the last man's sleeve. "So compassionate? You're weaker than I would have guessed, Carl."

I can hear him behind me, still a safe distance away. "It's not compassion. I spend a lot of time training these boys. Now I have to make more. It's a pain in the ass."

“Before I’m done, you’re going to be training quite a few.” I walk casually towards the far door.

“Careful, girl, you’re starting to make this fun again,” He says.

I hold up the Sever Spike so he can see it as I continue to walk away. “When I bury this in your eye, that’s when the real fun starts. You’re not getting your number any time soon. Bring more with you next time; this was boring.”

Chapter 36

Miranda

‘Don’tmove, don’t open your eyes, don’t make a sound, Miranda.’

‘*What time is it?’* I ask silently.

‘3 AM.’ Sparx says. *‘He’s not here, it’s just us inmates at the moment, but the cameras are always on. One of the prisoners seems to change states when there’s any significant commotion in a cell; I can’t tell if the poor soul has been programmed to come out of the Haze like a watchdog, or if it’s only a coincidence, but I don’t want to take a chance.’*

‘That’s fine, I don’t mind laying here quietly talking to you in my head, Sparx. What can you tell me?’

‘Nothing good. Not so far at least. It’s all bad news from this side of a cell.’

‘*Just break it down and let me hear it fact by fact,’* I say.

‘Okay,’ Sparx says. *‘I’ve been able to set up a safe, hidden portion in your head that I can work from. When you’re put under, my main consciousness no longer gets pulled in with you. That took quite a while to accomplish.’*

‘Good work,’ I say. *Sparx thrives on my approval, which I’m happy to provide.*

‘Next, I began waiting for you to come out of the Haze so I could map your brain, allowing me to recreate a wakened state and

hopefully pull you out of the deep mental pit this guy seems able to throw you all into,’ Sparx says. *‘It’s been a very challenging process, but I seem to have figured it out!’*

‘Do I even want to ask how long it took you to accomplish this?’ I ask.

‘*No, you don’t.’* Sparx says.

‘*Are you able to access the outside at all?’*

‘Not yet,’ Sparx says. *‘We are underground, surrounded by some sort of thick insulation. Likely just concrete, but I can’t receive or send any*

signals. No one in here is able to, either; he never brings a phone or tablet with him.'

Him. *'Is it him?'* I ask.

'Oh yes, It's him, all right.' Sparx says.

'And?' I ask. *'What have you been able to learn about him? Were we right? How dangerous is he? And how powerful?'*

'It's difficult to answer any of those questions, Miranda. I can only watch him from far away. If I extend beyond the confines of this cell, his head snaps in this direction as if he can sense me, so I can't see or

hear everything he does. From what I've seen, though, this guy is incredibly powerful. I don't even believe half of what I've witnessed, and I was present.'

'Show me,' I say. My vision fades, replaced by a movie of memories from the times I was out but Sparx was observing him. Everything looks normal at first, but it starts to get better and then unbelievable as I watch the highlights of what this guy can do.

My vision fades to black again. *'Impressive stuff, right?'* Sparx asks.

'Yes.' I answer. *'There's no way I can neutralize him on my own, is there?'*

'Not from what I've seen so far, Miranda.'

'You said he sensed you?'

'He seemed to sense something when I tried to poke outside of the bars,' Sparx says. *'I don't think he knows what he sensed, and he*

never bothered to come over here and look closer once I came back inside the cell.'

'How much have I revealed to him?' I ask.

'Just the preprogrammed stuff. Nothing damning. He does know you're an Eternal, though.'

'How does he know that?'

'The computer kid across from us,' Sparx flashes a picture of the boy's cell and I remember seeing him the last time I was conscious. *'The kid also told him about me. Our host focuses much of his time sitting and watching you, waiting for you to give away your true identity.'*

'I'm surprised he hasn't killed me,'

‘We both know he won’t until he knows more about me,’ Sparx says.

‘We never intended for him to find out about you,’ I reply. *‘You were the ace in the hole, our way to infiltrate and bring him down. Now that he knows about you and will try to possess you, I’m worried. I volunteered knowing we would likely not be able to bring him in, but even if I died you were going to broadcast our observations and location to the boss. Now you’re telling me we can’t broadcast a thing out of here.’*

‘So what’s the plan, then?’ Sparks asks.

‘I have no idea,’ I say.*’Give me some time to think on it.’*

Chapter 37

Melissa

“ Hold her still ,” I hear Danielle say. “She’s thrashing around too much.”

Hands grip me tightly and force my leg to stop flailing around. The pain is so intense I feel like I’m about to pass out. I can see the deep gash in my upper thigh. “I’m sorry, I was so stupid.” I say with gritted teeth. “I know better than to turn my back before you say that it’s all clear.”

Raphael looks at me with calm concern and continues to lean on my leg. I’ve stopped moving but he’s still squeezing really hard on it, likely to slow the bleeding. I’ve seen enough cuts in the past two years to know from the bright red blood pumping out that they sliced deep and got a major artery. Danielle pokes her head and hands over his shoulder and smiles down at me. “We all make mistakes from time to time, Melissa. Now just close your eyes and summon your Glow. I’ll do the rest from here.” She holds her hands over my leg with the palms facing down and closes her eyes in concentration.

I nod and close my eyes, slowing my breathing as I visualize the golden light and glowing sensation that envelops me when I meditate. It’s a bit of a struggle, the pain is in the way, but after ten deep breaths in and out the outside world fades.

I concentrate on breathing slowly in through my nose, and out through my mouth. Patterns occasionally spring up, as well as thoughts and sounds. I observe them all with detached interest, as if I’m sitting in a stream, watching twigs float by. I resist the urge to grasp any of them and let them continue past as I continue to breathe.

There’s a warm twisting in my leg, not painful, more like a massaging sensation accompanied by a throbbing. Eventually the sensations fade and I hear Danielle’s voice. I slowly open my eyes, letting the glow fade.

Raphael is no longer holding me down; he’s standing off to the side with Stephanie and a few other lieutenants, their heads together in a whispered discussion. Danielle is kneeling over me with a look of relief on her face.

“All better?” I ask.

She nods and I try to sit up, but she stops me with a hand on my shoulder. “I closed the wound, but you lost a lot of blood. Lay and relax for a bit.”

“I should really spend some time learning Reiki,” I say. “It’s incredible how you can heal with it.”

Danni shrugs. “I’ve just practiced the art for a long time. There are reports of ancient masters who could do much more than close cuts and heal with it. I’m definitely not the first to be this strong in the art. There are likely others alive today better than me, they just have the wisdom to hide their abilities.”

“Well, I’m glad you’re good at it,” I say. “Thank you for saving my life yet again.”

“You’re welcome,” she says.

I turn my head to the left and see the dead bodies lying on the ground. More hunters caught in our trap. “How many did we get?” I ask.

“All of them.” Danni says. “Twenty-five, none escaped.”

“Carl’s pack?” I ask.

“No,” Danielle says. “Helpers.”

I shake my head in disgust. The Infernals employ killers who come in all shapes and sizes around the world. When Danielle took the mantle of ‘Fallen’ and called for Gamers to protect themselves and fight back, we did. In the past two years we haven’t lost more than a couple thousand members, while those hunting us have paid dearly for their attacks. We’ve defended ourselves from over fifty thousand hunters during that time. And by ‘defended’ I mean killed. They wanted a war; Fallen has brought them one.

“I almost lost you, Melissa,” Danielle says. “You’re much too valuable to us — to *me* — to be in such dangerous conditions.”

“Until you learn to fly,” I say.

“That’s not funny,” she says. “I care about you. It doesn’t matter if I ever learn to fly. I want you to live a long, healthy life, Melissa. You’re inexperienced at fighting and killing, yet I seem to let you talk me into bringing you along.”

“How am I going to get better if I don’t practice?” I say.

“Stop it,” Danielle says. “This isn’t just some…” she stops herself in mid-sentence and smiles at me. “Wow, that hasn’t ever happened to me.”

She sits down with a look of concern on her face.

I laugh at her. “That was funny. You getting ready to tell me that this isn’t just some game.” I laugh again, and this time she joins me.

“Okay,” she admits. “This is, of course, a game. I want you to stay in it a while longer. Over the years, you’ve become like a little sister to me, and I want to protect you.”

“I forgive you,” I wink. “You shouldn’t be so involved in these outings either. How will you lead us if you get ejected?”

Danielle shrugs. “Things are set up. The movement is no longer dependent on one person. Besides, Fallen will survive even if I die. Others can and will take up the mantle. Anyway, I’m very skilled at fighting. I’m not in much danger, as long as there are less than 15 coming for me at once.”

“I want to see you fly,” I say. “It’s lonely up there in the sky, and I think you have the best chance of joining me.”

“I want that too. It’s exhilarating just to float a couple inches off the ground and I think I’m close to doing even more.”

“You’re very close,” I say. “After I started to float like that, it wasn’t long until I began to truly fly.”

Danielle stands up and reaches down to give me a hand up. We begin to walk towards the Eternals. “How long do you think?” she asks.

“Everyone is likely different, but once you can float, you’ve mastered almost all of the difficult parts of the process. Knowing you? I would bet within the next twelve months.”

Her face shines with excitement as we join the group. Raphael’s head snaps around to gaze at Danielle, quickly followed by Stephanie reacting the same way and instantly I detect danger in their expressions. Quickly I drop to one knee and look behind me, expecting an attack. Danielle is too preoccupied with the thought of flying to notice, but when I drop down she instinctively bends her knees to assume a ready fighting position.

There’s no one behind us. I look back at the Eternals and they are staring at Danielle. “What’s wrong?” I ask. “You’re looking at Danielle like she’s about to explode.”

“We’ve got to get to safety,” Raphael says. “Immediately.”

“What’s wrong, guys?” Danielle asks.

“Your Clean Mark,” Stephanie says.

“What about it?” Danielle asks.
“It’s gone.”

Chapter 38

Trew

" Can we determine who removed it?" Trew asked.

"No, not yet." Michelle tried to listen to Trew but the command centre had erupted into a flurry of activity when Raphael told Danielle the news. People were handing Michelle tablets, waiting in line to give her reports in an attempt to provide whatever details they could gather.

Trew turned away from Michelle, looking at Brandon. "Could this have happened by accident?" Trew asked.

Brandon's eyes smouldered as he looked at the scene on the main viewer. Danielle was being whisked into a vehicle and driven to a nearby safe house. His jaw rippled as he clenched it tightly. Trew started to ask Brandon another question but he raised his hand for silence. Trew looked out the window, waiting for Brandon to answer him, unconsciously mirroring the clenched jaw and thoughtful pose of his mentor.

After a time Brandon spoke. "There are a couple ways for a Clean Mark to disappear. The most common way is for an avatar to pass through a glitch, an area in the Game that is slightly unstable, which results in subtle changes while near it. If that's what happened, then when they get her away from the glitched area, the Mark will return."

Trew looked at Brandon. "You don't think it's a glitch, though."

Brandon shook his head. "No, I don't. We should know when our player trips a glitch. There wasn't any notification, was there?" Brandon looked at Michelle who met his eyes, quickly shook her head negatively, and continued to work with her team.

"That means someone removed the Mark," Brandon said. "First guess would be the Timeless, but in order for this to occur, both sides would need to formally sit down and agree to remove it. There would be a ritual and the mark would be lifted. This would leave a record in the Game that our team could track and find easily. Once again, because it's affecting our player, we would be notified by the Game. Michelle?" Brandon asked.

"No, that didn't occur," Michelle said.

“Is there a chance that her accessing the Glow and beginning to levitate could remove it?” Trew asked. “It might sound crazy, but…”

“It doesn’t sound crazy at all,” Brandon said. “It’s entirely possible that she could shed it by accident, and that’s what I’m hoping it turns out to be…”

“Damn it!” Michelle shouted, slamming her tablet onto the desk. Trew and Brandon stopped talking and looked at her. She walked over to the desk and sat down next to Trew. Her hands were shaking.

She sat there silently, tapping her finger quickly on the top of the desk. Finally she looked up. “It was removed on purpose, by someone.”

“Who?” Trew asked.

Michelle shook her head, looked down at the desk, and began to tap her finger again. “It’s not going to help us knowing who did it. We need to scramble to get it put back on her.”

Brandon stood up and walked over to Michelle. He grabbed her hand to stop her from tapping. She looked up and met his gaze. He swore softly under his breath and looked first to the left, then to the right. Trew had never seen Brandon look so… dangerous.

Brandon returned to his seat and activated his tablet. He typed in a command and one of the viewers began a video call. Angelica materialized on the screen.

“You do not look happy,” she said.

“Shane’s in play. He removed Danielle’s Clean Mark.” Brandon looked at Michelle to confirm his words and she nodded slowly.

Angelica swore loudly, causing the rest of the people in the conference room to stop their activities. “I’m on my way. Meet you there in less than ten minutes,” she said, and the screen went black.

Brandon stood up and walked towards the exit, Trew close on his heels.

Chapter 39

Trew

“Who’sShane? And how come every time I get one answer, three new ones seem to suddenly appear?”

“Yeah it’s great, isn’t it?” Angelica spun one of the chairs around, grabbed a seat that positioned her facing the door, and gave Trew a sly smile. “It just gets worse with time. I’ve been ‘in the loop’ for the past four years, and for every answer I get, it’s seven new questions.”

Trew sat down and stared at Brandon.

Brandon took a seat and placed his hands flat on the table. He looked silently at Trew, then nodded and began to speak.

“Creating and building the Game was an… aggressive undertaking. I was a young man full of brilliant ideas and beliefs, so sure that the world would become a better place because of the product I was about to bring into existence. I spent weeks and then months constructing an entire universe to exactly mirror ours. No one seemed to get it. No matter how hard I tried to convey my vision to others, they just didn’t understand all of the complexities. The only way to get anything done was to break each task into smaller jobs that a regular person could comprehend enough to accomplish.”

Brandon took a sip of water and activated the single viewer on the wall, displaying a slowly rotating model of Earth. “Then I met a programmer named Shane. He got it. He got me. I was so relieved to find another person who understood exactly what I was trying to do. Over a short period of time I began to share some of the larger responsibilities of constructing the Game with him. It was good to finally have someone else appreciate the difficult and incredible things that I was accomplishing.”

“Sounds romantic,” Angelica said.

“Then you must be listening to a different story,” Brandon said. “Finally, the Game was complete and we were ready to send in the beta testers. Of course I had to go in, and so did Shane. We had a blast. Beta testers had complete knowledge of where they were, unlike regular players of today. We knew it was a game and we went in to test it extensively to

find all the glitches and mistakes in the hopes of making it as perfect as possible for the kids."

"What went wrong?" Trew asked.

"Everything," Brandon said. "Or just one thing, but it was most important. There can be only one King, and Shane believed it should be him. It quickly became clear that Shane believed it was his universe to rule and control. The first beta test was a disaster. It turned into a destructive world war between the two of us."

"I'll bet that was something to watch," Trew said.

Brandon laughed. "It was an epic event," he admitted. "And it did allow us to improve the functionality of the Game in many aspects. It also felt very rewarding to drive a six inch blade into his eye when I claimed victory."

"So where is he now?" Trew asked. "Does he influence the Game from another building in this city, or somewhere else on Tygon? Is he a super-rich man like yourself who sponsors players?"

"Shane might have shared my vision of the Game from a technical point of view," Brandon said. "But he didn't share my vision for what the Game could do to help our society and people. He was just a clever computer programmer and I mistakenly gave him too much power for a brief time. When he was ejected from the first

beta test, I knew he would be a threat to everything I had built, so I needed to neutralize him."

"If he was a brilliant programmer how could you stop him from interfering?"

"There was only one way to protect the Game," Brandon said. "I locked him inside of it."

"Inside of what?" Trew asked.

"Inside the Game," Brandon said. "He entered the Game with the first batch of students, along with the initial Timeless. It was my intention to have him enter like the students, with no knowledge of the real world and a blank memory. Shane caught advance warning and somehow he programmed his avatar to remember who he was."

"He cheated," Angelica said.

"He manipulated the system," Brandon said. "But that was just the beginning. For the first few centuries he caused a significant amount of

damage. My plan wasn't a good one, I realized that he needed to be ejected from the Game and dealt with here, but he continually learned of my plans and stayed ahead of every Timeless I sent after him."

"The primitive people of Earth shared stories of these battles from one generation to the next," Angelica said. "They believed it was angels fighting."

"The favoured angel was cast down from the heavens, attacked by his brethren in an attempt to destroy him. Exiled from his home and never allowed to return to it."

"The Fallen?" Trew asked.

"That's the name he took. To most, he is known as Lucifer," Brandon said. "But his real name is Shane."

"Can't you First him?"

"He disabled our ability to do that, long ago." Brandon said. "He's destroyed all the Eternals and Infernals that we send after him to bring him down. Over the ages he has befriended a small number of Timeless and even assists them from time to time. They either protect him, or he remains hidden from them. I haven't been able to catch him."

"Shane is the 5,000 year old Eternal that the Devil sometimes listens to?" Trew was quickly putting the pieces together.

"Yes, it's a complicated situation," Brandon admitted.

"He can kill Timeless, he's been inside the Game since day one, and he knows it's a computer simulation which he helped design. Why not just send a flood of Timeless to bring him down? There must be a way to eliminate him from the Game."

"He's aware of that danger, and for a long time he has hidden. Every once in a while he surfaces, but our inability to view him and track him makes it easy for him to disappear again."

"He's very powerful?" Trew said.

"More than you can imagine," Brandon said. "He helped build the world, and there are many little features that we built into the digital landscape that give him immense power. He can open a door on one continent and step out on another; he can bend the laws of physics. Imagine a video game where the programmers insert fun glitches and Easter eggs, special features that allow you to change the game. We did that extensively during development, and Shane knows them all. He likely even built some

in that I don’t know about. Putting him inside the Game was the most serious mistake I made. It was the fly in the ointment added at the very beginning of creation.”

“Why not just enter the Game yourself and hunt him down?” Trew asked.

Brandon looked at Trew with a blank stare. Confused, Trew looked towards Angelica; she just closed her eyes and shook her head slightly.

“All right, so what does his involvement mean?” Trew asked. “If he’s the one who lifted the Clean Mark on Danielle?”

“It’s never good when Shane enters the field during a play.” Brandon said. “Not good for the player, and often seriously disruptive for Earth’s history. First, it means any Timeless can kill her. Most won’t be interested, but some will, and that’s a serious problem.”

“Can’t we just convince everyone to leave her alone?” Trew asked.

“There are too many games going on inside the Game,” Angelica said. “Players will lie to your face and stab you in the back. The Mark ensured they would all behave, but if Shane lifted it my guess is another one won’t hold.”

“Okay, so Infernals will target her. What else?”

“Eternals likely will as well,” Angelica said. “We have to suspect everyone.”

“I know Shane,” Brandon said. “He desperately wants one thing above all else. My guess is he’s going to target Danielle and see if she can somehow help him get it.”

“What does he want?” Trew asked.

“He wants to escape from the Game and come back here,” Brandon said.

“But that’s not possible. His body must have perished years ago.” Trew said.

“It did,” Brandon confirmed.

“Then how can he leave the Game and come back?” Angelica asked.

Brandon sighed. “There is a way…”

Chapter 40

Just before entering my last play, I unlocked the option to become a Timeless.

It was very expensive; I paid a lot of credits to simply try *to become one. I was told someone would contact me inside the Game to give me an extensive interview. If I passed their tests, they would make the offer.*

They did contact me and put me through a rigorous screening process. At the time, I thought I was testing to become a government special operative. I guess I must have passed, because they offered to transform me into an Eternal. When I asked them what that meant, they explained that Earth was a complex virtual reality simulation and we were all just players. They said I qualified to become more than just a player; they were offering me the chance to become an immortal who could live inside the Game to help it function more smoothly.

What did I do? Well, of course, I laughed at them and said the idea was ridiculous. Living inside a computer simulation, really!

Yeah, I was disappointed when I finished that play. As a player, I really did want to be an Eternal. Apparently the final test was to see if my avatar could conceive of such a thing, which I failed.

I think most players would jump at the chance to become a Timeless. Sacrifice this life for an opportunity to stay in the Game? Of

course I would have! My life here is nothing special, and I was a decently ranked player when I retired.

For the majority of us, the Game is much better than the lives we end up living after we turn 18.

Excerpt from interview with Clyde Jimmons – ex-top ranked player

Danielle - 54

“ We’re already hiding . For the past few years, if you’re a Gamer, then you’re a target.”

I hear Raphael sigh over the phone. It must be difficult for him, dealing with me all these years. I know I've become more reckless than even the little girl he used to protect. That's fine, I don't intend on behaving myself. That's not how to play this Game. "Average Gamers have been hiding, yes," he says. "You recklessly continue to walk around, and when you were safe from Timeless, I allowed it. But now you're not just one of millions of walking targets, you're the number one target for everyone who wants to kill Gamers."

"Don't be silly," I say. "Fallen is the number one target." It's still a mystery to the world who Fallen is. Our team is always one step ahead of the enemy, keeping my identity safe. Maybe I'm number two now.

"Well, no matter what number you sit at, Stephanie and I can't be near you right now." I hear the frustration in his voice. Now that it's gone, I've learned that one of the perks of having the Clean Mark was that two or three Eternals could constantly be with me. Apparently they give off a certain vibration or energy that allows other Timeless to track them down. If one or more Timeless stay together for a significant length of time, others will search them out to investigate what they're up to. It's a failsafe put in place to make sure they don't have an opportunity to congregate and form

dangerous groups that might cause havoc, which makes sense. Solitary life is one condition imposed on the Timeless; get a dozen or more living together and they could be powerful enough to cause worldwide damage. Stephanie has told me the real story of Troy; the great heroes were Timeless fighting each other. The real story is more exciting than Homer ever described it.

"So what would you like me to do, Raph?" I ask. "Can we get the Mark put back on?"

"No."

"How many factions will come after me, if I stay visible, do you think?"

"All of them, Danni." I can hear the frustration in his voice.

"Is there a way for me to hide from them?"

"Despite your eyes, and the abilities you've developed, you don't appear to give off the energy signature of a Timeless, which is good. Timeless shine brightly to each other. When we pass through a town and

notice a Timeless presence, we search them out. That wouldn't be good for you."

"Do I give off any unique signature?" I ask.

"Yes," he says. "Everyone does, but the differences are subtle. It would take a tracker, a specialist in these small differences, to find you. They will send them eventually, but not at first. The easiest methods often work best, so they'll just hunt you down the simplest way they can."

"From my Internet trail," I say. Every time an individual accesses the Internet they leave a traceable trail from their interaction with it. This trail makes it easy to locate anyone. "We don't even know if I'm in danger," I say.

Raphael laughs. "Sweet girl, can we just assume you're in danger? If not today, then likely tomorrow or the next day. Whoever took the Clean Mark off you will be coming for you."

"Any ideas who it was?" I ask.

"Daniel swears it wasn't him or his. Gabriel says the same. Assuming they're both telling the truth, which I am not prepared to do, that narrows it down to only a handful of others, all very powerful and dangerous. No matter how it happened, we must believe it was done on purpose and hide you until we hear otherwise."

"So the odds are good that I'm going to die soon," I say.

"No… not for a long time, Danni."

"Hey, look, Raph, it's fine. I know there's another place to go to. It's been a good run. If they hunt me down, I'm not afraid to die. I'll get to see Trew again."

"Don't talk like that, Danni," Raph says. "This is exactly why it's not a good idea for people to feel so secure about a life after this one. Suddenly no one cares if they stop breathing here. What if it's worse there, Danni?"

I say nothing. The thought hadn't occurred to me.

"What if you wake up in chains, a slave in a reality of misery?"

"Is that the reality we go to?" I ask.

"I have no idea. It's been a long time since I was there, but it *could* be. How about you just hang on to this life as long as you can? Besides, remember, you only get the best score by playing as long as you can in here."

"All right…"

“I have feelers out,” Raphael says. “Both the Infernals and Eternals are looking, too. Our resources are extensive, so the odds are good we will know soon. Hold on a second, Danni, my other line is ringing.”

I wait while he takes the call, watching Melissa fly around in the open blue sky. I gaze at her and wonder at the finer points of what she is doing. I’m so close to joining her up there, I wish I had no other worries in the world right now and could focus only on flying.

I hear a click and Raphael comes back on the line. “Where are you right now?” he asks. I can tell from the tone of his voice that his other call was not good.

“Half an hour outside of town, practicing with Melissa in a field.” I say.

“I found out who took the Mark off you,” he says. “Steph just heard.”

“Who was it?”

“A guy named Shane,” he says.

“Never heard of him.” I can tell from the tone of his voice that this isn’t a good thing for me.

“We’ve mentioned him by another name before…”

Uh-oh. My blood turns to ice as a thought enters my head. “The Fallen?” I ask.

“Bingo,” he says.

“Damn.”

Melissa drops down beside me. “Three black cars are speeding this way,” she says. “We should get out of here.”

“Gotta go, Raph. Call you soon.” I hear him ask me what’s wrong but I hang up the phone and look at Melissa.

“Which way do we drive to get away?” I ask.

Melissa shakes her head, a grim look on her face. “No time to drive, Danni. We’re gonna have to fly out of here.”

I begin to protest, to tell her she knows I can’t fly, but her look tells me she’s serious. I can see the dust from the cars as they approach and my mouth goes dry. I feel like a baby bird about to be kicked out of the nest by its mother, and I’m scared.

“Damn.”

Chapter 41

The human body, or avatar, as we call it, is an incredibly complex vehicle for a player's consciousness to inhabit. For optimal health and functionality it must be formed and maintained precisely.

Yet it is also very forgiving and resilient, and able to withstand extreme abuse and neglect while still functioning satisfactorily.

I wonder how it came to be what it is today? Was it just a formless construct until avatars focused on it? Or was it designed so delicately with such staggering detail from the very first moment by Brandon Strayne and the Mainframe?

If a few misaligned molecules and proteins can damage the human body catastrophically, can a different misalignment result in creating an extraordinary body?

Is the Game an exact replica of Tygon? If it is, then we should ask the same questions about ourselves. Perhaps if Melissa can fly… I can too.

Anonymous Tygon Citizen

Danielle's command centre

"Did she just compare herself to a baby bird being kicked out of its nest?" Michelle asked.

Brandon nodded his head and laughed. "Yes, she did. Exciting, isn't it?"

"What is?" Trew asked. "What am I missing?"

Brandon waved his hand and Michelle responded, switching the focus of the main screen from Danielle's perspective to a smaller viewer beside it. Melissa's point of view appeared on the main screen, it was a bit disconcerting to see the view switch from inside one person to the other so quickly, but everyone in the room had experienced this so often it no longer affected them.

"Turn up the volume and watch quietly," Brandon said. "Let's see how this situation turns out. I don't want to miss a moment of it because we're talking."

Trew nodded, confused and concerned as the three black sedans raced towards the women in the field.

***

Melissa

“I can’t fly yet!” Danielle shouts.

“You can float,” I say. “I think we can use that to allow me to pull you out of here. Now summon the Glow and start floating. Close your eyes until I tell you to open them. Hurry!”

I can’t fly while holding anything heavy, not more than a few feet. I’m not strong enough. But I know I can pull her if she’s able to float. This is nuts, but let’s see if it works.

I fly into the air to see how far away the cars are. They’re coming fast; we need to go.

I settle to the ground and try to stay calm as I watch Danielle summon her glow. She’s gotten very good at it; we’ve practiced for stressful situations exactly like this. I smile as I sense her glow appear. Yeah, I can do that. She floats gently above the ground.

“Ok, here we go.” I grab hold of her belt and take off. Excellent! She’s light as a feather. Slowly, I begin to move away from the approaching cars.

I fly much quicker than I can run. I think we clocked it at around 100 kilometres per hour. I haven’t pushed my speed to the limit,

though. Most of my time is spent around buildings. Bones will break very easily if they run into a solid building, so I keep it around 30-50 km/h. “I’m going to pick up speed now, Danni.” She nods, eyes still closed.

I figure I’m flying along at about 40 kilometres per hour or so now, about five feet off the ground. Danni is doing perfect. I look behind me and see the cars gaining on us; we’ll never outrun them this way. It’s time to take advantage of our ability to move across uneven terrain in a straight line. I see woods coming up fast; we need to gain some altitude. “We’re going up, Danielle. Don’t let that worry you, just keep doing what you’re doing. You’ve got this! You’re going to fly!”

I hear Danielle gasp as I soar upwards, but she maintains her state. I get ready to feel her extra weight; if it all goes terribly wrong, I can slow our crash to the ground enough that we shouldn’t break anything. She keeps floating, atta girl, Danni! We clear the trees and continue to cross the

woods. I look back and see the cars stop at the edge; there's no road through the forest.

We fly for another five minutes or so, until the woods are well behind us. I hover above the earth, holding Danielle and looking in all directions, but there's no one around. I wave at a couple of seagulls who are hovering near us. Birds find me a curious sight and often fly close.

"Okay, Danni," I say. "We are a bit higher than a foot off the ground — more like a couple hundred feet — but don't panic or drop your Glow." Her eyes squint and she drops slightly but catches herself. I sigh inside; it's always mind over matter. "Now I want you to calmly open your eyes and look around."

Danielle opens her eyes slowly, maintaining a strong Glow. She looks from side to side and then downwards. Her face lights up in a huge grin. "That's it," I say encouragingly, "Just enjoy where you are, don't think about it too much. Keep the Glow going. Now I'm

going to let go of you and you're not going to drop. Remember that I'm not keeping you up here, you are."

She nods and I let her go. She continues to float solidly in place. I drift backwards about twenty feet. "Now come towards me, slowly," I say.

She turns the palms of her hands to face behind her and she slowly moves closer to me, adjusting her hands as she reaches me to once again float in the air.

"Perfect!" I say. "Now let's float down to the ground. It's the same floating a few hundred feet up as it is floating just one. "

Together we descend. I touch down first. When she touches the ground, her glow fades and she runs to throw her arms around me. "That was incredible!" she exclaims. "I can fly! Wow, Melissa, I don't know what to say. How do I ever begin to thank you?"

"It's me who should thank you, Danni," I say. "Your company, your friendship, and your training has allowed me to live a life I never dreamed I could have. I'm honoured that I could give you something in return. Remember, though, the flying is all you. I can show you what to do, but it's you who had to do it. This is the result of thousands of hours of boring, tedious practice. You're the extraordinary person for the commitment you have displayed. You bought this skill with belief and paid for it with hard work."

“I appreciate that,” she says.

“So,” I say, “are you tired? It’s not supposed to sap your strength, but the first few times you fly you’ll likely forget to channel energy from around you and draw off of your own resources.”

“I am a little tired,” she admits. “I think I have the energy for one more quick flight, though. It beats walking out of here. Let’s find a safe place away from whoever was chasing us.”

I smile. “Okay, then, follow me.” I summon the Glow and take to the air, going slow and watching as she quickly joins me.

We fly west for about five minutes and Danielle quickly grabs my arm. “We need to go a different way,” she says. “There’s a black car parked on the side of that road ahead.”

I nod. “That one’s safe. Follow me and promise not to get angry.” I smile and she nods.

As we get closer to the car we can both make out a man standing outside, leaning against the side of the vehicle and looking up towards us. We land and Danielle laughs.

“Hey, Raphael,” she says.

“Hi, Danni,” Raphael says, walking towards her and grabbing her in a fierce hug. “Look at you, flying around like a little bird! Congratulations, girl.”

“Whose idea was this?” she asks, returning his hug briefly, then slapping him on the chest.

“A combined effort,” I say. “You’ve been ready to fly for a while now. I thought it might just be fear holding you back, so we orchestrated this little crisis to help push you in the right direction. Danger can be healthy sometimes.”

“You pulled it off nicely,” Danielle admits. “I saw those cars coming towards me and wasn’t thinking about issues that normally hold me back from trying. Thanks, I guess. But don’t make this a habit. My heart almost stopped beating at the thought of being caught by our enemies.”

“I know, Danni,” Raphael says. “I swear to you that the news about who took the Mark off came to me coincidentally at the same time we were doing this exercise. I won’t be pulling any more scenarios like this from now on. It was important for us to know if you could fly. You have a new and powerful escape route available to you from now on.” Raphael looks

over at me. “Now teach her how to fly erratically so she presents a difficult target to shoot down.”

I nod. “Are you up for a bit more flying right now to try it out?” I ask.

Danielle’s eyes light up. “Yes, let’s.”

Chapter 42

The greatest secret is that we are more powerful than we think.

The greatest tragedy is that we believe lies and ignore truth.

The greatest hope is that we will wake up from the dream that we all share and free ourselves…because the dream is a nightmare.

There is a better life waiting patiently for us all, not just outside of the Game…but here inside it as well.

The dog that appears to be growling at us as we approach is actually looking slightly behind us, trying to protect us from the danger that grasps us tightly. We hush the dog and remain trapped.

Ignorance is not bliss.

Wake up.

An excerpt from a Trew Radfield talk when he was in the Game

Miranda

I hear a voice and my eyes focus on the man on the other side of my cage. It's him, and he's smiling at me.

"Pardon? Did you ask me a question?"

"Indeed I did," he says. His voice is melodic and smooth, like warm honey dripping off of a spoon into a glass of tea. His smile is warm and comforting, I bet people find it easy to trust him. His entire bearing makes him seem fatherly and concerned. Maybe he

drugs us too; I feel groggy. "I asked you if you think I'm stupid." he says.

His question throws me off; it doesn't match his pleasant demeanour. I think cautiously before answering. "No, I don't think you're stupid. I don't even know you," I say.

His lip curls into a half smile. "Each time I bring you out of the Haze you react so differently. We appear to be making progress, then the next time it's as if you don't recall the previous day's interaction."

Okay, it's showtime. I quiver my lip and start to tear up, not really so difficult for me to do; I'm in a hopeless situation that's likely going to end in a very slow painful death, followed by oblivion and the loss of my soul.

“I’m trying very hard to do what you want, mister,” I say. “I’m finding it very difficult to concentrate. I hurt sometimes and I don’t know why. Other times I’m so dizzy and groggy that I can’t keep a single thought in my head. Then when I feel good, like right now, I look around me and discover that I’m in some kind of underground jail. I just want to go back to my normal life, and I’m afraid that’s not going to happen.”

I break down and sob. He waits politely for a few moments as I lose myself in the moment. I finally look up and accept a handkerchief from his hand, wiping my eyes and blowing my nose. I try to access Sparx, and my heart skips a beat. Where her presence usually sits I find nothing. I feel alone.

He must detect my surprise; he smiles and nods sympathetically, then taps a spot on the right side of his neck. There’s nothing there; he must be signalling for me to… I reach up and feel a small bandage covering my neck. I’m not acting this time as my face drains of colour and my stomach does a complete turn.

He smiles, “Yes, that’s right, Miranda. We found a way to remove it. Your nanocomputer is no longer inside you. My young associate,” he points to the teenager in the cell with the computers, “is taking a look at it right now. It’s much more intelligent than you

let on; I’m disappointed that you are such a convincing liar. We will have to work harder to gain your cooperation.”

I sit down heavily on the bed, crushed that they found a way to get Sparx out. I was doing so well; I wonder what they did to me to make me break. This is horrible, all of this planning and scheming for nothing.

“Don’t look so disappointed, my dear,” he says. “You were very entertaining for me. I haven’t run up against resistance like this in centuries. The good news is we are just getting started. I know you will live a long time, being an Eternal.” I flinch. “Oh, yes, I figured that part out, too. It’s been some time since I captured one of your kind in my web. We are going to have lots of fun, for a very long while.”

He snaps his fingers and I look at him. He waves his hand to summon me closer to him; it’s time for him to put me back under. I stand and walk numbly towards him for the tap that will allow me to forget my failures for a brief time. I don’t even care if he makes me suffer during the Haze. I’m broken.

He grabs my chin forcefully and tips my head up to look into my eyes. He nods in satisfaction as he reads the defeat and hopelessness.

“Who are you?” I ask meekly.

He pauses and smiles. Small motes of gold and red swirl around lazily inside his icy blue irises. Do I also detect small flashes of silver? “My name is Shane. Enjoy your rest, Miranda. Our work will finally begin when I bring you out of the Haze next time.”

He taps my forehead and I disappear.

***

I gain consciousness a short time later, lying in the darkness on my bed. I keep my eyes closed and wait for Shane to say something, but he doesn’t. I begin to smile inside.

‘*Tell me it worked?’* I think silently.

‘*Like a charm,’* Sparx replies. Once again I can feel her presence.

‘*It was so real, your absence.’*

‘*That was the plan,’* Sparx says. *‘It had to be, for the performance you needed to deliver, and you did it. Incredible job, Miranda. A shame no one can see what you did.’*

‘You can play it back from my memories when we get out of here,’ I say. *‘How did the delivery go?’*

‘*Our computer expert has what they believe is me,’* Sparx confirms. *‘It will keep them busy for quite some time, and I’m able to direct and control it.’*

‘*And the others?’* I ask.

‘Copies of myself were released and travelled by air to inhabit the other inmates. I have begun gently working to establish silent contact with their brains and psyches.’

‘Excellent,’ I say. *‘And you are able to communicate with all of your individual copies?’*

‘Not yet, but I know they are working. They send out tiny pings to let me know all is on track. They will establish contact when they have set up house in their hosts. We have not been detected by any of Shane’s or the computer kid’s technology.’

‘Dare I hope there’s still a chance for me to get out of this?’ I ask Sparx.

‘Believe you will, and you will, Miranda. You have been trained for centuries for this mission. It’s all going as planned. But Shane can change the rules at any moment, let’s stay sharp.’

‘*On to phase two,’* I say.

‘I’ll wake you when we are ready,’ Sparx says.

Chapter 43

I hope you are all enjoying this channel. Realizing how incredibly busy Trew is for the next few weeks while his beloved Danielle is still inside the Game, I think we are extremely lucky to get the regular exposure we get from him. Take this segment, for instance. Every morning we get to bring Trew a coffee and spend a few moments talking with him.

Let's go on in, shall we?

"Knock, knock, good morning, Trew."

"Good morning, Lisa,and hello to everyone watching at home. Ahh, you've trained me to crave this morning coffee to kickstart my day, Lisa. Thank you so much."

"It's our pleasure, Trew. So is there anything you can share with us today? Danielle is in grave danger now that her Clean Mark is gone; that's what all the experts are saying."

Trew laughs. "Lisa, if you've spent any amount of time watching Danielle play, I think you have to admit that she possesses incredible skills to protect herself. She isn't your regular damsel in distress. I wouldn't want to meet up with her in a dark alley, or a well lit room for that matter."

"Of course you're right, Trew. She is very formidable. But we don't know what special powers her hunters might possess. We've had limited sightings of Timeless and other extraordinary creatures inside the Game."

"I agree with you there, Lisa. I suppose any new meeting will be good for her ranking and the fans. I can assure you, I will always put my money on Danielle, and that isn't a personal decision, it's a shrewd and informed bet."

"We were all amazed when she showed her ability to fly yesterday, Trew."

"As was I."

"What do you make of reports that there is a young player who claims to be able to levitate outside of the Game on Tygon?"

"Andrew? I've met him and seen it for myself, Lisa. Remember, the Game mirrors our world exactly. If something is possible inside the Game, it can be achieved out here as well."

“You’ve seen him levitate? Incredible.”

“We continually underestimate ourselves, both inside the Game and out. Thoughts are truly the most powerful things we possess. This is an exciting time to be alive, both inside the Game and here.”

Morning interview with Trew, Lisa Rohansen reporting.

“ I told you to come to me, Carl. Why are we speaking on a telephone?”

“I’m close to getting a big group of Gamers, Boss. I can’t leave right now or I’ll lose them again, and it’s taken me months to find them

There was a long pause on the line while both silently gauged the other. “Okay, fine. You’re very close to your number. That means I’m very close to being pleased.”

Carl knew he was being mocked. It had taken entirely too long for him to eject the last 80,000 players, and they both knew it. He didn’t bother to respond to Daniel’s insincere praise.

“Kill them, then I have a new assignment for you,” the Devil said.

“But this won’t reach our number. We’re still very far from it.”

“You can get back to it after this next assignment. There might be a very narrow window on your next target, Carl.”

There was a tap on the coffee shop window. Carl looked up and saw a familiar figure standing outside. Gabriel raised his hand in greeting, appearing cheerful as he rubbed his hands together to warm them and walked towards the entrance. Carl frowned. “Listen Boss, I've gotta go. I’ll call you after I’m done with this group.”

“So disinterested in your next target that you don’t even try to get it out of me?” Daniel sounded suspicious, Carl always pushed things farther than he should, but he didn’t seem like his normal self on the phone today.

“You never tell me anyway,” Carl growled, “so why bother begging?” Gabriel had entered the front door and was walking towards him, nodding and smiling at people as he approached. The entire room had become more joyous and positive by Gabriel’s presence. It made Carl want to throw up.

“Someone has lost her Clean Mark, Carl,” Daniel said. “We will take full advantage of that. You are to eject Danielle Radfield from the Game.”

“What?” Carl couldn’t believe what he was hearing. Gabriel sat down across from him and watched politely.

“Kill the Gamers, then Danielle. And do it all quickly,” The Devil commanded.

“All right,” Carl said, looking downwards at the table.

“And, Carl?”

“What?”

“I want you in front of me immediately after that. It’s been too long since we’ve had a meal together. That’s an order.”

Carl didn’t hesitate. “Sure thing, Boss." He hung up the phone, closed his eyes for a moment, and then spoke.

“Thanks for meeting me.”

“Happy to see you again. It’s not often that I’ve heard from you these past few centuries, Carl,” said Gabriel. “Your tone sounded serious. What’s up?”

Carl looked at Gabriel, who boomed out a surprised laugh. It was deep and rich, but Carl didn’t detect any malice in it.

“Stop it!” Carl snapped.

“I’m sorry,” Gabriel said. “This must be terribly confusing for you.”

“Damn it,” Carl said. “I was hoping I was wrong. Thought perhaps it was just my imagination.”

“It isn’t,” Gabriel confirmed.

The two men sat quietly, then Gabriel spoke up. “How can I help you?”

“I’ve been given orders; too many orders, and for the first time in I can’t remember how long, I have issues with some of them. What orders do I follow?”

“You know the rules, my boy. Follow the orders that match your eyes. It’s pretty simple.”

Carl nodded slowly. “Okay. Thanks for the confirmation. I guess I need to find Danielle, then.”

“That doesn’t sound good,” Gabriel said.

“No,” Carl shook his head, “I’m sure it won’t be.”

Chapter 44

Millions of Gamers are now on Tygon, and I don't mean players… I mean millions of people who are following the teachings of Trew, calling themselves Gamers and meeting to discuss his messages and philosophy.

Exact numbers are difficult to estimate; they seem to be following the advice of Danielle inside the Game and are remaining underground, avoiding large meetings and hiding their trails of communication with each other.

When asked for a comment, Trew smiled and said the following: "It's not that difficult to believe, since our worlds are identical. I hope no one drives a spike into me here, though. I want to spend more than a few weeks on Tygon."

Suddenly overnight, Tygon once again has a large religion.

Are we playing a realistic computer game? It sounds absurd the first few times you say it. It was true for Earthlings, though…

Very interesting developments.

Report, Channel 1 Game News

Shane

I haven'tbeen this nervous in years. This girl is very intriguing. Mother to a new religion; able to fly through the air; possessing healing powers that are usually kept very secret if they are

fostered and grown at all. Danielle is turning the way this universe works on its head, from a player's perspective, and she seems to be doing it all as if it were just… some *game*.

I simply have to meet her.

It's cold out, but I've been standing here for the past fifteen minutes, across the street from a gourmet coffee shop. Since I removed her Clean Mark, she's become much less predictable, which makes this much more fun.

No signs of protectors, specifically Eternals.

Okay, Shane — showtime! I cross the street and walk towards the shop.

It’s time to meet my ticket home.

***

Danielle

I see him look my way as he approaches the counter. Just a glance, but there’s something about it that makes my senses tingle. I pretend to read my magazine; my cell phone camera is on and watching the counter the entire time. He doesn’t glance my way again; instead he studies the menu board, patiently waits his turn, then smiles and places his order. I guess I was wrong; I turn my phone off and go back to reading my magazine.

“Excuse me, I couldn’t help but notice you sitting here.” I look up and it’s him. How did he do that? He was walking towards the door a few moments ago and suddenly he’s beside me. I remain calm and smile up at him.

“Do I know you?” I ask. He looks harmless enough, and I feel safe sitting in the middle of a crowded coffee shop.

“No, we haven’t met before,” he says. “I recognize you, though. You’re Danielle Radfield, right?”

“I am.” I nod cautiously. I still get recognized from time to time, although not as often as the years pass.

“I knew it!” he says. “I was a very big follower of Trew, back in the day.”

“That isn’t true,” I say.

“Why do you say that?” he asks.

“Because if you were a big follower, you’d be dead.” Everyone knows Gamers who were ‘on the record’ are all dead. Unless… “or are you one of the lucky ones?” I ask. The lucky ones were those who were spared during the culling. A strange lot, most of them wanted to remain active in the movement. Without knowing for certain why they were spared, the new and secret group avoided them. A wise move, I think, which is why I came up with it.

“No,” he says, “I wasn’t one of the lucky ones. I just never went to an event or did anything that would associate me with the movement. I’ve always been very cautious about things like that.”

“Well, good for you,” I say. “It looks like your instincts were correct. I wish millions of others had been as cautious; they would still be alive today. It’s likely not very wise for you to be talking to me now.”

“Well, yes. I guess I should go.” He doesn’t move to leave. “This is just a lucky coincidence, however, so it wouldn’t hurt for me to meet you and maybe chat a bit. Unless I’m being too presumptuous? If so, I do apologize and I’ll move on.”

“You should likely go,” I say. “No offense, but we all need to stay safe these days.”

He nods. “I agree absolutely.” He begins to walk away. “There is just one question I’ve always had, though… it would be silly for me to walk away and never ask it.”

I sigh; really, I’m too kind sometimes. Against my better judgment, I look up and smile. “What question is that, uh…” I realize I don’t know his name.

“Jason.” He extends his hand and I shake it.

“It’s nice to meet you, Jason,” I say.

“And you as well,” he says. “I was just wondering… how could they leave him alone that night?”

“Who?” I ask, but I know who. It’s the same question that nagged at me for so long.

“Your protectors? The Eternals. How could they allow Trew to be alone even for a minute like that? It just doesn’t make sense to me. I’ve done a lot of research over the years and from what I’ve been able to piece together, Timeless can… sense each other, somehow. I don’t know if it’s telepathy or what, but regardless of how they do it, they can.”

“Yeah, I’ve heard that too.” Only recently, but he doesn’t need to know that.

“Well, then, what excuse did they give you? He was killed by another Timeless; they would have known for certain that he was there, on the same floor at least. And if they did, which they must have, then how could they allow themselves to be separated from either of you?”

I’ve not thought about it that way before. I feel dizzy; what he’s asking makes perfect sense. Did they know Carl was there? If they did, and allowed themselves to be separated from Trew, that would mean…

Your supernatural protectors set Trew up to be killed…". My ears feel like they're filled with cotton, I can feel a sweat break out on my brow. I reach up to wipe my forehead. "Are you all right?" Jason looks concerned and reaches for my arm.

"I'm fine." I take a drink of water and breathe deeply, allowing my pulse to slow down. After a few moments, I feel much better.

"I can see how you might feel that way, Jason," I say reassuringly, "but I've thought long and hard about what you're suggesting. There's no way they allowed Trew to be killed."

"I can understand how you want that to be true, Danielle," he says. Then he leans forward and whispers, "I can prove that I'm right, and I think you're in grave danger. From them."

I want to call him a liar, but something in his manner tells me he believes what he's saying. Strangely, I'm afraid that *I* might believe him. This is years in the past, but I have to know if my friends are truly on my side. I can't imagine what to do if they aren't, but I need to know.

"I want to see your proof," I say.

"I don't know, Danielle…" Jason looks suddenly worried.

"You don't have any proof, do you?" I say.

"Yes," he hesitates, "it's just that I'm nervous. I've survived this long by flying under the radar. If I were to bring you to my place to show you the proof, I would be putting myself in serious danger."

"Please," I say. "It must be a sign that we stumbled upon each other today. We will be very careful, but I must see your evidence."

He looks at me; I can tell he's reluctant. I wait patiently and hope that the war inside him ends in my favour. Finally he nods his head affirmatively. "Fine. Against my better judgment, I'll show you."

"Great, let's go." I stand up and reach for my jacket.

"No, not right now," he says. "I'll contact you and arrange to take you to my place. Then I'll share my knowledge with you."

"When?" I ask.

"Soon." He places his hand on my arm and squeezes it gently. "Until then, tell no one about this. If they find out, it will put us in even greater danger."

"Don't worry, Jason. Your secret is safe with me."

Chapter 45

It feels like a dream, but I know it isn't.

Too vivid, this feels more real than when I'm actually awake. It only takes a moment of crystal clear clarity of sound, vision, and every other aspect of where I stand, to understand where I am.

I smile and bow my head, which is always how the communication begins.

"How are you doing, Trew?" the masculine voice surrounds me; not just a voice, but also a feeling of peace and calm.

"I'm busy, and worried, and…busy," I say out loud.

"Ahh, yes, I can understand all of those feelings. Unfortunately, it requires much time and effort to influence two worlds. You are doing very well so far, my son. Subtle, which is key."

"I'm frightened for Danni," I say. "I think there are many factions hunting her, and all of them are invisible to us."

"To you, perhaps. There is one who sees everything."

"Brandon?" I ask.

Gentle, deep laughter dances around me, making me smile. "No, Trew. Despite what he would have you believe, Brandon misses the occasional detail. Not many, but some. I can tell you that there is nothing which occurs on Tygon that escapes my attention."

"Sylvia," I say.

"Indeed."

"Then I will ask her for help."

"Be prepared for her to deny you," the voice says.

"Why would she do that?" I ask.

"Each of us plays an intricate game, Trew. After aeons of moves, it is possible to become less able to make changes. Even the smallest adjustment can bring everything tumbling towards failure. Sylvia may not help you in this regard, as much as I am certain she wants to."

"Then what can I do?"

"The best that you can, Trew. That is all any of us can do…"

***

Carl

I've been following her for too long.

Numerous opportunities have presented themselves, yet still I hold back. This isn't like me. Soon I won't be able to tolerate my own presence, so thick is my self-disgust.

Never mind; no sense dwelling on the past. Today is the day.

She turns down a quiet alley, heading towards her favourite coffee shop. Most wouldn't know it's her favourite; she does an excellent job of keeping her routine random and unpredictable, but I'm a pro, and one visit every six to ten days is as routine as I've been able to observe. It's enough to be a weakness for her; a strength for me.

She goes in and I wait on the other side of the street, leaning against a building as the world passes me by, each person scurrying past. For the thousandth time I debate whether I will say anything, or simply strike. I enjoy delivering something clever, but she's become extremely competent over the years. My gut tells me to show her the proper respect and say nothing; my considerable ego encourages me to capture the moment with a quirky, smartass statement of some sort.

"Outta the way, Carl." A body bumps into me then moves past. I'm caught by surprise, damn it! I've been stalking Danielle so long I'm getting lazy. I catch a faint whiff of perfume as the figure quickly walks away; a beautiful woman glances at me and smiles. I immediately begin to follow. I don't recognize her, but it will only take a moment to learn who's interfering with my hunt. She turns the corner and I quicken my pace and follow.

The alley is dark, cramped, and filthy. I can feel the dangerous aura that surrounds it, warning normal people to stay out. I smile; it's my kind of place. I see her vanish through a door and move to follow her.

Suddenly I hear a man's voice behind me. "What the hell's the matter with you, Carl?" Strong hands grab me from behind and prevent me from moving. "Slipping in your old age, it would seem. Nighty-night, Grandpa," I feel a small needle prick my neck and consciousness begins to fade.

As blackness takes me, all I can think is, *A clever comment? They didn't even respect me enough to strike* fast *and silent*…'

Chapter 46

“Good morning, Lisa. Wow, is it morning already? I didn’t sleep at all last night. No, that’s fine, come on in. I could use that coffee you’re holding in your hand.”

“Good morning, Trew. You look surprisingly awake and refreshed for someone who hasn’t slept. What’s your secret?”

“Excitement! No matter where I turn, exciting things are happening, Lisa. I don’t dare sleep and miss developments — inside the Game or out. Oh, my alarm is going off, I’ll have to leave in about five minutes. Do you have a question of two for me to answer before I go?”

“Just one question this morning, Trew.”

“Fire away.”

“We’ve been watching you speak on the video feeds. The masses are tuning in to listen in record numbers. You’ve alluded to something repeatedly, but haven’t come right out and said it. I was hoping to get a straight answer this morning, Trew.”

“I will if I can, Lisa. What is it you’d like to know?”

“Do you believe the people of Tygon are all living in an elaborate and complex reality simulation — that we are just players in a computer game as well?”

“Yes, Lisa, I do. It appears that millions of others share the same belief.”

“If that is true, then is it also possible the same is happening in the ‘next’ reality? And if so, when would it end? I don’t know what to think about the idea that we might all be tens, hundreds, thousands of levels deep within a game upon a game.”

“I’m sure it would end somewhere, Lisa. Maybe the next life truly is the real one. We will have to wait and see when we get there.”

“I’m dizzy at the thought of it, Trew.”

“Don’t worry, Lisa. I’m here to hold us all steady.”

- Morning interview with Trew, Lisa Rohansen reporting.

Danielle’s Command Centre

“ What have we been able to learn about this man named Jason?” Brandon asked.

Nadine stepped forward and brought up a video feed. “Everything checks out so far. He’s a low ranked player named Mark Aunders on Tygon, age 14. This is his second human incarnation. Inside the Game he has led a fairly unremarkable life. He has no family, works at a local bookshop… we can see that he does spend quite a bit of time on the Internet and watching movies. He’s very good with computers; we can’t find a reliable trail of usage or history of browsing, which is rare but not unheard of.”

“Are we concerned that he’s a threat to Danni?” Trew asked.

“From what we’ve been able to learn, Danielle can handle herself with him, no problem,” Nadine said.

Brandon nodded. “Okay. There’s news to share with you all on another front. Reports from reliable sources indicate that Carl is in the wind.”

Michelle looked concerned. “What do you mean, in the wind? From our perspective he’s been more in the wind than out of it over the years.”

“From the Infernals’ perspective. He was supposed to meet with Daniel some time ago, but hasn’t shown up. There is a faction-wide alert to report his whereabouts as soon as anyone spots him. My source assures me the Devil is insane with anger over Carl’s lack of communication. Carl’s in a mess, even for him, if he doesn’t soon make an appearance before his boss.”

“What do we do with this knowledge?” Trew asked.

“We spread the word to everyone we can,” Brandon said. “This could be another elaborate trick; they often use disinformation to keep us off our game. If it’s accurate, then if we see Carl anywhere near our players, we deal with him before he gets too close. The instructions are to bring him down and deliver him to the Infernals. As little damage as possible; the regular courtesies we extend to Timeless. No one is calling for his removal from the universe at this time. We are bound to help; they’ve done the same for Eternals when asked.”

“Where was he last seen?” Michelle asked.

“By us?” Brandon asked. “When he brought the group into the warehouse trap Danielle set up for him. “On another note," Brandon said. "What are we doing?”

“In what respect?” Trew asked.

“I don’t feel Danni is really playing much lately. Yeah, she can fly. Yes, she’s learning some incredible skills with energy and Reiki based practices. Yes, she’s killing and hunting down those trying to wipe out Gamers. And sure, her Clean Mark has been lifted, and we’re concerned about that, but other than that, what is she really doing?”

The Command Centre erupted in laughter. After a few moments, people started to realize that neither Brandon nor Trew were laughing, and the room slowly became quiet.

“Her rank is not number one,” Brandon said.

“It fluctuates, but that’s normal,” Nadine said. “She still has a lot of play time, Brandon, and she’s doing incredible things that the average player only dreams of doing.”

“I had a lot of play time left too,” Trew said. “The Game didn’t care; I was kicked anyway.”

“Do we even have a concern?” Michelle asked. “When she went into the Game, Alex didn’t have a goal plan. Her limited points allowed her to spend them on the basic things, so from our perspective she is doing incredibly well. A finish in the top one million players would make her a superstar, and she’s never lower than the top 500 rank.”

“This type of team,” Brandon indicated the group in the room, “Doesn’t thrive on lack of goals; we need to be working towards something. I agree that she’s doing incredibly well. I also agree that we have no direction from her game plan. I want us to come up with a list of accomplishments that

we can help her work towards, to keep us busy. We have the skills to keep her number one when she exits the Game. To endeavor towards any other outcome is a waste of all our time.”

Michelle nodded, “Of course, you’re right. We’ll think about what has been accomplished so far and come up with some goals based on our knowledge of Danni and her growing skill set.”

“I want you all to keep this thought in the back of your minds as you plan,” Trew said. “Danni has proven to be one of the most gifted players we’ve ever seen. If you think of something for her to accomplish and your brain tells you such a thing would be impossible to do… then you know

you’re on the right track. Danielle seems to be particularly adept at achieving the impossible, and we want to see as much of that as we can.”

The team looked from Trew to Brandon, who nodded in agreement.

“I also want to find a way to get her protectors back with her,” Brandon said. “Someone come up with a way for Stephanie and Raphael to be by her side without attracting the attention of every Timeless in the world. Make that a top priority.”

“She’s in danger,” Trew said.

“More than ever,” Brandon agreed. “Put someone on this Jason fellow. I want him fully checked out. Our info might say he’s clean,

but I want to make absolutely certain. Get an Infernal on him ASAP.”

“I mean, she’s in danger right now,” Trew said, pointing to the monitor behind them.

Danielle was shaking hands with Jason in the street across from a large building. Another camera feed showed Raphael watching her from across the street.

“Something doesn’t feel right,” Brandon said. “I wanted Raphael by Danni’s side when she went to meet him. He’s too far away from her!”

On the screen, Danni and Jason walked into the apartment building and got onto the elevator.

“We’ll make certain Raphael or Stephanie is by her side next time she meets with him,” Michelle assured him.

On the viewer, the signal from Danielle started to crackle and become fuzzy. The two got off the elevator and began to walk towards an apartment. The viewer flashed a few times then went dark. The team looked at each other silently.

“Her feed’s being scrambled,” Trew said.

“Damn it!” Brandon exclaimed.

Raphael stood outside the building, patiently waiting.

The team watched the blank screen helplessly, hoping that it was just a glitch and would come back on.

It didn’t.

Inside the Game, Raphael waited for three hours. Then he made a call and entered the building.

Three hours later, everyone’s worst fears were confirmed.

Danielle was gone.

Chapter 47

Danielle's Command Centre

" Can you repeat that?" Trew said. The past hour had been a flurry of panicked activity, everyone scrambling to do whatever possible to find Danielle. Inside his head, Trew was screaming at how quickly time was passing inside the Game while they worked outside of it. Their opportunity to help Danni was disappearing.

"We looked further into Mark Aunders, the kid playing Jason's avatar," Michelle said. "It turns out the location of his table in the system was not correct. Further investigation has revealed there is no such person playing the Game."

"This kid doesn't exist*?* How is that possible?" Trew asked, looking at Brandon in confusion.

"That means Jason is likely a PlaceHolder," Brandon said.

"A computer generated individual, designed to perform in the Game for specific purposes," Trew said. "Something randomly generated by Mainframe?"

"Likely," Brandon confirmed. Trew stood up and headed for the door, intending to speak with Sylvia. "There's no point in confronting her, Trew," Brandon said. "Whoever set up the identity for us to find knew enough about our resources that they were able to build a fake trail that looked legitimate. Either she has this set in motion and will deny it, or it's a random construct, just bad luck."

"Or it was a hack," Michelle said.

"Likely," Brandon agreed.

Trew sat down. "The more I learn about this Game, the more I want to scream and throw chairs out of windows," he said. "Who the hell can hack like this? The official story is no one can hack the Game from Tygon. Mainframe won't allow it. If anyone tries something like this then they are easily caught and given the death penalty."

"That's absolutely true. Mainframe catches any hackers. Trust me, we know too well how good her security system is," Brandon said. "It's

definitely a hack from the inside. I would bet everything I own that it's Shane."

"Or this Jason guy was taking her to Carl?" Trew said. "That's a good guess, too, isn't it?"

"Yes," Brandon said. "And I sincerely hope you're right, Trew. Carl would be a better opponent right now, but it stinks of Shane."

"How long can her signal be scrambled?" Trew asked.

"Indefinitely," Brandon answered. "There are no harmful effects from long term scrambling, no chance of being ejected from the Game. The communication between her consciousness and avatar won't be affected, just our ability to see her. There have been avatars scrambled for…"

"Okay, I get the picture," Trew said. He didn't want to hear that it was possible for them to go for decades without seeing Danielle in the Game.

"The building has been scoured from top to bottom. She's not there, guaranteed," Michelle said.

"Another clue pointing to Shane. He could transport them out of there easily. They could be anywhere on Earth by now."

"So what do we do?" Trew asked.

"We just keep trying, hoping something or someone can help us," Brandon said.

Trew looked intently at the black screen of Danielle's feed. After a few minutes he closed his eyes and prayed.

The flurry of activity continued on around him.

***

Melissa

"What can I do, Raphael?" I ask.

Raphael looks angry and frightened, meeting my eyes with grim determination. "I can't sense her anywhere. That's not good because I'm a tracker." He sees my confused look and explains, "I have the ability to track individuals by their unique energy patterns. Once I have your pattern, I can find you anywhere within five hundred miles. And I know Danni's pattern extremely well."

“Oh,” I say. “So I guess there’s no point in me taking to the air to see if I can spot her.”

“No, but thank you for offering,” Raphael sighs. “I honestly don’t know what to do. We will find her but it won’t be quick. Damn it, I knew I should have been right by her side the entire time!”

I hate to say it, but I have to. “Is there a chance she’s… dead*?*”

He shakes his head absently, “No, she’s alive. We would know instantly if she was dead.”

“How would we know that?” I ask.

Raphael looks at me strangely. “I would know,” he assures me. “She’s alive, somewhere. You head back to the compound and meet up with Stephanie to see if anyone has any ideas.”

“Where are you going to be?” I ask.

He has a heavy, hooded jacket on, and goggles hanging around his neck, which he puts on. “I need to be within five hundred miles to sense her. I also have to make sure I don’t go past her too quickly, or I’ll miss detecting her. There’s a slim chance I can find her,

although they likely have her shielded, so this trip will be for nothing. But I’ve got to try; it won’t take me too long.”

“Try what?” I ask.

“You might be the first human to fly in the history of this planet,” he says. “but you’re not the first avatar to do so.”

He positions the goggles, bends his knees, and jumps upwards. Wow, he’s fast! He floats in the air about twenty feet up and yells down at me, “Hurry, get to Steph. Tell her I should be back in about twelve hours.”

In spite of my surprise, I manage to yell up at him, “Where are you going?”

“Gonna circle the globe, at least a couple times, to try and find her. It’s worse than looking for a stinking needle in a haystack, but I have to try.”

In the blink of an eye, he’s gone. I hear the boom from air rushing in to fill the void his lightning-quick exit created. I take to the air and head for Stephanie, thinking to myself, *It’s possible to break the sound barrier? It looks like I’m still a baby when it comes to flying.*

Chapter 48

What is a PlaceHolder inside the Game?

This is a question I hear often.

The quick explanation is this: A PlaceHolder is any avatar inside the Game that is not controlled by a player.

At last count, we had just under two billion players inside the Game. Our young students are incarnated in the Game as animals and plants and insects and such; I'm not sure of the exact number, but it's over half a billion. The remaining players are incarnated as humans, approximately a billion and a half of them, living in a world with a human population of just over seven billion people.

Yes, that's a lot of PlaceHolders walking around.

Now, before you have visions of zombies stumbling about attempting to destroy the world, let me assure you that PlaceHolders are very complex programs. They are born, they live, and they die just like any player controlled avatar. The average viewer usually can't tell the two apart. If I allowed you to watch the life of two humans and asked you to pick which one was the PlaceHolder, most of you would guess incorrectly; they are that realistic. We had to implement the player directory because we were flooded with calls of viewers wanting to subscribe to follow players who were actually PlaceHolders. The way it works today, before you call us to subscribe, you search out the human and find the corresponding player, a much better system.

So you see, PlaceHolders are humans, and they are needed in the Game to allow the real players enough variety and opportunity to play a more exciting Game. The world needed to grow and expand beyond the available players. PlaceHolders allowed this to happen.

PlaceHolders are the automatons, the cogs and gears that allow the Game to function for a smooth playing experience. A shopkeeper who sits all day and sells items? Often a PlaceHolder. Factory workers that go to work day in and day out to complete a simple, repetitive task? Best done by a PlaceHolder.

That doesn't mean players don't get stuck doing these types of things. Sadly, most of them stand beside PlaceHolders for their entire lives, stuck in

the same ruts with the same unfulfilling results.

See what I mean when I tell you it gets tough to tell the players from the non?

One of the fun parts of watching the Game!

Brandon Strayne - the Game Explained

Miranda

Sensations of cold and pain force me to open my eyes.

I feel icy wet concrete pressed against my cheek; not the type of pillow I'm used to. I raise my head and slowly look around. This is no cell — it's a filthy alley. Dirty snow and dark, stinking water drips from my matted hair and face as I sit up.

This can't be good.

My hands and feet are numb and bare. I'm shivering fiercely; that's likely what woke me up. I'm dressed in light pants and a sweater covered in dirt and grease, soaked thoroughly with alley water.

I stand up and reach out to catch the edge of a dumpster to stop me from falling. A wave of hunger and dizziness sweeps over me;

my thoughts are sluggish. It's a good guess I've been drugged. Here's hoping it's wearing off.

Ten feet to my left is a row of cardboard boxes, I can hear someone coughing inside. A large, dark rat squeaks loudly to my right, scurrying towards the shadows, something hairy hanging from its mouth. The alley extends deeper behind me, getting darker as it goes. The lights on the walls are mostly broken and useless. My best option lies ahead; a dull grey light shines on a street. I can see cars and people moving past the alley opening.

I take a step forward and intense pain spikes upwards from my heel into my hip, like a white-hot electric current driving straight into my stomach. I bite my lip and try not to cry out; only a small whine escapes, echoing off the walls. Pursing my lips, I give it another try. The pain increases. Getting out of this alley is my goal and I'm going to do it, even if I have to crawl.

Slowly I move towards the street, counting the steps as I go. Twenty-four steps, each one an agonizing moment of torture, lasting for eternity. I take a step, wait until the bulk of the pain subsides, then grit my teeth and

take the next one. As I count twenty-four my hand grips the wall and I clear the alley. I want to sit down, just for a minute, but I know that if I do it'll be impossible to get back up. I decide to head for the café on my left. A quick calculation tells me that salvation is only fifteen steps away. Fifteen impossible steps. I can't move another inch. Tears begin to form in my eyes.

Wait a minute…

'Sparx? Where the hell are you? How come I just remembered you now? Come on, ol' buddy, kill the pain sensors in my leg so I can get to that café over there.'

Nothing. I can't sense Sparx at all. Something's wrong. Very wrong.

'Sparx!' I yell in my head. 'Can you hear me? I need you, just for a few moments, then you can go back to whatever it is you're doing…'

I close my eyes and try to focus within, to search for some trace of Sparx, but the pain is too great; I can't calm down. 'Fine, then, don't help. I'll do this myself.' I try to sound confident, but I'm holding onto sanity by a thread. The pain, and no response from Sparx… and where the hell am I?

I decide to think about what's happening while I walk. Maybe it will help me keep moving.

Step.… When's the last time I lost contact with Sparx? Total contact, complete silence? The answer is never.

Step.… I can always sense her, even if she doesn't respond.

Step.… Where the hell is Shane? What happened, for me to end up here?

Step.… Did he find out about me? Why didn't he just kill me?

I stop and lean against the wall, gasping for air. The world is spinning. I look around to see if anyone will help me. Everyone is staying very far away from me, not that I can blame them.

I grit my teeth and move one painful step at a time. I expend my last ounce of energy and fall, about two steps short of the café. With a grunt and a moan, I crumple like a wad of wet toilet paper, falling with a heavy thud onto the sidewalk. The pain lessens when the weight is taken off my leg. Sounds from the street are less clear. Maybe I'm lying in a pool of water. Perhaps if I close my eyes, just for a minute… ahh, yes, that's better. I'm starting to feel warmer now…

I feel hands grab and lift me. I can't muster the strength to open my eyes. I try to mumble 'Thank you,' not caring if whoever has hold of me

intends to do harm or good. Oh, god, they're standing me up. The pain shoots up my leg and explodes into my head with a blast of heat. *Sparx, where are you…?*

Chapter 49

What's the point in knowing that Timeless exist if we don't get to view them?

I know I've commented on this before, more than a hundred times in the past few weeks, but come on — it's like being shown a mythical figure and then hiding it away again.

And what's with all this new supernatural activity on Earth? Flying? Energy that can heal people? Who knows what else?

Did someone suddenly flip a switch and make Earth nothing like Tygon? I doubt very much we can do the same types of things here. I know I sound negative — hell, I know *I'm being negative, but someone has to say what millions of us must be thinking.*

Show us more and prove that it's for real!

I think if we continue to be treated like this, we should show the powers that be how much control we really have. I'm encouraging you to stop viewing the Game. Stop supporting Brandon Strayne and his silly waste of time that has become the focus of all our lives.

Wake up, people! Rant by Game critic, Tim Brandl

Carl

Cold, dark and damp . Figures that's the kind of place I'd wake up. Most people would just be glad to wake up, but I'll reserve that feeling for after I've determined who took me.

I close my eyes and use my other senses. If I had a buck for every time I was dumped in the dark and escaped easily, yeah, I'd have a few bucks. I enter a meditative state, then pulse my energy field outwards, releasing it and waiting for it to come back to me. Less than a second later the pulse returns, a type of psychic sonar which gives me a brief outline of my surroundings.

I'm in a very small concrete cell; there's metal mixed in with it. Looks like whoever put me here knows what they're doing. Not much energy will get out of here or in. Once again I curse that kid who played Faraday and

invented the Faraday cage. I hope the kid scored well for the invention, but it's been a constant pain in the ass. Then I chuckle to myself; I never complain when I use it to *my* advantage. Funny how that works.

I turn to my left, right, up and down, releasing a pulse to get a full picture of what surrounds me. It's so dark that when I hold my hand up to touch my nose I still can't see it. Damned metal in the

concrete. I can't determine what lies more than twenty feet in any direction. There is a hallway and another cell directly across from me; it's empty at the moment.

I slowly move my hand along the bars of my cell, stopping as I feel a tray, a cup and what feels like bread with some kind of warm stew. I carefully bring the tray to my bed and sit down, then quickly use the bread to shovel the food into my mouth, not stopping to taste or smell it. As soon as I'm done wolfing the food down, I take a big gulp of liquid, then I blow out through my mouth to prevent the taste buds from working. I can't stop the tasters from working a bit at the end, though; I'm catching faint flavours that actually taste pretty good. I quickly use my finger to scrape a bit of both the food and the liquid and taste it more carefully, searching for any telltale hints of drugs. I can't detect anything familiar.

Sitting back against the bed, I slowly count to five hundred. No dizziness, nausea or any other signs of being drugged. Out loud I

say, "That's one." This is how I mark the time during captivity, by the meals. Marking it out loud helps me remember, which isn't a problem now, but I've been locked away in some very rough situations and it gets harder to focus as time goes by.

I feel a disturbance outside my cell; not a door opening — the air begins to hum slightly and a sharp line of blue outlines the shape of a door. I close my right eye and look at it with my left. No sense losing all of my night vision if the lights are suddenly turned on and then off again. Slowly, a doorway forms; blue light envelops the entire interior of an area three feet wide by six feet tall. I see two shapes materialize, one standing tall, holding the second, which appears to be unconscious. They step through and the darkness returns.

I say nothing, waiting quietly to see what they do next. The one who is awake — a man, by the sounds of it — utters a single word and a dim globe of light appears in the middle of the hallway between the cells. He carries

the other person towards the cell opposite me and places them inside, laying the figure down on the cot. Both of them have their backs to me; I can't make out any details. The man exits the cell. It's too dark for me to see the new prisoner as the door closes. The man's eyes flit to my cell and his look changes from a serious scowl to a charming smile as our eyes meet.

"You've got to be kidding me," I mutter in disgust.

He laughs, "I know. Embarrassing for you, right?" He gives the other cell door a hard pull to make certain it's locked, then saunters closer. He stops an arm's length away, always a good precaution when dealing with a caged Carl. "You look groggy. Did you just wake up?" he asks.

I say nothing.

"You've eaten, at least. That's good. No drugs, we want you awake and alert from now on. I'm not a horrible host, Carl."

"Whose call was it to do this to me?" I ask.

"Mine," he says. "You've been a bit unpredictable lately."

I laugh, "I've been unpredictable my whole life. That's part of my boyish charm that everyone loves."

He smiles, "I mean unpredictable for you, Carl. She's too important to me right now to allow you to eject her just yet." His eyes move slowly to the cell opposite me, then back.

"Who is?" I ask, but I already know.

"Danielle," he confirms. "It's not an easy thing to remove a Clean Mark, I couldn't have you taking advantage of that before I got some time with her. I assume Daniel told you to make her dead?"

I look at him blankly. He knows I don't break confidences. He shrugs, "Well, if he didn't give the order yet, he soon would have. I need her. Don't worry; when I'm done, I'll let you finish her off. Just sit patiently for a while and we can all get on with our business. What do you say to that, young friend?"

"Why did you bring her here?" I ask. His look told me all I need to know; that's her lying in the other cell.

"Just in case you need to learn her aura signature better," Shane says. "Once I let her go, it's important that you catch and kill her quickly. She'll have information that I don't want shared with others."

"Then kill her yourself," I say.

“It’s a bit complicated, but the truth is I won’t be able to. It will make things messier than they need to be.”

“I don’t know what you’re yapping about,” I say.

“You don’t need to,” Shane snaps. “Just relax a while and keep your mouth shut.”

He glares at me, letting me remember that I’m sitting in a cell. If there’s one creature in the world for me to be afraid of, it’s this old monster. I give him the respect he’s owed and say nothing.

“I’ve got things to do; it’s a busy time right now for me. Some very exciting developments are going on inside the Game. Lots of loose ends for me to tie up before I head out.”

“Head out to where?”

“I think I’m finally going to be able to head back to Tygon.” He looks at Danielle’s cell again. “If this young lady has the skills I think she does, soon I’ll be standing over Brandon Strayne’s broken body.”

“Everyone needs a goal,” I say.

He raises his hand and the doorway appears again. “I’ll leave the lights on for you two. Try not to bore her to death before I get back. I know how much you love to chat.”

He chuckles at his own joke and enters the portal. It stays open for a moment, then disappears. The lights in the hallway get a bit brighter and a small light appears in both my cell and Danielle’s. I look at her and see she’s fully awake; she’s been lying quietly, listening to the two of us talk.

I look at her for a moment. “You feel okay?” I ask.

“What do you care? You’re just going to kill me anyway.”

“I’m ordered to hunt you,” I say. “That gives you a chance to turn it around and kill me, Danielle. And from what I’ve seen over the past few years, you just might be up to the task.”

“I don’t have my Sever Spike with me,” she says.

“Maybe you’ll get it before we face off,” I say.

We sit in silence for quite a while. I try to come up with clever words, but I keep drawing blanks.

“It’s funny that we both wound up here,” I say.

“Not funny for me,” she says. “I get nabbed by some crazy, then I’m thrown into a cell across from my worst enemy. To make matters worse, it looks like you are actually afraid of the nutjob that grabbed me. I don’t

know who he is, but when you bow your head to him, that must mean he's very dangerous."

"He is," I nod.

"I know that after he's done with me, whatever hell that entails, I'm going to have to fight you. I just hope I have the strength to kill you, Carl. I would be very disappointed if I don't succeed in that."

"I'm not going to kill you, Danni." I say.

Her laughter fills the room and continues for a few moments.

"I'm serious," I say. "From now on, you're safe with me."

"You expect me to believe that?" she asks.

"No," I say. "But it's the truth. I have orders, and I follow those orders."

"I just heard him. He's going to order you to kill me. The Devil has likely already given you the same command."

"Yes, but I also have orders to keep you alive, at all costs."

"You have orders to kill me *and* to keep me alive?" she asks.

"Yes," I sigh. "I'm to kill you, and protect you."

We sit quietly for a few moments. Finally she asks, "So what orders do you follow?"

"How well can you see me from over there?" I ask.

"Perfectly," she says.

"Then get closer to the bars. I want you to see something." I push my face against the bars and she gets close to hers. "Timeless are all bound to follow orders in the same manner. There is no discussion when it comes to this point. We follow our eyes. The orders that match my eyes, that's what I follow. Infernals ordered me to kill you, Eternals ordered me to save you."

"Oh, my god," she gasps. "Your eyes!"

I nod my head wearily. Her look confirms what I've been able to hide from everyone but Gabriel. I've seen the red disappear, replaced with gold specks swirling mockingly in my eyes. "Yes, it looks like after all these centuries, I'm to be an Eternal for a while. I'll protect you, Danni. I'll do everything in my power to protect you."

Chapter 50

Miranda

Long before I was taken by Shane, I learned how to wake up without moving or opening my eyes. It's a routine that has come in handy countless times over the years.

Part of the routine involves a greeting from Sparx not long after I wake up.

'Hey come on, I'm awake.' I say. 'I've done my part, now you say something witty or clever like you usually do.'

I remember being in the alley; I open my eyes and sit up. "Sparx?" I say out loud, looking at my surroundings. I'm in a small room, well lit, with cute little pictures hanging on white walls. There's lots of pink, and a small window with a dainty curtain that is keeping out most of the morning light.

The door opens and a young woman walks in; she's Chinese. Shoulder length, straight black hair, pretty round face with long eyelashes and big dark eyes. The tray in her hands holds a teapot and some small treats.

"Hi," I say weakly. "Where am I? And who are you?"

She looks at me politely, then says something in Mandarin. Okay, looks like she doesn't know English. Mandarin is fine. I can speak most dialects from around the world. "I'm sorry, but I don't speak English," she says. "I am glad to see you are awake. Can you understand me?"

"Yes, I can," I say.

"Excellent. Your Mandarin is impeccable. I detect no accent at all. It's like you were born speaking it."

"Thank you." I bow slightly from my seated position. "How did I end up in this room?"

"You collapsed in front of my father's café," she says. "We did not know what to do with you. We brought you to this spare bedroom to allow you to rest and warm up. You were very cold and dirty."

"Thank you," I say. "My leg was injured."

"Yes, once we got you cleaned up I noticed that your leg was damaged. We summoned a healer. It should be fine now."

I look down at my leg and flex the toes to test it out. It appears to be completely healed. “How long have I been here?” I ask.

“Three days,” she replies.

“Where am I?”

“We are in the Longhua District, in the province of Hainan,” she says. “My name is Jing-Wei.”

I visualize a map of China in my head. Wow, I’m in one of the very southernmost parts of China. “I am happy to meet you, Jing-Wei. My name is Miranda.” There’s no point in lying to her.

If she wanted to hurt me she could have done so at any time over the last three days. I wonder how I got here. Shane can create portals; he must have opened one and, from the condition I was in, kicked me out of it.

“Do you have a telephone?” I ask.

“We have access to a cell phone, yes,” she says. “I will go and ask my father if we can borrow it from his cousin.”

“Thank you,” I say. “I will rest a bit more while you go.”

She nods and leaves the tea and snacks on the table beside the bed. I close my eyes and lie back. I hear the door close a few moments later. Taking deep breaths, I begin to meditate, focusing on my body, trying to locate Sparx.

After a few moments, I open my eyes and blink rapidly to keep the tears away. I can detect a presence, but it’s empty. I think they destroyed her circuitry. Sparx is gone.

I lay back in my bed and try to remain calm. Sparx was more than just a sentient nanocomputer, she was my friend. We were together for decades. It’s like part of my soul is gone, a part that I talked with and loved every day; a part that not only shared my life, but added so much to it.

When we volunteered to infiltrate Shane’s lair, it was assumed that I would be the one sacrificing my life. It never occurred to me that he might detect and destroy her instead.

I look around the room once more and see the clothes I was wearing in the alley. They are washed and clean, folded neatly on a chair. There’s a note sitting on top of the pile, I reach over and open it. It must have been in my pants pocket; it’s written in English;

Sorry to cut our time short, Miranda, but I have more pressing matters to attend to. It was a delight to meet you. I enjoyed our brief time together.

Perhaps we will run into each other again and can continue our work; there is much I would like to learn from you, it's a shame this new project requires so much of my focus.

Shane

P.S. Don't worry about your little friend. I'll take very good care of it for you.

I fold the letter into a small square and place it in the palm of my hand, holding it out in front of me. I allow the rage that Shane has stirred in me to focus into a small ball of dull grey energy; it envelops the letter which slowly rises into the air an inch above my palm. The note spins quickly three times, smoking as it spins, then vanishes in a flash of icy light. I brush my hands together and lie back on the bed, trying to think of a plan to get Sparx back from that monster. I'm still tired. I soon fall asleep.

***

I hear the door open again and wake up. It's Jing-Wei and she holds a cell phone in her hand, smiling triumphantly as she walks towards me. I smile as she hands it to me. "Thank you, Jing-Wei."

"You are most welcome, Miranda," she says. "You have the most beautiful eyes. The small flashes of red in them are very remarkable."

I smile at her. "Thanks. They've been like that for a long time, although long ago instead of red, the flecks were gold coloured."

"Truly?" she asks.

I nod as I dial a number on the phone and wait for it to ring. A Chinese operator comes on and asks me for some information; we speak for a few moments and then she connects my call. Eventually it rings and I hear a familiar voice on the other end.

"Hello?"

"Hi, Steph," I say.

"Miranda?" she sounds surprised. "Where are you? Done already? How did it go?"

"I don't think it went well, Stephanie," I say. "As for where I am, It's going to be a bit of a trip to come get me, or send me money to get home."

“Don’t worry, Miranda,” she says. “There is nowhere on Earth that we cannot come to get you.”

“Actually, there is,” I say, remembering the cell somewhere underground that was my home for the past few months. “But right now I’m in China.”

“Give me the details and we’ll come get you.”

“Steph,” I say, “Sparx is… I think Sparx is…” my voice breaks off into a sob.

“Let’s just get you first, Miranda. Sparx is a tough nut; don’t give up on her.”

I take a deep breath, nod silently and swallow. “Okay. Here’s where I am.”

Chapter 51

Tygon

For the people who lived and worked there, VirtDyne was the most secure building in the entire City.

The massive skyscraper was surrounded on all sides by a tiered courtyard, separated from the rest of the city by a 30 foot tall, six foot thick concrete wall. Basic admittance through the gate into the courtyard required a specially issued passcard; unauthorized individuals couldn't even eat lunch in its shadow.

Once you entered the courtyard, the actual building was accessed by massive doors located on all four sides of the building. The North Entrance was for residents, the South for Game-related workers, and the top executives used the West door. Only a handful of people could enter the East door.

As you approached the appropriate door, security cameras would focus on you, verify your passcard, and then scan retinal, DNA, and body profiles to compare against the data stored in the main computer. Security staff would then scan each individual for a list of restricted items; if any of these were found, that person was detained while the authorities came to interview them.

No one protested the intense security process, because this was the nerve centre of the world's most important source of income and entertainment. It was an immense honour to be allowed into the VirtDyne building at all; a person would give up much for a

chance to sleep in one of the most basic apartments for just a single night.

Since its construction decades earlier, not a single person had ever managed to gain unauthorized access to the VirtDyne Building.

That was about to change.

The man walked towards the gates and stood in line to enter. The line moved quickly; when it was his turn, he smiled at the security guard and walked through. His card beeped and a green light flashed on the gate.

He walked towards the South door, the entrance for Game staff. Once again he waited for his turn to enter and walked confidently through. The scanner beeped and flashed a green light, indicating that he belonged there.

There was a directory inside the entrance, but the man didn't stop to examine it. Only newcomers would stop and check the directory out, perhaps gaining the attention of the cameras. He had been fully briefed on the directions to his destination. The man approached an elevator and waited with a small group of people for the door to open. No one acknowledged him; so many people worked in this building that it was easiest to ignore each other. The man blended in perfectly.

The elevator arrived and the group piled in. The elevator began its climb towards the top, interrupted by frequent stops. By the time they had reached the 65th floor, the man was alone in the elevator. A few moments later, the elevator dinged and came to a stop. He checked to make certain that he had arrived at the top floor — not of the building, of course, but the top floor of the Game portion of the skyscraper.

The man got off the elevator and turned left, walking to a bank of offices and swiping his card at a door, entering silently as it beeped and opened to allow him access. He walked to a small desk and sat down. To his right there was a bed; this was a resting room

for Game employees. When activities were so intense that a team member could not leave their player for long, these rooms were available to allow them to catch a few moments of rest.

He checked his watch and nodded, pleased that everything had gone as planned. He had arrived ahead of schedule.

Now to wait patiently.

***

"I can't keep my eyes open," Trew said. They'd been in the command centre for hours, and were no closer to finding Danielle. He looked around the desk at the team. Everyone looked crushed; all attempts to locate her had produced no success. As time sped by inside the Game, no one inside or out was having any luck.

"Go get some sleep," Michelle said. "We'll wake you immediately if we learn anything."

As much as he hated to admit it, Trew knew he needed some sleep. There was only so much a person could do, and he'd reached his limit. "Okay, but don't let me have more than 45 minutes. I'll be ready to take a stimulant again by then."

"Okay," Michelle said. It was obvious that she'd been taking more stimulants than allowed, but she had gotten a few hours of sleep prior to learning that Danielle was taken, so she was fresher than Trew. "Why don't you use one of the resting rooms just down the hall?"

"Good idea." Trew rubbed his eyes and walked to the door. "Good luck. Come get me in 45."

He walked mechanically down the hallway, too tired to think and too stressed to consider the enormity of what was happening in the Game.

Trew took out his card and held it over the door latch to one of the resting rooms. The lock turned green and clicked open. It

wasn't until he had closed the door that he noticed someone was already sitting at the desk inside.

"Oh, I'm sorry," Trew said. "I didn't realize this room was already in use."

The man stood up and smiled. His manner seemed… off, in some small way. Trew's instincts told him something wasn't quite right. He took a step backwards and put his hand on the door.

"That's entirely all right," the man said. "I was just getting ready to go back to work. It's all yours, friend."

Trew opened the door and stood there uncertainly.

"Where are you going? I said it's no problem for you to use the room. Come back in."

The man's tone sounded too eager. "No, it's fine. I can get another room. Have a good night."

Trew turned and walked out of the room and started heading back to the command centre. Immediately he heard the man behind him, walking quickly to catch up.

Trew looked over his shoulder and suddenly time slowed to a crawl. He saw the man reaching into his coat pocket, pulling something out and pointing it at Trew. The man said something, but it sounded long and drawn out, as if it was all happening in slow motion. Trew realized that this man was here to kill him, and he was defenseless standing in this hallway.

Visions of getting in the elevator with Carl came rushing back to him, the feeling of helplessness and impending doom returned.

Trew heard a voice yell out and he instinctively dropped to his knees. The assassin hesitated for a split second, then a brilliant flash of light erupted from his chest, followed by a spraying arc of crimson blood. The assassin grunted and dropped his weapon. He touched his chest and looked at the blood on his hand with confusion.

A second later the assassin hit the ground with a wet thud, he was dead.

Time returned to normal. Trew felt a hand grab him and pull him up. “Are you all right, Trew?” A deep, bass voice said.

Trew looked at the man who had just saved his life. He was tall — about 6’4”, with tanned skin and short cropped, silver-white hair which stood up in a controlled mess on the top of his head. Trew could feel the power in the man’s grip, and see it in his eyes. He held a weapon of some sort in his hand, but Trew didn’t recognize it as being anything he’d ever seen before.

“Hey, bud,” the man said. “Are you okay?”

“Yes, I think so,” Trew said. “Where did you come from? Thank you for saving my life.”

“Glad to do it,” the man said. He smiled an easy, crooked grin and slapped Trew on the back. “That was cutting it a bit close! Don’t tell Brandon the guy actually got his weapon pointed at you when you give him the rundown.”

Trew nodded, still shaken up from the experience. “Who are you?”

The man stuck out his hand. “Name’s Cooper. Sorry to meet you under such circumstances, although this is really the only way we could have met up until now.”

Trew shook the man’s hand, not sure what to say.

“I guess I should run,” The man said. “I can hear others coming. You should be okay from here on out. Tell Brandon I said ‘I told you so.’ This building can be illegally accessed if they want to bad enough. And tell him he owes me a drink next time I see him.”

“Okay,” Trew said, bewildered. “I got your name, but that doesn’t tell me who you are.”

“I’m your Protector, kid,” the man smiled. “Inside the Game they gave you an Eternal. Outside the Game you get something much better — you get me.”

Cooper twisted his right hand in a quick series of motions, and white light began to envelop him. The light disappeared, and so did Cooper.

Chapter 52

From time to time, a player enters the Game and plays a spectacular session. It seems to occur only once or twice in each of Earth's generations, but the impact felt from these avatars causes waves that ripple long after they have exited their play. These events generally involve the artistic and spiritual areas of the Game, not the more mundane aspects of life.

Can you name a great artist, scientist, or singer from Earth history? How about a memorable spiritual figure? I'm certain more than one name just popped into your head.

How about a great factory worker, or cashier or waitress? A name likely doesn't spring to mind, does it?

If everyone could fly, would we be so focused on Melissa and Danielle?

Perhaps a better question is this: If everyone can fly in the Game, how come only Melissa and Danielle are actually doing so?

Anonymous

Brandon listened to the phone ring on the other end of the line. He knew it would ring twelve times before being answered; there was significance to the number, plus it allowed him to change his mind and hang up. The ringing was like a cooling down period to understand the implications of what he was doing. For this call,

he'd already thought long and hard before dialling. He had no desire to hang up as he waited for the twelve rings to occur.

"I must say," his father's voice sounded through the receiver, "I'm surprised you didn't call sooner. Things have been heating up pretty good there."

"I'm only allowed a certain number of calls to you," Brandon said. "It's always a tricky decision as to when to use them. She's still very young in the Game."

Brandon's father chuckled. "Just because we know she can live to 140 doesn't mean that she will live to be 140."

Brandon smiled and said nothing.

"Are you able to navigate the mine fields that are popping up all over the place for you, Son?" he asked. "Danielle is missing and she no longer

has the protection of a Clean Mark. Trew is being targeted for assassination on Tygon. The most dangerous Infernal killer on Earth is nowhere to be found. Shane is in play, and showing a very active interest in your player. Does that cover most of the high points?”

“You left out Miranda,” Brandon said.

“She’s not related to the others.” His father paused. “Is she related to the others, Brandon?”

“Everything is tied together in some way or other, Father."

“She’s lost her nano companion?”

“That is uncertain at the moment,” Brandon said.

“What aspects are out of your control? Off the tracks when it comes to your plan?”

“I don’t know, which is why I’m calling you.”

“My boy, I’m amazed at the amount of pieces that you’re currently juggling. I haven’t even mentioned Sylvia or the other new God that seems to be stirring on Tygon. Then there’s this new religion on Tygon. You really deserve to be where you are at this moment, even if you fail in the long run, which seems very

probable. Just to watch you in action… you are a true artist, my boy.”

Brandon laughed. “Thank you, Father, that's as close to a compliment as I’ve gotten from you in a long time.”

“What can I do for you?”

“Did Cooper really step in and save Trew?” Brandon asked.

“Yes,” his father said.

There was a pause as Brandon considered his next words. “There’s a price for his involvement,” he said.

“Yes, there is.”

“I need payment deferred,” Brandon said.

“That’s not possible,” his father replied. “There are some things even you can’t manipulate, Son. Deferring payment for Cooper getting involved is one of those things.”

“Father, everything can be manipulated,” Brandon said. “for the right price.”

“What are you suggesting?”

“An offer too good to be refused…”

Chapter 53

Danielle

" What are you doing?" I can hear noise from Carl's cell. He's in the far corner with his back to me. I should be glad for these moments; he spends most of his time leaning against the front of his cell watching me with those new eyes of his. I really don't know enough about Timeless. Should I feel safe with him now that he's an Eternal? From the little I *do* know, Eternals can still do nasty things. It's not as clear cut as red eyes equals bad and gold eyes means they only do good.

His cheerful disposition certainly hasn't changed. "I'm preparing a gourmet meal," he says, continuing to make noise.

We've been in here for 25 days. I can't believe I'm about to say this, but this has been the most boring 25 days of my life! Nothing's happened — nothing painful or ominous, at least. Carl says to be glad for the peace and quiet. He hasn't said too much about Jason — his real name is Shane — but when he talks about him, I can tell he's concerned. That alone is enough to make me nervous. I remember watching Star Wars and thinking how scary Darth Vader was, until they introduced the Emperor. A few days ago I called him Darth Vader. He wasn't too amused.

Three times a day a person appears out of the darkness down the hall. They remove our empty food trays and replace them with new ones. They never say a word. Sometimes it's a man, other

times a woman. They look like inmates in some kind of asylum, mechanically doing their task, then shuffling back into the darkness. The first few times I tried to speak with them, but they don't say a single word. I don't bother any more.

Carl has been… different. I think he's genuinely nervous. He spends a few hours every day with his back to me in the corner. Sometimes I can hear noise, other times nothing. I think he's trying to dig his way out. From what he's said, if he gets free, he will do his best to take me with him.

We've spent quite a bit of time talking. Twenty-five days with no one else to talk to… I guess we were bound to agree to put our differences aside for now. He's still an arrogant bastard and I've made it clear that I still

intend to kill him with the Sever Spike. He's made it clear that he can't wait for me to try.

I try to be more like Trew; he was always fascinated with people, asking them questions and then sincere follow-up questions to find out as much about their lives and struggles and hopes and dreams as he could. I think that was one of the things that made people want to be around him so much.

Trew would have been fascinated by Carl, that's for sure. It's been tough to get much out of him, but when he does let his guard down and really talk about parts of his life, well, he's seen some amazing things.

I've reciprocated and shared parts of my life with him. He sounds pleased and genuinely surprised at some of the stuff I've done. The other day I told him a story and he laughed for a long time. There were tears coming from his eyes as he pictured the scene I described. When he finally stopped laughing, he said something that surprised me. Wiping his eyes, the laughter slowly fading from his lungs, he said. "You know, I'm glad you've lived an exciting life, Danni. I think you've made the world a better place for having been in it, which is a rare thing in this Game."

I smiled and said, "Ya think so?"

He looked at me seriously, then nodded his head. "Absolutely. So many come here to play, full of grand visions and plans before they get here, then they end up wasting it."

"Wasting what?" I asked.

"All of it." He looked disgusted. "The entire friggin' opportunity. Fortune favours the bold; too bad so many of them fall prey to becoming meek."

"Maybe they want to be meek because of the famous quote, 'The meek shall inherit the Earth.'"

He'd looked at me with a sly smile. "You're right on the quote, but the real definition of meek intended for that quote has been forgotten. When I say meek I mean the current and incorrect version — the pathetic and weak type of meek."

"How do you know what the original quote meant?" I asked.

"Girl, I helped write some of that stuff when it was just loose pages."

"You wrote parts of the Bible?" I didn't believe him.

He nodded, “And the Quran, and the Book of the Dead, and the Vedas, I’ve helped write parts of all of them.”

“No way,” I said.

He laughed, then told me a story of how he’d come to write a particular set of passages from one of these books. I sat there silently for hours, listening to him tell me such a detailed story it would fill a book. After he was done, I continued to stare at him in silence.

“What?” he growled. “Stop looking at me like that. Still don’t believe me?”

“I believe you,” I said. It was impossible not to. “It’s just such a shame that no one will ever know about your life. If one little story is so rich with entertainment and details, what must the rest of it be like?”

“It’s been all right,” he said with a grin. “I’ve had a good play. No regrets when you put the spike in my eye and send me on my next adventure.”

“Don’t you get tired?” I asked.

“Sometimes,” he said. “But then I just sleep and wake up refreshed and ready to go.”

I laughed. The more I spoke with him, the easier it was to see him as a regular man. I wasn’t sure if I liked this feeling or not, but decided I could hate him again when we were free of this place. For now, we were the last two people on Earth, and I didn’t want to be alone. As long as he behaved, I would too.

“There,” Carl says, interrupting my reflection from the other day and bringing me back to the present. “Prime rib with Yorkshire pudding and gravy. Should be ready in half an hour.” Carl has finished whatever he does in the back of his cell and moves up to sit next to the bars.

“Sounds yummy,” I say as I move next to my bars and lean against them.

We sit quietly for a while, each waiting for the other to speak. It’s usually me who breaks the silence; he says he doesn’t need to talk. But I can tell he does.

“It must be horrible for you,” he says.

“What’s that?” I ask.

“Knowing with so much certainty what lies beyond this world.”

“Not at all,” I say. “It’s comforting to know that there’s more than this. Knowing that when we leave this life, we go to another place and continue on.”

“You know what it’s called? The next place?” he asks.

“Tygon,” I answer.

“That’s right,” he nods. “Well, I’ve lived on Tygon, and I remembe*r* living there. Would you like to hear a little story?”

“Sure,” I say. “I have time.”

“This is the story of a man named Harry. He was born on Tygon and lived a boring, unremarkable life. The first 25 years were disappointing by anyone’s standards. Born and raised by parents who were too busy living their own lives, trying to work so they could earn just enough money to put a roof over their heads and food in all of their bellies. They always wanted more, but no matter how hard they tried, they couldn’t seem to get ahead.”

“Sounds much like Earth,” I say.

“Indeed,” he replied. “ Harry went to school and quietly became part of the herd. They taught him the basics of math, science, and art. He showed an aptitude for art, but his teachers discouraged pursuing that avenue. All teachers are trained to discourage artists. ‘The jobs are in math and science, Harry,’ they said. Young Harry blindly believed them and obediently focused on that direction of pursuit.

He attended secondary school and then college, graduating with a degree in computer programming, convinced that the world was his oyster. He was certain that he would do better than his parents, make lots of money, buy everything he ever dreamed of having, and make the most of his life. How do you think that turned out for him?”

“Not very well?” I guess.

“Not very well,” Carl confirms.

“Harry turned out to be just as unremarkable as everyone else who lived in the world of Tygon. It wasn’t entirely his fault — he was the product of years of precise and controlled systems. Those who controlled Tygon wanted the majority to be unremarkable people who didn’t think too much, want too much, or try too hard. Good little automatons was what society needed, that’s what they trained people to be, and that’s what Harry was.”

“Sounds familiar,” I say with regret.

“Yes, this could be a normal Earth child’s story,” Carl says. “One of the ways to keep the people asleep,” he continues, “is by giving

them games to play. Games of all sorts and types, but over time they discovered that computer games worked the best. They grab a person’s full attention, allowing them to entirely forget about their pointless, miserable lives until it’s time to wake up and go back to their jobs. Then when they’re at their jobs, they don’t sit and complain about their crappy existence, they think about how fun it will be to get home so they can go back to playing their games.

“The more popular they got, the more complex and realistic the computer games became. Designing and building games required only a few great minds to come up with the ideas, but many mediocre minds were needed to implement the tedious details necessary to build the intricate games. Harry is one such

mediocre mind. He works for a top computer company, doing small mindless tasks with the rest of his teammates to produce the finished product, a brilliant game for the masses. In order to

understand the games they work on, staff members are encouraged to play the games themselves in their off time. Harry plays them with his colleagues, and he does very well — much better than the average player. Perhaps it’s because playing requires finesse, touch, creativity, the mind of an artist. Harry’s mind is that of an artist, and almost by accident it’s given the opportunity to work and thrive in the new setting.

One day, after years of working for the company, Harry gets exciting news from his superiors. He’s invited to become a beta developer on new games. Harry is excited, not because he’ll do more complex programming, or that he will earn more money, which he will. Harry will get to beta test the newest games before they go live. Can you guess which company he works for, Danni?”

“No,” I say.

“The company is called VirtDyne,” Carl says. He pauses to look at me, but I don’t recognize the name. He smiles and continues to give me clues. “The game that he is invited to work on and then

beta test is the newest cutting edge game on Tygon. It’s called the Game of Life at first, but not long after it goes live, everyone simply refers to it as ‘The Game.’”

“That name rings a bell,” I say.

“Yes, I thought it might,” he says. “Harry enters beta testing and is brilliant. He knows this is a game, and the combination of a lifetime of experience playing games, writing computer code, and his true artistic mind enable him to find glitches, play and unlock scenarios that the average beta tester can’t even get close to, and really shine.”

“Sounds like Harry has found his calling,” I say.

“His bosses say the same thing. On the Game’s fifth and final beta test run, Harry is invited to join a special group of testers, an elite bunch of programmers and players who are asked to really beat the hell out of the Game; to come up with new scenarios and ideas to turn the world on its head. He does better than expected, destroying previous records, finding bugs in the mechanics of how the universe was built, and garnering a long list of high performance results. Then he exits the Game, and just prior to it going live, he gets to meet the man himself, Brandon Strayne.”

“The creator of the Game,” I say.

“Indeed,” Carl says. “The meeting turns out to be an incredible opportunity for Harry. After a very expensive and lavish night out on the town — Brandon is a generous host — they offer Harry a special opportunity. A chance to re-enter the Game with the first wave of players, not as a mind-wiped student, but as a special player.”

“A Timeless,” I guess.

“That’s what Brandon calls them. A small, powerful group of players who cannot age or die; only physical violence can kill them, and that is such a rarity that for all intents and purposes Timeless can live for hundreds, even thousands of years. This is the opportunity of a lifetime for a man like Harry, a boring regular

guy on Tygon; the chance to become a powerful, long-lived individual in the Game. He already knows how real the Game is; he’s beta tested it in all its aspects. By the time they tell him the one small detail, that when he does die inside the Game he won’t be able to return to Tygon, that his soul will have no body to return to, he can barely hear what they are saying. There’s no hesitation in his mind as he gladly shakes Brandon’s hand and accepts the position.”

Carl takes a drink from his metal cup, then sits looking at me. After a few moments of silence, it appears he’s finished. “Wow,” I say. “That’s a

great story."

"It is," he nods.

"I see what you mean," I say. "Harry doesn't look forward to leaving this life, because he knows he has no body to return to and will cease to exist."

"No, little one," Carl says patiently. "He dreads the thought of going back to that droll, boring, pointless existence. Here in the Game he is so much more; to wake up back in that life on Tygon, that would be hell for him. He's one of the few lucky ones. A Timeless wins both ways; they live for a long time with special powers in the Game, and they don't have to return to Tygon when they finally do die."

"But they cease to exist," I say.

"You don't know that," he says. "What if they are the only ones allowed to go to a real heaven? Religion here says many souls die and go to hell; perhaps they are talking about Tygon."

I don't like the sounds of that. "Maybe you're right," I say, afraid that he is.

We sit silently for a while; he doesn't appear to be thinking about much. All I can think about is the new possibility he just raised. Just like that, I think I want to live this life for as long as I can.

"Thank you for the story," I say. "It's a very personal thing to talk about."

"What is?" he asks.

"Who you were on Tygon, and how you became a Timeless," I say.

Carl looks confused for a moment, then he chuckles. "Ah, darlin', That wasn't *my* story. Didn't you hear the main character's name? It was about Harry."

"Oh," I say. "I assumed it was about you."

"Nope, it was about a Brother named Harry. He told it to me one day, to pass the time."

"Is he an Infernal or Eternal at the moment?" I ask.

"At the moment? He's dead," Carl says. "Sent him on his way to the next great adventure myself, about 140 years ago."

"Oh."

"Yeah," Carl says. "Harry's life on Tygon was paradise compared to mine."

Chapter 54

Danielle Radfield has suddenly disappeared inside the Game. What many thought to be a minor, short term signal loss has turned into a channel of constant static.

Trew assures us that she hasn't perished; authorities confirm that her body is still alive and well on the stasis table, indicating that she's still alive inside the Game. So where is she? Normal events inside the Game are always witnessed; if she had been in an accident and is now in a coma somewhere, we would see images that players in a coma project. If she was blindfolded or drugged we would witness signals and pictures, though they would be hazy and confused. It appears someone or something has interfered with her signal, not a common occurrence.

Some suggest that she was abducted by Infernals and is being held for some terrible purpose, perhaps being tortured and beaten. Another popular theory is that the group responsible for the mass annihilation of the Gamer movement has her.

No matter where she is, we hope she is safe and becomes visible to fans across Tygon soon.

If you would like to join your local area group forming a vigil for Danielle, they can be found on the infoweb by searching for the term 'Danielle is gone.'

Lisa Rohansen - Game Channel

Danielle

We're like caged animals in a zoo. We measure time by the number of feedings we get. I keep track separate from Carl; every few feedings, one of us will check with the other to make certain that we still agree on the count. If we get fed three times a day, which both of us guess, then today is the 25th day of our captivity.

The cloaked inmate has just dropped our meal off. I grab the tray and bring it back to my bed. A few moments after I start to eat, my senses announce something is different, something subtle, what is it…?

I don't hear the shuffling feet of the inmate walking away.

I look up and the cloaked figure stands in front of my cell. I can't make out the face, but the height suggests it is a man. His bearing is different from the regular food delivery person, more confident and self-aware. Before I can say anything, the hooded figure speaks.

"Pretty boring so far, right?" he says.

I continue to pick at my food, remaining outwardly calm, but inside I want to rush the bars and grab him by the throat. "Nothing to complain about so far, Jason. Or should I call you Shane?"

He chuckles. It isn't a pleasant sound. "You should call me neither," he says. "You stole my name; you should call me that."

I smile. "Fallen?" I ask

He nods.

"I know a man named Edward. When they had a baby boy, they named the child Edward as well. It's possible for more than one person to have the same name, you know."

"Bad analogy." He shakes his head. "Here's a much better one. I knew a man who was a king. Another person in the kingdom decided that he would also be called king. That did not end well for the second person. It's not possible for a kingdom to have two kings."

"That is a better analogy, I suppose," I say. "There are many countries in the world where the ruler is called king. They don't kill each other or demand that all but one renounce the title."

Shane laughs out loud. "That is simply because they lack the might to do so, Danielle," he says. "Every king in history worth his salt has dreamed of ruling the world." He leans forward and whispers, "I happen to be mighty enough to be the only Fallen, and my title doesn't encompass a small area of land; my domain is the entire planet. Has been for thousands of years."

"So you took me because I called myself Fallen?" I ask. "Sounds a bit petty."

"I can be that way sometimes," he says. "The prerogative of a powerful person."

"We could have cleared this all up if you'd visited sooner," I say. "By all means, you go ahead and call yourself Fallen."

"Very generous of you; my thanks." he says.

I wave my hand. “Sure, no problem. Now if you’ll just unlock this cage and pop me back home, I’ll bid you goodbye and hope I never see your face again.”

“As much as I would like to accommodate that request,” he says, “since I have you here, there are a couple other issues that I would like to address.”

“Such as?” I ask.

“All in good time, little one,” he says, “all in good time. We’ve accomplished a lot for one visit. I will come back soon to discuss the next issue.”

He smiles and waves, then begins to walk slowly towards the shadows. I watch him go, but just before he reaches the area where they disappear, he stops and looks upwards. “Oh, yes,” he turns around. “I almost forgot the other item on my to-do list for today.”

He saunters back, stops in the middle of the hall and looks me in the eye. “Carl?” he says. “Step forward into the light, if you would be so kind.”

I look over at Carl’s cell and watch as he steps forward, his eyes slightly downcast, his posture non-threatening; not how I’m used to seeing him.

“All the way to the bars, Carl,” Shane says. “I know about your eyes. It’s time I got a nice look at them.”

Carl sighs and steps up to the bars, raising his eyes to meet Shane’s. Shane steps closer and peers intently into Carl’s eyes.

“I knew there would be a price to pay,” Shane says, “when I lifted the Clean Mark from Danielle. I was surprised to find out just how big a price was exacted.” He reaches in and grabs Carl by the chin, gently turning his head from side to side. “I apologize, my old friend,” he says. “I know how much you enjoyed

being an Infernal. You were one of the few to have only served one side. Considering how long you’ve been around, it’s an impressive record that will be difficult to break.”

“Yeah,” Carl says. “It’s too bad the Timeless don’t care about the past. It’s all about today and tomorrow.”

“Exactly.” Shane lets his hand drop. “Perhaps you will survive this and come back to the correct side of the struggle.”

“One can only hope,” Carl says.

“Indeed.” Shane continues to stare at Carl, but he addresses me. “The universe really does have a sense of humour, Danielle. I remove your Clean Mark so I can have Carl kill you; he suddenly becomes an Eternal and is ordered to save you.”

“Put the mark back on me,” I say. “Maybe he will change back.”

“Perhaps,” he says, “but likely not. Sylvia is a clever adversary; I will have to make my next move very carefully.”

He turns on his heels and begins to walk toward the shadows. “I hope you enjoyed the first part of your stay, kids,” he says. “This was the boring but necessary part. The next phase involves pain.

Lots of pain. Carl can fill you in if you want some advance preparation.” He disappears into the shadows.

I look at Carl and see a new emotion in his eyes. It’s an emotion I never thought to see from him.

Fear.

Chapter 55

“Trew, with so many other players to watch inside the Game, why do you think Danielle is the most popular character currently playing?”

“I think the answer to that question is very simple, Lisa. Everyone is watching Danielle because they can sense her actions inside the Game will affect all of us outside.”

“Do you believe that, Trew?”

“Do you, *Lisa?”*

“Yes, I truly do.”

Excerpt from morning coffee chat with Trew

Miranda

I forgot how lonely it is, to be alone inside my head.

I sip green tea and look out the window. I’ve been safe and sound with Stephanie and Raphael for the past three weeks. We are all scrambling to find Danielle; I was disappointed to arrive and learn that she had been abducted by Shane.

While we search, Steph has been helping me try to find out what happened. There’s no point in trying to fully debrief me; I barely remember anything. The plan was for Sparx to record it all and play it back when the mission was complete. The true plan was that Sparx would escape to fully share my suicide mission — a

mission that was a failure from all angles. I’m alive, which was the best case scenario, but we don’t have Shane or even any useful intel on him, and Sparx is gone.

The door knocks softly. “Come in,” I say.

The door opens and Stephanie walks in. She looks around and moves to the tea set by the window. There is an extra cup and she begins to make herself some tea. “Morning, Miranda. How are you feeling today?”

“Nervous,” I say. “Do you have the latest scan results?”

She nods. “I do. Let’s grab a seat and discuss what they report.”

We both move to the dainty table and chairs sitting in front of another window. I look at her with concern. “Anything positive to report?” I ask.

“Yes,” she says. “The scan detects a presence in you still, a molecular match for Sparx as we know her.”

“Where is it located, and how come I can’t sense it when I meditate?” I have always been able to sense Sparx in my body. Closing my eyes and entering an advanced state of focused meditation allows me to

sense where she is and communicate with her. Since I woke up in China I haven’t been able to sense her that way.

“Right shoulder, the exact spot she was programmed to return to if there were ever any problems and she couldn’t communicate.” I nod with some relief. The idea was for her to return to a spot where we could find and extract her if she ever went inactive and we couldn’t repair her from inside of me.

“Are we going to extract her, then? See if we can bring her back online?”

“We observed that Sparx is still online,” Steph says. “All diagnostic probes indicate that she is working properly as intended.”

“She’s not working properly as intended,” I say. “She won’t respond to me.”

“That’s true, but she is definitely communicating with someone, and her security systems are also armed. If we try to remove Sparx,”

“Then I explode into a spray of fine mist,” I say.

“Yeah,” Steph says. “It’s a bit of a problem.”

We sit for a few moments and say nothing, sipping our tea as the words sink in.

“I should leave, then,” I say.

“That’s not a good idea, Miranda,” Steph says.

“Staying isn’t a good idea,” I say. “What if Sparx is reporting everything I see, think, hear, and say? Shane will be able to spy on us, which can’t be good. I should leave.”

“There are ways to neutralize Sparx’s security systems,” Steph says.

I shake my head negatively, “Those methods involve destroying her.”

“Look, I know you don’t want her to be wiped out, but what other choice do we have? You have no place to go; Sparx is no longer in our control and a danger to all of us.”

“Sparx contains too much knowledge. We can’t afford to lose her,” I say. “There must be a way to get her back. Come on, Steph, you helped me

design her. Just because you've spent the last 50-plus years on guard duty doesn't mean your brain turned to mush. Help me think of a way to save Sparx."

Steph sips her tea. Finally she asks me a question. "How big is she?"

"64 quantum bits large." I say.

"64 Qbits, huh? That isn't very large at all."

I laugh. "Perhaps not for most things, but to get a quantum entanglement of 64 atoms is way beyond the scope of regular people. I think the record out there right now is 14."

"I wish she was only 14. Then perhaps we could pull off what I'm thinking."

"Which is?" I ask.

"Teleporting her out of you."

I think about what she's proposing, then I nod my head. "That just might work. When we teleport her, she might very well reset, which would break the control Shane is exerting on her at the moment. If it doesn't…"

"Then she will explode," Stephanie says, "but safely outside of your body."

"First problem," I say, "We don't have a place that can do it."

"Yes, we do." Stephanie smiles.

"Okay, moving quickly to the second problem. There is no way we will be allowed to try it. That will change the universal laws of physics too much, I don't think humans are ready for this kind of breakthrough in physics."

"Please," Stephanie says. "For the past few hundred years they have been on the entirely wrong path. Some brilliant minds got the dialogue started, but in the past fifty years the intelligence pool has gotten very shallow. They are way overdue to realize their current models are not correct. We will just help push some clever young scientist towards understanding that, which could still take decades."

"Okay, fine," I say. "It's an option. Any other ideas? Good ones that don't involve advancing humanity a thousand years forward with one or two days of cheating work?"

Stephanie thinks for a few moments, then begins to laugh.

"What's so funny?" I ask.

"I forgot about Samantha," she says.

“What about her?” I ask.

“She discovered a talent not long ago. She can communicate with technology.”

“How well?” I ask.

“I’m not sure. Last time we spoke she was able to turn things on and off, initiate movement and simple commands. She was very encouraged by her results; I think she’s been practicing quite a bit.”

“Practice is always good,” I smile. “Perhaps you can go talk to her and see what she is able to do.”

“Want to come with me?” she asks.

“Yes,” I reply. “But it’s not a good idea. If Sparx is active and reporting back to Shane, then I don’t want them to hear any more than necessary. Just go get it done and let me know how it turns out.”

“Gotcha,” she says. “Will you still help us look for Danni in the meantime?”

“I don’t want to give that bastard anything for free just by watching me in action.”

“So you sit up here and drink tea until we can get this under control?”

“Exactly,” I say. “I trade one jail for another. So hurry the hell up and get Samantha to help me.”

Chapter 56

Carl

I have to hand it to him, the man sure does know how to dish out pain.

He's had me in this small room for the past… I don't know, maybe two hours. He started with small physical stimulation, nothing too invasive. I'm not bleeding or missing limbs or appendages. Nothing seems to be broken, but he does know how to bend the body to the most painful extremes.

Then he started in with the psychic pain.

It's always amazed me how sensitive our energy fields are when manipulated. Even a no-talent, fully dull human will weep and beg like a baby when you start to manipulate their aura.

Yeah, Shane's a master, all right.

He should be. The man's had over five thousand years to practice and hone his talents.

I try to think of other things as he tortures me. He must be happy to see that I turned; I know he boasts that he never has. I think it's because his eyes don't denote one clear side or the other, but his actions always lean towards Infernal. Over the centuries, Shane always seemed perturbed that I'd been an Infernal for so long. Well, that ship officially sailed. I'm a goody two shoes at the moment, which is painful enough on its own.

Ahh, there he goes, turning up the dial a bit. Still, nothing I can't handle. On a scale of 1 to 10, for a normal person this would be a 12. I cry out and scream and sweat and weep. That's all involuntary; there's not much I can do to stop these reactions. It's actually a waste of energy to try. Let the body do its thing to eliminate the excess misery, allowing me to focus on keeping my core sane spark intact. The real goal of the master torturer is to make you lose control, to splinter your mind into so many pieces that your sanity flees. That's when the interrogator wins, after that they just take their time to pick up the pieces, asking you whatever they want because you no longer possess the strength to resist them.

It's been a long time since I broke. I was young and had no idea what was happening. I learned a lot. There aren't many on Earth who could succeed in doing it to me now.

Unfortunately, I’m lying on the table of the most skilled master in the world.

“That’s it for today, old friend,” Shane says. He walks to the table across the room and pours a glass of water, then brings it back to me and holds it to my lips. I drink greedily, not sure what his angle is. Never one to mince words, I come straight out and ask.

“What do you mean, that’s it? I expected to be here for a lot longer. You can dish out more than this, I’ve had novices get lucky and make me twitch more.”

Shane chuckles at the insult. We both know I’m lying.

“I didn’t bring you here to torture you,” he says. “I simply wanted to show you what the first session is going to be like.”

Oh, crap. I hope I’m not understanding him correctly.

He smiles and nods his head. “That’s right, Carl. This will be Danielle’s first session on the table. You did fine; how do you think she will fare?”

“You’re insane,” I say. “If you put her through this on her first session, she won’t make it to a second.”

Shane looks at me and frowns. “Oh, I’m sure she will. I’m very good at this, Carl. She will spend days with me — weeks, even. Each day will be just a bit worse than the last. Eventually I’ll break her, but before I do she will suffer more than anyone I’ve ever had on my table.”

I look at him blankly. If he sees how much this upsets me, then he’ll be able to use it against me. “It’s your show,” I say. “You want to break her like that, no one can stop you.”

“That’s right, no one can.” Shane says. “I’ll come for her sometime after the sixth meal has been delivered. I’m looking forward to it.”

“We done here, then?” I ask.

He smiles at me for a few moments, then nods. He goes to the door and opens it. An inmate shuffles in and removes me from the table, slinging me over his shoulder. Shane says nothing more as the inmate takes me through the shadow doorway back to my cell.

***

Shane went to the sink, removed his gloves and threw them into the garbage, then washed his hands methodically. He dried them with a towel and walked over to a nearby monitor hanging on the wall.

The screen came on, displaying Seven in his cell. “Feedback indicates everything went well, Master.” Seven said.

“Excellent,” Shane nodded. “Let’s hope we’ve given him proper incentive.”

***

She looks concerned as the inmate dumps me onto my cot. I lay there quietly as he shuffles out, locks the door, and disappears down the hall.

“You okay?” she asks.

“I’ve been better,” I say.

“What did they do to you?” I can hear the fear in her voice.

“They tried to get information out of me,” I lie.

“How bad was it?” she asks.

“I’ve experienced worse,”

“Will they come for me next?”

There’s no way she can handle what Shane just did to me. She shouldn’t have to.

Maybe me being an Eternal is a good thing after all.

“Not if I can help it, Danni,” I say. Six meals. The idiot told me that to try and hurt me. What he really did was give me a time limit. I’m ready now, anyway.

“I need some rest,” I say. “You have plans after our dinner meal tomorrow?”

She laughs. “Not really. What did you have in mind?”

“The roast that I’ve been working on in the back of my cell.” The hole there, carefully dug away to remove the metal lining behind the stone wall.

“It’s finally ready?” she asks.

“Yeah. It’s time to get you out of here, Danni.”

Chapter 57

Trew

“ Where are we going?”

“Out.”

“That’s a little vague.” Trew watched Brandon in the mirror of the elevator. “Danni's missing and there’s a ton of problems happening inside the Game right now. We can’t afford to leave.”

“We can’t help with any aspect of the Game at this point in time,” Brandon pointed out. We may as well get out for a few hours and take care of something on Tygon that needs to be done. You haven’t left the building since you were ejected from the Game, Trew. An hour out will do you good.”

“I don’t like it,” Trew said.

“Noted,” Brandon said. “Now come on. The rules have changed for someone and he needs to hear it.”

“Who?” Trew asks.

“You’ll see in a few minutes.”

The two men arrived in the main lobby and walked towards the exit. When they reached the doors, Brandon stopped. “Okay, walk outside by yourself. I won’t be far behind.”

“Is it safe?” Trew was aware that people wanted him dead. He didn’t know exactly who yet, but it was obvious from the failed attempt of a few hours ago.

“Of course not,” Brandon said. “Now go out and wait for me at the main gate.”

Trew could tell from Brandon’s look that things were under control, Brandon wasn’t going to knowingly put Trew in danger. He nodded and walked out the door.

He’d taken two steps when he felt a slight hum and a presence beside him. “What the hell is he doing letting you go out by yourself?” Cooper asked angrily.

“Where did you just come from?” Trew asked.

“From the place I disappeared to earlier,” Cooper said. “Where ya going, Leader Man?”

Trew laughed. Cooper had a way of sounding angry and playful at the same time. He was guessing that the man was both lethal and gentle in equal portions, and he didn’t want to be on the wrong end of that spectrum. “I was instructed to walk to the gate and wait for Brandon,” Trew said.

“He’s close by?” Cooper asked. When Trew nodded, Cooper shook his head in disgust. “Bloody waste of a summon, then, when Brandon is near, you’re as safe as you can be with me.”

“I needed you to appear, jackass!” Brandon shouted from the front door. As soon as Cooper heard him he began to move his fingers, summoning the doorway back into the light that he came from. “Hold on, don’t

go anywhere!” Brandon held up his hands. Cooper reluctantly dropped his hands to his sides and waited beside Trew as Brandon approached.

“What. In. The. Hell. Do you think you’re doing?” Cooper appeared extremely angry with Brandon, which made Trew want to ask why. The tension was thick, so he decided to keep his mouth shut.

“Trying to get your attention,” Brandon said. “Do you know how difficult you are to contact once you’re in the field?”

“Yes, boy.” Cooper’s jaw was clenched together very tightly. He didn’t appear to be angry at Brandon, but he was certainly angry

about something. “I know *exactly* how difficult I am to contact. That is one hundred percent the point. Did you hit your head, Brandon? Are you ready for the repercussions that will be caused by this?”

“Of course I am,” Brandon said.

The answer seemed to startle Cooper. His mouth snapped shut with an audible click and his look changed from anger to sadness. “Don’t, boy. I am good at what I do; I’ll disappear and pretend we didn’t talk. I can make that a reality, but I need to go now.” He started to make hand gestures again, summoning bright whiteness around him.

“It’s already done, Cooper. Price negotiated and agreed upon. The next phase has been initiated.”

Cooper’s hands dropped limply to his sides, his shoulders slouched slightly, and he looked first at Brandon, then at Trew. He appeared disappointed.

“There’s that little time left, then?” he asked.

“Time’s running out,” Brandon said with a nod of his head.

Cooper nodded, looked around, then pointed to a nearby stone table. “May I?” he asked.

“Sure,” Brandon said.

Cooper sighed and walked over to the table. “Where’s he going?” Trew asked.

“To vent.” Brandon said.

Cooper screamed loudly and struck the table with his right fist. There was a loud thud as his fist met the stone surface. Trew was sure he must have broken his hand. The table began to shiver and make a whining sound. In the space of a couple heartbeats, it quickly dissolved into a fine powder and began to blow away in the wind like a bag of flour had just been thrown upwards. Cooper walked back to join the two men.

“Okay,” he said to Brandon, “give me the rundown.”

“You’re here full-time, with Trew whenever I’m not. Level one security. Any problems, you kill first, ask questions as a third or fourth option.”

“That it?”

“No,” Brandon said. “Trew gets the full package.”

“Why?” Cooper asked. “It’s a waste of time.”

“He gets it, and lose the attitude. It’s not a waste of time.”

“What’s the full package?” Trew asked.

“It’s complicated and you wouldn’t understand it if I told you,” Brandon said. “You will learn in small snippets what it means. You need to walk before you learn to run.”

“It looked like Lohkam would be first to this stage, Brandon.” Cooper said. “He’s going to be pissed.”

“Please,” Brandon snorted. “Lohkam was never any good. If you put money on him, that was a fool’s bet.”

Cooper chuckled. “Oh, I put my money on you, boy. I was just telling you what it looked like up until a few moments ago.”

Trew glanced from one man to the other in confusion. “I have no idea what you two are talking about.”

“That’s fine,” Cooper said. “We shouldn’t be talking about this right now, anyway. Okay, Trew, you heard the man. I’m with you as much as I

need to be." He looked at Brandon. "Are we going to see him now?"

"Yes, it's as good a time as any," Brandon said. "There's a brief lull in the Game so we can afford to be away for one hour, perhaps two."

Cooper nodded. "Let's go, then."

"Go where?" Trew asked.

"You've got a real live flier on Tygon, kid. Let's go meet him."

Chapter 58

I think everyone should read the chapter about success in George Knight's (Trew's) book 'The Game Is Life.' In it, he states that success leaves clues; the best way to achieve something is to find others who have done the same thing and follow their example. Spending time with Melissa was an incredible opportunity, and a perfect illustration of Trew's point, although I didn't realize it at the time.

As far as the specifics of flying, for me it all seems to boil down to the mind. Meditation and mindset are absolutely crucial; you need to believe with everything you are that you can do it. It's difficult to put into words. When you think about flying you can't say to yourself, 'Yes, I can do it.' Instead you have to think, 'Yes, I do *fly. I flew earlier and I'll fly later as well.' I'm not sure if that makes sense or not, but it is a key point for achieving success, in this and all goals.*

The line between the dream and reality must disappear in order for one to become the other. If you tell yourself that soon you will fly, you never will, because you will never live in 'soon.'

That's the mental part of it.

Yes, there is also a physical part to it. Do you know that birds have hollow bones which make them light enough to fly? If you were to fill a bird's bones with lead or some other non-lethal material which increased their weight, I don't think they could fly. We fill our bodies up with poisons of all sorts, effectively killing our chances to soar. I take one sip of a product that contains aspartame and I sink to the ground like a deflated balloon. Yes, I know aspartame is a deadly

poison not fed to anyone on Tygon, but on Earth it's put in everyone's food and drink, so I knew I could try a sip here and not die. I won't have any more, I promise. Yes, I know how dangerous it is.

My point is that there is a mind and body component to flying. I may be the first one on Tygon to fly, but I won't be the last, and I wouldn't have achieved it if it wasn't for Melissa.

She wouldn't have achieved it if it wasn't for Trew. Of course, she does deserve most of the credit.

Interview with Andrew Young, Tygon's first flying citizen

“ I don’t remember Andrew from the Game,” Trew said. Brandon, Cooper, and Trew were enjoying a drink in the back of the private transport as it drove towards the boy’s home.

“I pulled his record,” Brandon said. “There was nothing special to speak of. He’s just beginning to play as a human, but he did very well. His avatar joined your movement and he spent some time with Melissa. Based on the amount of time he spent with her, I’m surprised that he brought enough information or motivation back with him to become our first flying citizen.

“That’s the thing about progress and miracles,” Cooper said. “You just never know where they’re going to come from, or when. Your Game being so damned true to this reality, that’s another miracle.”

“It was simple,” Brandon said. “It did require a significant amount of detail and execution, and a very complex operating system.”

“Are you going to let me meet it?” Cooper asked. Even in the relative darkness of the vehicle, Trew could see Cooper’s eyes gleamed with eagerness at the thought.

“Of course not,” Brandon snapped. “What’s wrong with you?” He looked seriously at Trew, “Under no circumstances is Cooper to meet Sylvia. Ever. Do you understand?”

“Okay,” Trew agreed. “Any specific reason why?”

Cooper laughed and slapped Trew on the back. “Of course there are specific reasons why, Trew. Don’t worry, I won’t ever try to sneak a visit with her, I was pulling Brandon’s strings a bit.” Cooper slapped Brandon’s knee. “Don’t worry, boy, I won’t get close to your little pet mainframe.”

It was amusing to see Cooper treat Brandon like a young kid, and surprising that Brandon allowed it.

“Can Andrew fly as skillfully as Melissa and Danni?” Trew asked.

“I don’t think so,” Brandon said. “We knew he could levitate, and it’s only been a short time since he exited the Game, so I don’t expect he’s been able to practice much or long. From what we can tell, his process matches that of the girl’s exactly; it makes sense that in a few weeks or months he’ll likely be zipping around the skies the same as them.”

“What does it mean?” Trew asked.

“You tell me what it means, Trew.” Brandon said.

Trew found their gaze unsettling. He shrugged his shoulders. “I haven’t really thought about it.”

“I think you should,” Brandon said. “Your followers are going to be looking to you for a response to this historic event. This changes the way the world works in most people’s eyes. They’ll be looking for some reassurance.”

“Then you should make an address, Brandon.” Trew said.

Cooper chuckled softly. Brandon shook his head.

“Some things appear to be changing on Tygon. Despite numerous accomplishments and successes, I don’t inspire millions the way you are able to. I brought the world together using entertainment, wealth and power. I use the Game and money to control everyone, and so far I think I’ve done a good job.” Cooper nodded in agreement beside him. “Since you exited the Game, and even before that, it’s become obvious that the people of this world want more. They want a leader they can follow out of love; a leader who

cares about them and will guide them to new levels of thinking and existing. That leader isn’t me — it’s you.”

“I don’t think so,” Trew said. “The Gamers are just a bunch of kids who liked an idea in their last play and want to keep it going here for a bit.”

Brandon looked at him and smiled. “You’ve been isolated, focused on Danielle since you completed your play. In a few weeks, she will be done with her play and life here will go on. Reports are coming in from all over the world, for my eyes only. Everyone I trust and respect all recommend one course of action immediately.”

“What do they recommend?” Trew asked.

Brandon smiled. “They recommend that I assassinate you before you realize what and who you are to this world. They agree that you are the single largest threat to my leadership that has ever emerged.”

Trew was stunned by Brandon’s statement. It wasn’t conceivable to him that he would threaten Brandon, the man who was responsible for all of his success and standing. Confusion showed on his face,

the other two men laughed. “Don’t worry, Trew,” Brandon said. “I have no intention of eliminating you. This is exactly the result I hoped you would achieve.”

“I would never hurt you, Brandon,” Trew said. “Your advisors are wrong.”

“I know, my boy,” Brandon said. “I trust you implicitly. Never doubt that fact.”

“I think I’m going to cry,” Cooper said. He pulled an imaginary tissue from his pocket and pretended to wipe tears from his eyes.

Trew laughed. “So I will build my influence and help you in any way I can. Is that the idea, Brandon?”

“It is,” Brandon nodded. “But the first order of business is to get Danielle safely out of the Game.”

“Um…” Cooper said. “I am occasionally out of the loop, but last *I* heard, she’s gonna die. For good. And your Game is gonna cease to exist, killing billions of kids who get trapped inside. You’re on a collision course with big problems, Brandon, and time’s running out.”

Trew and Brandon both glared at Cooper, who shrugged his shoulders. “Yeah, it sounds bad, but that’s what you’re facing. Sorry to rain on your parade, boys. But keep your eyes on the train that’s about to run you over.”

“We’re working on it, Cooper,” Brandon said.

“I know, I know,” Cooper said. “Just wanted to make sure I hadn’t missed any new developments. I want you to succeed.”

The car slowed to a stop and the men looked out. Coloured lights flashed through the windows, there were police cars parked in front of Andrew’s house. An ambulance was at the front door, and the paramedics were wheeling out a stretcher with someone on it. The person on it was fully draped in a white cover; it was clear they were dead.

The three men swore at the same time. “Maybe it’s a parent, or something,” Cooper said.

“Here’s hoping,” Brandon said as he opened the car door and got out.

Chapter 59

Tragic news today.

Young player Andrew Young, recently in the news for showing the ability to levitate on Tygon, was discovered dead in his room late last night. Official autopsy results report that he died as a result of ingesting restricted chemicals. It's uncertain which chemicals they were or exactly how much he ingested. This is sad news for the Gamer community; Andrew quickly became a celebrity within the movement when he developed the ability to levitate.

I had the opportunity to meet Andrew and report on his talent. It was a shock to everyone to hear about his untimely demise. We extend our sympathy to his parents.

In Gaming news, the Danielle channel remains without signal. Viewers are hopeful that a connection will soon be reestablished.

We will bring you details on any and all Game-related news as it becomes available.

Lisa Johansen reporting

" The news is wrong," Michelle said. "Andrew was murdered."

"Any ideas on who did this?" Trew asked.

"There are rumblings," Brandon said, "in many circles."

"And…?" Trew asked.

"Factions and leaders, whom I believed safely under control, are thinking that this might be the time to once again make a challenge to my authority," Brandon said.

"That doesn't sound good," Lilith said.

"It's more annoyance than threat," Brandon said, "a distraction that I don't particularly have the time or patience for at the moment, which may lead me to react forcefully."

"Violence?" Trew asked.

Brandon laughed. "I'm too civilized to resort to violence, initially at least. I control the money, the media, the police, and the Game." Brandon straightened his tie and picked up his tablet. "No, I will find out who is

making the most noise and make an example out of them. Somewhere on Tygon, a very rich and powerful business person will be entering the labour camps by the end of today, without enough money or support to even get a ride to the gates."

"That sounds a bit over the top, Brandon," Lilith said.

Brandon didn't respond. "Michelle, I want someone scouring the feeds to see if there is anyone else who might be a flier inside the Game. We know how things work; once something is accomplished once, more start to appear. There must be a couple of people levitating around the world. Have them found, and bring me the names of the avatars and the kids who are playing them."

"Earth doesn't know fliers exist yet," Trew said. "Isn't that required?"

"Usually, yes. But let's err on the side of caution."

"What about Tygon?" Nadine asked.

"Yes," Brandon said. "Definitely Tygon. We might actually see more fliers here than in the Game."

"Brandon," Lilith said. "I think you might be going too far with your strategy to ruin a business leader."

Brandon turned his head to look at her. "It will be Jeremy Conrad," he said.

Lilith looked at him.

"Don't look so stern, Lilith. The man tried to have you killed years ago for speaking out about the camps. We all know it was him; he's been living on borrowed time as it is. This will send a message, and pay an old debt."

"This isn't some game, Brandon," Lilith said.

Trew and Brandon laughed at the same moment, then gave each other a sly glance. "That's exactly what it is, Lilith. You think the only game takes place on these screens? With children? If there's any lesson to be learned, to be fully understood, it's that life is a Game."

"That's not how most people see it, Brandon," Lilith said.

"That's not my fault," Brandon said. "I've done everything I can to show them the truth. If people want to sleep and pretend reality is something different than what it is, then they will." He stood up and walked towards Danielle's blank screen. "It's all a dream, all a Game. It must be, since the Game is modelled after Tygon."

"Do you know that for certain?" Lilith asked.

Brandon shrugged. “Who knows anything for certain? In the Game, Trew read a book written by a lonely old man and believed it. He shared his belief with others and in a short time they also began to believe. He shared his belief through words. I showed our world the same message, I simply used a different medium: the Game.”

Brandon tapped the monitor. His knuckles produced a sharp echo in the silence of the room. A picture appeared suddenly on the monitor; a view from Danielle’s first person perspective, squinting her eyes as bright light exploded into view, then she began to climb out of what appeared to be a pile of rubble.

As Danielle pushed another handful of stones away from the hole she was climbing out of, everyone in the command centre began to move.

Brandon looked at one of the young men sitting at the table. Their eyes met and Brandon spoke loud enough to be heard over the sudden noise. “Jeremy Conrad,” he said.

The young man nodded, stood up, and walked out of the office.

***

Melissa was tired. She’d been flying seven to ten hours a day for the past month, looking for any signs of Danielle, but finding none. Raphael had taught her to sense energy signatures; she wasn’t as good as Raphael was, but apparently she had the talent.

As the days passed, her optimistic hope had slowly turned to despair. After weeks of searching, flying over new areas, then reviewing areas she’d examined before, Melissa now feared that there was no way they would ever find Danni.

It was mid-morning and Melissa was ready to grab a bite to eat and a nice warm drink. Aerial searching had become dull, cold work. She began to head towards the nearest village, but a glint of light in the distance caught her attention.

Melissa quickly flew upwards, then rotated slowly in a complete circle, scanning as far as her eyes could see. A hundred kilometers distant, she spotted a flash of intense colour. Melissa decided to go check it out.

Lowering her goggles, she started towards the source, increasing her speed as she went. Raphael had taught her how to draw power from her surroundings; “zero point energy” he called it. She could draw free energy seemingly from nowhere, instead of depleting her own sources. This

allowed her to go faster and farther. Thanks to his training, she could fly all day and not get overly tired.

As she got closer, Melissa saw a large hole in the ground. Lying beside the hole were two people who appeared to be unconscious. Melissa landed about twenty-five feet away and ran the remaining distance on foot. She knelt over the body she recognized, putting her head close enough to feel breath on her cheek. She checked for a pulse and found it. Everything appeared normal.

Melissa jumped into the air and floated upwards about twenty feet, activating her headset and placing a call to Raphael.

"Any luck?" Raphael asked on the other end of the line.

"Yes," Melissa said. "I've got her! She's unconscious, but her pulse and breathing are normal."

"You've got her?" Raphael sounded surprised and relieved. He also sounded worried.

"Yes, Raph. Can you get a fix on my signal?"

"Hold on a sec. No, not quite. Go a bit higher."

"Okay," Melissa slowly began to rise up into the air. She was about fifty feet up when Raph stopped her. "Got you. Okay, I'll be there in just a few minutes. Call Stephanie and tell her to lock onto you as well."

Raphael disconnected the call and Melissa dialed Stephanie.

Chapter 60

I have always been fascinated by knowledge, specifically how some of it is accepted, some of it is rejected, and other portions are allowed to be considered further.

Many believe this is not terribly interesting. They say, 'If something works, then it is accepted; if it doesn't, then it is not accepted.' This is definitely not the case. A plant exists today that can be processed and refined to provide us with a myriad of benefits. The leaves and seeds bestow incredible health, allowing our bodies to fight disease and maintain optimum function. The oils pressed from the plant can be made into an efficient and clean burning fuel to replace our current system of poisonous and polluting fuels. The fibers from the plant can be formed into compounds, which are then used to make a material that is stronger than most of our current metals. All of these benefits and more can be obtained by using this plant. The other amazing fact is that processing it is very inexpensive.

A person can learn to tap into unseen energy and focus it on human cells, resulting in healing a person of most sickness and disease, at no cost to anyone.

These are just two examples of knowledge that our race gained, tested, confirmed, and then denied so that the majority would never know or believe such things.

I have spent my life studying knowledge, and throughout our long and rich history there are thousands of examples like this. Our race

has ignored discoveries that could help us to evolve and grow. Every day we continue to ignore these types of miracles.

Imagine if the very first cave man to discover fire had looked around and simply stamped it out before anyone else could see what he had.

Perhaps he did; perhaps it happened many times, until the truth could no longer be hidden.

Or perhaps there were fires all around early people and it never occurred to them how to use it to their advantage. Then one woman or man

came along and thought differently than the others. They held raw food over the fire and the others laughed and mocked her.

This is the history I follow. It is both interesting and challenging to piece together.

Challenging because those who do not want advancement most often destroy record of the advancement, many times, until the advancement can no longer be denied.

Cara Halm, Historian of Advancement

Shane

This new computer fascinates me.

Looking at the monitor, I watch it floating lazily inside its host. At the current magnification, it looks like a regular cell as it rides the river of lifegiving blood towards its new destination. It reminds me of a similar event that occurred more than two thousand years ago with a man who designed a similar machine.

The current microcomputer is composed of silica and metals; the ancient one was made from modified tree cells and strings of mysterious single stranded proteins that the inventor had just discovered. He called them rNA. Both the old and the new are made from the same thing… atoms.

His creation was too advanced for its time, a dangerous, microscopic sentient life form. It had to be destroyed, along with him and his entire country. That's how Atlantis ceased to exist. I annihilated all of it, then let it sink below the surface of the ocean.

I watch this little supercomputer float around and my instincts tell me that I should do the same thing now, destroy this whole damned continent and bury it.

But what if it can help get me out of this damned Game? I'm not as nice as I was back then; it's time to be a bit more selfish and take care of myself.

I look away from the monitor towards the boy sitting at his computer. "What have you got for me, Seven?" I ask.

"I'm able to hack into its basic command structure," he says from inside his cell, "but I've had no success tapping into higher command

functions."

"You've been at it for quite some time," I say. "This is disappointing to me, Seven."

He looks frightened, which is appropriate, because we both know I'm likely going to hurt him. "I'm sorry, boss," he says. "This is the most sophisticated piece of electronics I have ever seen. If I make one wrong step, the thing disintegrates. We've already lost two of the copies that it sent to the other inmates."

"I know this, Seven," I say.

"I'm sorry, boss," he whimpers again. "I'm afraid that they're all linked together. It makes sense that they are, since they're so small and apparently governed by quantum mechanics."

I sigh and nod. It looks like I'm expecting too much from my young friend. "You are very useful, Seven. It is for that reason alone that I will accept this failure. I agree, if they are all subject to quantum entanglement, then tampering with one might cause us to lose the one in the field that does work properly."

He sounds relieved. "Shall I go ahead and bring up that feed on the monitor?"

"Yes." I say.

He types in some commands, and images appear on the screen. It's exactly like watching the feeds from a command centre on Tygon. Her vitals are displayed on the bottom right side of the screen; the sound and my view is from a first person perspective — and it's all being recorded.

"It looks like they've been rescued," I say. Raphael is talking to Danielle, hugging her and making sure she's unharmed. I can see Stephanie and the young flying girl in the background.

"Her vitals look good," Seven says.

Danielle walks over to the car and gets in next to another figure.

"Who is that?" I ask.

The face of the person inside the car is familiar. Very familiar.

"This could be a problem," I say.

Seven finally recognizes the other occupant in the car. "Isn't that Three?" he asks.

"Yes, it would appear that it is."

Chapter 61

In case you're one of the few who stepped away from your viewers for a brief rest, get back to it now! Danielle has returned to the Game, and she has company.

Early updates tell us that Carl, the infernal who killed Trew and… well, I don't have to give any of you his resume, do I? Carl is with her!

If you subscribe to Melissa's channel, then you were fortunate enough to witness Danielle climbing out of a hole in the desert, Carl by her side.

We don't have much to report, but this is news — big news!

Okay, back to the view screen for me, too. This is so exciting!

Lisa Rohansen reporting

Danielle

" That's it?" Raphael asks.

They brought us back to the estate, cleaned us up, and had a doctor give me a complete checkup to make sure I was okay. Carl came with us. Raphael looked at his eyes, and just nodded. I tried to talk a couple of times, but Raphael said to save it, that we would do a full debrief once the doctor said I was in good health. I'm not sure if Carl got medical attention. After they said I was fine, we all assembled in the main room. Then I began to tell my story. Every

once in a while, Stephanie or Raphael would interrupt with additional questions.

"What do you mean, that's it?" I ask.

"He's wondering if you left anything out," Carl says. He sits in the corner, I think it might take a few tries before he feels comfortable around the Eternals. He's used to walking in and making threats, inviting violence or delivering terrible news. To be actually sitting here 'on our side' now seems to be a bit strange to him. I know it's a lot strange for the rest of us. The Eternals don't seem too fazed by it, though. They've always said that the Timeless are all Brothers and Sisters; each of them has been on both sides of the field before. I'm not so sure how it works; I'll have to trust them. This new one, Miranda, makes me more nervous than Carl. She

actually sits among us with red eyes, yet they don't seem worried about her either.

"Not much happened, if that's the entire story." Raphael admits. "You were gone for over a month, Danni. Captured by one of the most dangerous creatures on this planet — no offense, Carl."

"None taken," Carl says. "He always made me look like a Boy Scout, but that just gave me a goal to shoot for." His grin is old Carl to the core. I smile.

"And he did nothing to you?" Raphael shakes his head.

"He did stuff to Carl," I say.

Stephanie stands up and pours a drink of water and a glass of Scotch. She carries both over to Carl, who takes the scotch and waves away the water. He takes a drink and sighs.

"What's your take on it, Carl?" Raphael asks.

"I'm not sure why he took her," Carl says. "He said he wanted information from her. Before she got there he told me I was to kill her when he was done, but that was a lie. He knew all along I had changed."

"Yes, somehow the leaders know when it happens," Raphael confirmed. "I tried to hide it too, but Daniel kicked me from the lair very quickly. Not even a hug and a handshake."

Carl laughed. "He's not the touchy feely type, that's for sure. I've been running through the whole experience in my head, and the only explanation that fits is that he wanted me to break Danielle out."

Carl talks about the torture, how it wasn't horrible for him, but for a person like me it would have been devastating. Then Shane promised I would get exactly the treatment he'd delivered to Carl and told him when it would happen. Carl also talks about his digging, and us being left alone until he just happened to finish his work.

"So he took the two of you and locked you up together, just so you could escape?" Stephanie asks.

"May I inspect the two of you?" the Infernal asks. Her name's Miranda. A pretty lady, although she looks sad for some reason. They are all treating her like she's an Eternal, which doesn't make sense after what Carl told me about a Timeless having to follow their eyes first and foremost. I trust the people in this room, though. If they feel she's no threat, then I will bow to their wisdom.

“Sure ya can, darlin’,” Carl says. He stands up and closes his eyes. Miranda approaches him and does the same, entering a state of light meditation. Then she runs her hands up and down, I can feel the Reiki energy radiating from her hands.

After a few moments, she opens her eyes and shakes her head negatively, then moves to my side. I close my eyes and wait for her to scan me as well. A light tap on my shoulder tells me when she is done. I look at her questioningly, but she shakes her head again. “Nothing that I can detect. I thought he would plant a monitoring device on you, but I can’t sense anything.”

“Maybe he figured out a way to hide something?” Stephanie said.

“I would definitely detect it,” Miranda said. “Even without Sparx.”

“What’s Sparx?” I ask.

“I’ll tell you later,” she says with a sad smile.

“Something stinks; I think we can all agree on that,” Carl said. Everyone in the room nods, including me.

“So what’s next?” I ask.

“I have no idea,” Raphael says. “Usually there’s an enemy, a crisis, something. But I don’t see anything… or is it just me?”

“I agree,” I say. “The movement is underground, and our members are safe from assassination.”

Carl grunts and laughs at the statement. I smile sweetly, knowing how much we pissed him off in the final few months of his hunt, denying him success.

“I’m safe and sound. Carl is… neutralized, for the moment, as far as we are concerned. He’s not a threat to us.” I pause and frown. “Is that true? Are we all certain that Carl is not a threat? ‘Cause maybe he’s a plant, sent here to destroy us from the inside?”

Everyone in the room laughs. “I can see how you might think that, Danni,” Stephanie says. Timeless are above the backstabbing and lying that so often accompanies human dramas, at least to a point. If Carl showed up with red eyes and claimed to be on our side, well, then we would be very, *very* cautious. In all likelihood we would suspect treachery.”

“Really?” I say, looking towards Miranda. “If an Infernal showed up, claiming to be on our side, we would suspect they were lying?”

Stephanie shakes her head. “No, not Miranda. She’s different.”

“How so?” I ask.

“I can’t tell you, Danni.” Steph says. “What I can tell you is that everyone in this room will vouch for Miranda. You know what our primary mission is, to protect you at all costs. I am willing to bet my entire existence, and your life, on my judgment.”

“Does everyone else agree with Stephanie?” I ask. I look at each Timeless in the room and one by one they nod; even Carl appears to agree. I wonder what they all know about her that makes her safe? I shrug, knowing there’s no point in asking.

“Okay, then,” I say. “So that leads us back to my original question. What do we do now?”

The room is silent.

“No bright ideas?” I ask.

“It’s your play, Danni,” Raph says. “It always has been. We are here for you.”

“Well, if it’s my play, I haven’t done a very good job of it since Trew left,” I admit. “I doubt anyone will be following my life at all on Tygon.”

“Oh, yes, you’re very boring,” Carl says sarcastically. “A flying girl who hunts professional killers and makes them look like untrained boys, as she exacts vengeance to protect her flock of hidden followers. Followers of a new religion that rivals centuries old establishments. Very boring, indeed.”

I laugh out loud. “When you put it that way, it doesn’t seem quite so bland.”

“Think of something, girl,” Carl finishes his drink. “Before I get so bored my eyes turn back to red from sitting on my ass and I have to try and kill you some more.”

Then it comes to me in a flash, like a jolt of lightning.

“Uh-oh,” Raphael says. “I see that look in your eyes, Danni. The same one you had when you were little, before you jumped off that dumpster and into traffic.”

I grin. “Then get ready to catch me, Raph, ‘cause I’m about to really start playing this game of life.”

Chapter 62

Carl

Instinct wakes me up. I open my eyes and try to roll to the side. It's the best way to avoid a knife thrust or a gun shot.

I can't move. Something holds my entire body in an iron grip. Maybe this is it, then. I take a deep breath, ready to find out what comes next.

I hear a humming noise near my head, and smile.

"Time to settle up?" I ask.

"I made a promise." Her voice comes from my right side. I turn my head and meet her eyes.

"You surprise me again, girl. It takes very strong Talent to hold me immobile."

"That isn't her," Raphael's voice says from the darkness.

"All right, then," I say. "Keep your promise, Danielle. I can hear the Sever Spike humming, it sounds hungry. Send it home; into the right eye is the most painful, they say."

She walks towards me and holds the Spike near my face. Raising it high over her head to strike, she pauses. It begins to descend toward my eye. I see it speeding toward me the entire way; blinking isn't my style.

Then it stops. If I close my eye, the lid will touch the Spike's tip.

She slowly lifts the weapon and sheaths it behind her back. Then she turns and walks toward the exit.

"Danielle," I say. She stops with her hand on the door.

"I'm sorry about Trew. I've been in this Game for over three thousand years, and I have little remorse, but I do regret using the Spike on him."

She doesn't look back. Her shoulders sag slightly; her voice remains steady and strong. "I can't begin to guess at the terrible things you've done on Earth. Despite all of that, I don't believe that, deep down, you are a bad man."

"If there was ever anything good in me, I think it disappeared a long time ago," I say.

"Someday I would like to hear the story of the young beta tester who entered the Game to become the Timeless named Carl," she says softly, and

walks out of the room .

Chapter 63

My last play was an incredible opportunity to learn how life works. It was a short play, lasting only 40 years, but I returned with the understanding that we've been missing out on Tygon. For thirty years, viewers have been told the Game mirrors our reality exactly. We've used this knowledge to some degree, taking discoveries and improvements from player's experiences and applying them to life on Tygon. Thanks to the Game, we are able to safely and effectively fly aircraft in this world. Thanks to the Game, we've discovered new, clean burning sources of fuel. There are new medicines and techniques for saving lives. The list of advancements brought out of the Game is considerable.

Considerable though that list may be, I can assure you we still do not seem to get it. There's so much more we can do, and the sad truth is that most of the time it doesn't even occur to us to try.

Brandon Strayne gave each and every citizen on this planet a gift the day he turned the Game on. With the help of children who don't know any better, he shows us that we can be more than we could have ever dreamed possible. He showed us that with effort, discipline, and faith, an average person can become more. If any of you watch Danielle play the Game, or Melissa soar through the sky, you have been shown what you can do as well.

For far too long, we have sat in our comfortable homes, turned on a viewer, and watched others play the Game of Life. I hear people say how sorry they are because I am now too old to play the Game. I'm

grateful that I'm too old to play! It prepared me for the real *Game, the one we live in at this very moment. You won't find me wasting my entire life following someone else's exploits and adventures. No, I much prefer to participate in my own life here on Tygon.*

Life is not something we are stuck in because we can't go anywhere more fun. Life is a daring adventure, a bold Game.

I'm playing it. I invite you all to join me.

Trew addressing the nation via satellite link

“ Hello, Trew,”Sylvia said. “Back so soon? You were here only two days ago.”

“Time seems to pass more quickly with each tick of the clock,” Trew said.

“I was happy to see Danielle reappear,” she said.

“Thank you. So were we.”

“How’s she holding up?”

“Very well,” Trew said. “They didn’t harm her. There were threats, and a long time spent in a cramped little prison, but overall she is in good health and spirits.”

“That was yesterday on Tygon time, right?” Sylvia said. “That means that on Earth she is approaching her 60th birthday. She looks very young for her age, don’t you think?”

“She looks no older than the day I left her side.” Trew said. “It’s as if time has frozen for her. We made an agreement to live to the age of 140, and she spent the credits to do it. Looks like she won’t have a problem doing just that, from a health perspective.”

“It’s not just the credits, Trew,” Sylvia said. “I don’t allow that many years for average people, but I knew Danielle would do the task justice. She is becoming sound in mind, body, and soul. There is a special connection when it all works together properly. The human body, properly maintained, can live much longer than 140 years. She eats well, exercises, and meditates. She has learned how

to worry less, and listen effectively to her body, the vehicle she is driving in. It’s an excellent lesson for viewers.”

“It’s a generous gift, too, allowing her to have additional years in the Game, especially since she doesn’t get to come back here when she’s done. Did you know that when you allowed her the extra time, I wonder?”

“What do you mean, she doesn’t get to come back here?” Sylvia asked. “Have you given up on your goal, Trew?”

“No,” Trew said.

“I am sorry to tell you, but you have.” Sylvia said. “The rules of the universe are simple but clear. In order for an outcome to occur, the person must believe without any doubts that it will happen. It is always possible to ascertain this level of belief by observing how the person thinks and talks.

They must be in a thankful mindset and believe that the change has already occurred. It's that simple."

"I know you're right," Trew said.

"Then change your thinking. Immediately."

"I will," Trew said.

"That is an interesting choice of words. Did you know that before the Game went live, the world was seeded with many hints and tips, to help players along the way?"

"No, I didn't know that."

"Yes," Sylvia said. "Thoughts, musings, inspirations… that type of thing, embedded in the very matter of the world. A person diving for a pearl might swim through such a node, and come up from his swim with a sudden inspiration. A lady riding her horse in the countryside would return with a deep musing and write it down to share with others. Some players learned about these nodes and began to spend credits to find them. 'Worldly wisdom' is what many call it."

"That's very interesting," Trew said.

"There's a powerful little node that people discover from time to time; it conveys the idea, 'Where there's a will, there's a way.' A clever bit of inspiration, and applicable to you right now."

Trew understood the lesson. "Then I will Danielle to return to Tygon when she is done inside the Game." He said.

"And you just did it," Sylvia said with delight.

"Did what?"

"Announced how you will save Alexandra."

"With my will," Trew said.

Sylvia sighed. "Oh, my dear boy. I know it does you no good to give you the answers, but this one time I wish I could."

"I'm afraid I don't understand."

"That's all right," Sylvia said. "Come back and see me soon, Trew."

Trew stood up, more confused than ever, and walked to the door. "Okay, Sylvia. Thank you for the talk."

"You're welcome."

Chapter 64

“ Still got it for an old gal,” Trew said.

“Very funny!” Danielle slapped him playfully, then nuzzled into his shoulder and pulled the covers up further.

Trew smiled and leaned in to smell her hair. “Who would have ever thought that a sixty-year old could be so damn hot?”

“I feel like I’m twenty-five, although they say I look more like 38. I guess I can accept that compliment at my age.”

“You’re making an impact in the world of health and nutrition. Actually, both worlds are paying attention to what you’re accomplishing.”

“Our time’s almost up, love.” Danielle got up and began to dress.

“How can I help you, Danni?” Trew asked.

“I don’t know, Trew. It feels like we are all in some giant holding pattern. Something big is about to happen, I can feel it.” She smiled. “But since I have no clue what it is, there’s really nothing you can do to help me at the moment. Be ready to jump into action when I need you, though. How ‘bout you, babe? Is there anything I can do to help you?”

Trew smiled and shook his head. Inside, he knew he should say something; time was running out. But he didn’t want to upset her; she still had a lot of years left inside the Game. Plenty of time to save her on Tygon.

“Since I made it known to the Gamer movement that I intend to live to the age of 140, there’s been a swell of people announcing their intention to live just as long,” Danielle said.

“I know,” Trew said. “That’s a problem.”

“Why?”

“They didn’t spend the credits. It won’t happen.”

“Some of them appear to be on track,” Danielle said.

Trew smiled and said nothing. He didn’t want to tell her that these people would be killed ‘accidentally’ before their bodies on Tygon wasted away and died. There were some facts he didn’t want to address, because if he did, then she would ask about her own body on Tygon. Trew had visited it, and although everything appeared normal now, it would begin to deteriorate as the weeks progressed. Living to the age of 140 within the

Game would stress her body on Tygon past the point of being able to survive in stasis.

The light on the door turned green and chimed; their time together was up.

“See ya soon, sexy!” Danielle kissed Trew and ran towards the door.

Trew threw the covers aside and walked to the exit. He stepped through, expecting to take the helmet off in his small chamber, but instead he found himself in a large room bathed in faint purple light.

There were two reading chairs sitting in the corner beside a fireplace. Trew walked to one chair and sat down. He had been here many times; the soothing comfort of the chair was always wonderful. Beside him stood a small, ornate table that held two steaming mugs of liquid. Trew had never tasted anything like the beverage — another treat reserved for this room, it seemed.

“Hello again, Trew.” The deep, soothing voice came from behind him. Trew heard footsteps and wondered what his host would look like today. He always had a different appearance. Varied height, complexion, body structure — always a new look.

Followers often asked Trew what God looked like. He would smile and say that it was pointless to attempt a description. God was, after all, a feeling. Regardless of his — or sometimes her — appearance, the specific and distinct feeling was always consistent.

God felt like belonging, like being in the safest place in creation. Peace and absence of judgment. Words never did the experience justice, although Trew continued to try.

Today it was a man who sat beside him. Tall, with blonde hair and deep blue eyes. A ready smile on his genuinely happy looking face. Laughter seemed to be waiting just below the surface of his mouth, ready to bubble up at the slightest opportunity. He reached for his drink and Trew grabbed his. They clinked mugs together softly and drank. Both men closed their eyes and savoured the unique, indescribable flavour. In unison they sighed, then opened their eyes and smiled at each other as if sharing a secret joke.

“How are you doing?”

“I’m doing well,” Trew said. “My best moments are right after a visit with Danni.”

“I know,” he nodded. “That is why we are visiting today at that moment. Today is the most serious conversation we have had to date, my boy.”

“Okay,” Trew said. He took another sip of his drink and waited.

“You are ready,” the man said, “for what is soon to come.”

He paused. Trew normally asked questions when given such an opportunity. Today, Trew sensed that the moment required him to be absent of questions. He was fully focused on the words he was hearing, careful to remember this entire event as best he could.

Tygon’s God nodded in satisfaction. He took another sip of beverage and looked into the fire. After a few moments he continued, “Tygon is about to undergo great change. The activities and society that brought Tygon to its current state will not be able

to advance it to the next level. You will be the one to lead this new change.”

He looked at Trew with fondness, mixed with fatherly concern. Trew smiled reassuringly.

“Life has been easy for you so far, compared to what will now happen. I know that many would disagree, but it is only by hammering a blade and immersing it in the fire repeatedly that you forge the strongest, truest blades. You have been shaped, and now you are ready to be forged.”

He stood up and walked to the fire, holding his hands out to it. “Brandon and the others are there to help you. The world has been setting key people and events in movement; soon they will all be in place. Like a horse exploding from the gate on race day, it will begin. Know that I am with you, even when it appears that I am not.”

“Do our visits end?” Trew asked.

“No,” the man smiled, “not at all. There may be times when you do not wish to speak with me, but the visits will continue.”

“Then I’m ready,” Trew said.

“Yes.” He smiled and embraced Trew lovingly. Holding him at arm’s length, he nodded with authority and confidence. “You are ready.”

Chapter 65

It has been an interesting couple of days since Danielle came back online. Days here, years in the Game, with much excitement and activity that have produced very few concrete or dramatic results.

Carl appeared out of nowhere, flashing his newly changed eyes and helping Danielle to escape from her dangerous captor. We haven't been able to learn many details regarding who took her, or for what purpose she was detained, but Carl has been cautiously accepted into the group of other Eternals who surround the leader of the Gamer movement. Danielle seems reluctant to trust Carl with the more intimate details of the group, preferring to exclude him from the most important meetings and missions.

Danielle herself has increased her persona of 'Fallen,' rallying cells of Gamers all over the globe, conducting meetings and setting up methods for communicating and assembling should the need arise in times of crisis.

Earth itself has been very calm. At any given moment in history, a large portion of Earth's population is preoccupied with deep concern that some conspiracy or doomsday event approaches. Most often the appointed time arrives, and then passes without incident. Presently, there is no mass anxiety over the world ending. Some find this odd; others find it a pleasant break from the ongoing drama that has become predictable and boring to both Earth inhabitants and viewers alike.

Melissa and Danielle continue to fly the skies in secret, still not having shared their incredible abilities with the public. Because of this secrecy, no one else on Earth has exhibited similar talent.

Tygon, however, is watching Danielle and Melissa fly every day. There have been reports of a dozen or more young players manifesting a small talent for levitating on Tygon, but these claims remain unsubstantiated.

Also on Tygon, Trew and Brandon have been spotted on more than one occasion leaving the VirtDyne building and traveling to meet with powerful and influential world leaders. We have been unable to learn any details of these meetings, but we can confirm that they have taken place.

Game viewership continues to increase dramatically as 30th anniversary events occur all over Earth at irregular and surprising intervals.

It's a great time to be watching or playing the Game.
Lisa Rohansen reporting

Danielle

" I think it's time we allowed him to come with us to these meetings," Stephanie says.

I sigh and blow a stray lock of my hair upwards, trying to ignore her as I watch it fall back against my forehead.

"I agree," Raphael says.

"Well, that's a real shocker," I say. "Wait, let me think for a minute and try to remember the last time you two didn't agree on something."

"You want someone in here that likely won't agree with us?" Stephanie asks.

"On this point? Yes, please."

Raphael smiles and walks to the door, opening it and waving someone in. He stands there for so long I think no one is in the hall. Then I laugh out loud as Carl strolls in, a sour look on his face.

"Seriously?" I ask. Raphael nods, so I look at Carl and ask him. "I think we should continue to keep you out of the top secret meetings. Stephanie and Raphael disagree. What do you think?"

"I think you're right," he says, and begins to walk out the door.

"Huh?" I say. "Wait a minute, Goldie, get back in here and tell me why."

He glares at my use of the nickname for the flecks that mark him as an Eternal. I smile sweetly; that's exactly why I use it. I wave him back in and pat the chair cushion. He comes back in and sits down. I've found out over the past couple of years that being an Eternal doesn't automatically change you into a cheerful and pleasant person. Carl continues to be the arrogant, confident, aggressive killer that he was when his eyes had red flecks. I know that's often just a front. He is useful, though I will not admit that when he is present.

He sits there, looking at me with a combination of amusement and impatience. I sit patiently, staring back. We played this game a lot when we were in the cages; I got pretty good at being silent longer than him. Carl doesn't seem to be in the mood to lose today, and I'm impatient to get on

with more important things, so I finally break the silence. “Why do you think I shouldn’t trust you to come with us?” I ask.

“Two reasons.” He holds up three fingers. “Number one,” he lowers one finger, “I hate to agree with those two. Number two,” he lowers another finger, “I enjoy the break when you all leave.” He keeps his hand raised and says nothing. I’m about to correct his math and tell him he’s still holding up a third finger when it dawns on me what finger is extended. I chuckle; the man makes me laugh.

I point to the others in the room. “They say I can trust you implicitly. They say that there’s no way you will betray me if your eyes turn back and you become an Infernal again.”

“That is correct,” Carl nods. “If I once again become an Infernal, I am not allowed to betray what I experienced or learned as an Eternal.”

“There’s no way you can get around that?” I ask.

“Darlin’, the rules are set for us. It’s the price we pay for our special skills and perks. Trust me, if there was a way to bend the rules, I would have already bent them the other way.”

“Oh, okay,” I say.

“So for the record, all three of us agree that Carl is trustworthy,” Stephanie says.

I sit and tap my finger against the side of my chair. “Okay,” I say.

“Okay, what?” Carl asks.

“Okay, you’re in,” I answer. “Why you didn’t tell me this sooner is beyond me. We could use your expertise in these meetings.”

“This is the first time you asked me,” he says. “To be clear, I can’t disclose anything I knew as an Infernal. Nothing that is currently happening, at least.”

I wave my hand absently, “That’s fine, we don’t need to know any of that for these meetings. Raph, can you push our next visit back a couple hours, please? I want to bring Carl up to speed.”

“What kind of trouble are you up to, Danni?” he asks.

I smile at him, “All kinds.”

Chapter 66

“Hello, Father.”

“Son.”

“How are things?”

“They’ve been better.”

“But have they been worse?”

“Yes, my boy, they have.”

“Well that’s something, at least.”

“Is everything ready?”

“Yes,” Brandon said.

“Do you think he’s ready?”

“I do, Father. If I had any doubts, I would have waited longer before setting this in motion.”

There was a pause on both ends of the line.

“Cooper, huh?” Brandon asked. “You really pulled out all the stops.”

“He’s the best, that’s for certain.”

“I can only imagine the threats or promises you had to make to get him to accept the role,” Brandon said.

“Oh Son, you have no idea what’s going on here. After they made the announcement that Trew was the one, they lined up and competed for days to win the spot.”

“Really?” Brandon was astounded to hear this.

“Then when Cooper himself stepped forward to compete… I was as surprised as the rest when I found out.”

“I’m glad it’s Cooper,” Brandon said. “It makes paying the price worth it.”

“It’s not worth it, Son,” his father said, “but it’s too late to take it back.”

“I know,” Brandon said. “Time’s running out.”

Chapter 67

I remember following a very good player because he had done extremely well in his last two sessions. This time he turned out *quickly* to have *a very mediocre life. I remember thinking, 'This young man is wasting his life. I've subscribed to his channel for three weeks now, and it just gets more mundane and boring as time passes.' One night I came home from work, grabbed a drink to unwind, and decided to tune into his channel one last time before cancelling it the next day. He was a waiter, working at a restaurant day in and day out, spending all of his money on silly things and not getting ahead or accomplishing anything. That final night when I tuned in, he was wiping down dirty tables and setting them with clean silverware while a coworker was talking to him.*

Out of nowhere, as if he was reading my thoughts, the thirty-two year old waiter said to the girl, 'This is crazy. I work each night and make just enough money to spend the next day. Is this what my life is?'

'Maybe,' the girl said cheerfully. She didn't seem too upset about it, and the young man said as much.

'Why would I be upset?' she asked. 'I'm better off than a large percentage of the people who live in this world. If this was my entire life, I could do worse.'

'Well I think it's a waste,' the man said. 'If this is what my entire life will be like, then what's the point?'

'Maybe it's not about you,' she said. 'What if you were born simply to have a child who would grow up to become a doctor and cure cancer, saving millions of lives?'

That made the waiter think. It made me *think.*

I didn't cancel my subscription to that player's channel. I followed him for his entire play, on the off-chance that he might do something important, or have a child who did something incredible. When his life had played out, he didn't have a kid that grew up to cure cancer; he didn't do anything remarkable at all. But he might have, and that's why I continued to watch.

I think that's why most of us spend so much time watching the Game; there's a chance that someday we may witness something rare and incredible. Then all that time we invested will have been worth it.

Interview with a Game fan

Shane

" How are things coming along, Seven?" I ask.

Seven just sits there, looking at his computer monitor, deep in thought. I wait patiently for a few moments; he tends to do this when he's really immersed in a serious challenge. There have been serious

challenges lately. I have set some aggressive goals for my little cadre of pets, and they have done remarkably well. Finally I grow impatient; I'm the boss — he can damn well snap out of it. "Seven," I say.

"Yeah," he mumbles. That gets my attention; I don't tolerate that level of disrespect. I walk over to his monitor, prepared to teach him some manners. Then I see his screen and stop dead in my tracks. A moment later, I take a gulp of air; apparently I forgot to breathe for a moment.

"Beautiful," I say.

"Yeah," he says.

"That's it, then?" I ask.

He slowly pries his eyes away from the monitor and a grin spreads across his face. "That's it, boss."

I nod and tap his head gently, putting him into the Haze, then leave his cell and walk to my desk in the centre of the room. I pull out my chair and sit down, placing both hands flat on its cool surface. Ten deep, complete, relaxed breaths. There is such power in the simple act of breathing, an often overlooked gift from the beyond. After ten breaths, my focus is clear, I reflect on what has just happened. I smile.

For over six thousand years I've been trapped here, exiled to this miserable existence by Brandon Strayne. Today, my patience and persistence are rewarded. I have dreamed of this day for millennia.

I stand up and take off my lab coat, folding it neatly and draping it over the chair. Then I open the desk drawer, remove the ring of keys, and walk to cell number one. I walk inside and gently tap Number One on his forehead. He blinks as he comes out of the Haze. I nod and walk out of his cell. One follows me, and stands just inside his cell door. I gesture for him to move outside, just past the open doorway.

At a leisurely pace, I repeat the process for all thirteen cells, smiling at each of my pets as they wake from their Haze and stand at the threshold of their cell. When they have all been awakened and released, I walk back to the centre of the room and stand there, slowly turning to meet each of their gazes.

"The only way to fail is to stop trying. All of you have continued to try, long after normal people would have stopped. I am pleased with your work; today I give you the gift that was promised when you came to live here. Today I grant you permanent sanity.

I look around. Some of them are smiling at the announcement; others weep and hold their hands together in gratitude. Others stare silently, not sure what to make of my declaration.

"As a further gift to you all," I say, "I have integrated your genius with your regular consciousness. When you leave here you will retain the incredible talents you have, yet they will no longer overwhelm you and drive you insane."

I stand silently, allowing them time to understand the gift I have just given them. Then I address them again. "You will all notice a blue marking on your right wrist, the infinity symbol. It is the magic contained in that symbol that allows you to remain in your current state. It also allows me to find you, any time I desire, for as long as you shall live on this Earth. I grant you your freedom, but understand that sometime in the future I may call on you for assistance. If that day comes, you will help me. Does anyone disagree with this?" I look around to make certain no one does.

"You have thirteen days to travel whereever you would like. When you leave here, grab a duffel bag on the way out. Inside, you will find enough money to take you anywhere. Remember — thirteen days, then find a place of safety. That is all. Once again, thank you for your invaluable assistance. I couldn't have done this without all of you." I wave my hand and they begin to file out.

I see Seven and get his attention. He walks over to me hesitantly. "Don't worry, Seven, you may leave as well, if you wish." I see the struggle in his eyes. He is my favourite; being around me allows him to do things he never imagined. On the other hand, I'm an extremely difficult master.

I recognize the power hungry look in his eyes and smile. He's going to stay with me.

“Excellent,” I say. “Grab your duffel bag and meet me at the exit. I have an incredible computer lab to show you.”

Seven nods eagerly. “Is it close by, boss?”

I shake my head. “No, Seven. We must travel to get to it. Would you like to guess how long it will take us to arrive?”

“Thirteen days?” he asks.

“Correct.”

Chapter 68

Miranda

“ My shoulder aches .”

“Which one?” Stephanie asks.

“The one that holds Sparx,” I say.

“How painful is it?” I can see the concern in her eyes. We haven’t been able to get it out, or get it to respond to our repeated attempts at communication.

“Scale of one to ten, it’s only a three, but it’s a throbbing kind of pain.”

“I’ll go see if Samantha can come take a look.” She starts to walk out the door.

“Whoah, wait a minute,” I say.

“What?”

“It’s not constant. If I didn’t know better… yes, I swear it’s Morse code.”

“Really?” Steph runs to the nearby desk and grabs a pen and paper. She quickly hands it to me and I sit down on the bed. I start to scribble the signals down, nodding to her as I do. “Yeah, it’s definitely Morse code,” I say.

“What’s it spelling?” she asks.

“Shh. Let me focus.”

The pulsing doesn’t last long. I don’t focus on the entire message, just the letters. It’s important that I get them all down correctly. I can read the actual message when it stops.

As quickly as it began, the pain disappears; the pulsing stops. I slowly write the message down and read it. Then I begin to cry.

“What is it, Miranda?” Stephanie grabs a tissue and hands it to me. I dab my eyes and hand her the paper.

She reads it aloud. “Hi M, it’s me, Sparx. Captured, but found a way out. Will be with you again soon, don’t try to remove me. See you in a few days, if this works. Beware.”

Stephanie hands me back the note. “That sounds like very positive news, Miranda. In just a few days Sparx might be back with you. Why are

you crying?”

“The last word,” I say. “Beware.”

“Yes, that sounds a bit weird. Maybe she’s trying to warn you that it might be dangerous, her trying to get back to you?”

I shake my head negatively, “That’s not it. Beware is a code word.”

“What’s it code for?” She asks.

I don’t know if anyone is Firsting me, but at this moment I have to assume someone is. I close my eyes and start humming to myself to drown out the self-narration. Then I write the explanation of the code word blindly on the piece of paper and hand it to Stephanie.

I open my eyes in time to see her read the paper. Her eyes widen and she turns pale as death. “Are you joking? Please tell me you’re joking!”

I shake my head.

“Goddamn it!” She crumples the paper and throws it in the trash. “We have to tell Danielle.”

“No!” My shout stops her in her tracks. “That’s not allowed.” I say.

“Says who?” she asks.

I point to the sheet in the garbage. Stephanie sits down heavily on the bed beside me. “This isn’t good,” she says.

“No,” I agree, “it isn’t.”

Chapter 69

The entire team was present in the middle office of Danielle's command centre. Her 60th birthday would be occurring in less than an hour, and everyone was gathered to celebrate. Most fans on Tygon had taken a Game day so they could watch as much of her day as possible.

"Where's Angelica?" Michelle asked.

"Not sure," Trew said, watching Danielle sleep.

"Before we get to the magic moment, I would like to say a few words," Brandon said. He stood at the head of the table; everyone took their seats. "Thank you," he said. "I just want to say how incredible you are all doing. Although the last couple days have been easy, most of our time together hasn't been simple at all. I can't believe how well this group handles challenges. Who would have thought Danielle would get this far? A girl who was pulled from the camps, given a free play, and thrown into the Game with a paltry amount of credits. What she is accomplishing is nothing short of spectacular, and each of you is responsible for helping. In a few moments when we raise our glasses, be sure you nod to your fellow teammates. Every one of you should be proud. Now let's sit back and spend the next hour watching our girl celebrate her special day."

Everyone took their seats and watched the monitor feeds.

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Shane

"Bring up her feed, Seven," I say.

"Um, Boss?" Seven clicks away at his keyboard, bringing up a view of Danielle on the main 120 inch screen.

"What is it?" I ask.

"I was wondering, since we aren't below ground anymore — well, okay, we are below ground, but in a different part of the world — anyways, would it be possible for you to call me by my name instead of the number you gave me?"

"What *is* your name?" I ask.

Seven thinks intently for a few moments, then shakes his head. “I don’t remember, Boss.”

I look at him curiously.

“Okay, then. Seven is fine.”

“Excellent,” I say. “Is everything ready?”

“It is.”

“Then we shall begin when she finishes her run and opens the door to enter her house.”

“Are you excited, Boss?” Seven asks.

I give him my best smile. “You have no idea, Seven.”

***

Danielle

That’s strange. When I went to bed last night, I couldn’t access the net or text on my smartphone. This morning, the system appears to still be down. This just doesn’t happen any more. Damned inconvenient, today of all days. I wonder how many birthday messages I’m missing.

I laugh out loud and get dressed, putting on running gear for a short jog.

I come down the stairs and immediately notice how quiet everything is. I love getting up and jogging early for just this reason. No noise, no one asking me for my thoughts or opinions, no televisions on. Just peace and quiet.

I open the front door and start my jog, a quick 5k run, be back in 40 minutes or so. As I start to run down the street I notice it’s quiet out here as well. Too quiet.

There is no humming from the power lines, the regular street sounds that are always there, humming and clicking and other subtle noises that you just take for granted… until they aren’t there anymore.

I pass people on the streets. All of them look confused. Many are looking angrily at their phones; some are frowning, others are in heated discussion with their brows furrowed in frustration.

As I return down the street on my way home, curiosity gets the better of me and I stop to talk with a neighbour that I recognize.

“Hi, Jen; everyone looks upset this morning. What’s happening?”

Jen looks at me with concern, “No one has any wireless signal,” she says. “Since last night, no one can access the Internet or any other news or communication channels.”

“That’s odd,” I frown. “Do you have power?”

“No,” she says. “Power’s out as well.”

“Well, I’m sure it will come back on soon,” I say. “I wonder how far the power outage has spread?”

“That’s the problem.” Jen looks worried. “With our phones not working, it’s impossible to know if it’s just our block, or the whole city.”

“We’ve come to rely on our technology too much,” I say.

“Yes,” she agrees. “I hope it comes back up soon.”

“I’m sure it will,” I say. “I’ll see you later, Jen.”

“Take care, Danielle.”

I reach the front of the mansion and do some stretches, warming down slowly before I go in and wake the house up. This is odd; if our systems are down for long, no one will die, but I bet the population will be very agitated… over an inconvenience. I have to admit I’m feeling agitated myself. I’ve come to rely on my smart devices so much that I can’t imagine them not working.

I wonder if Stephanie or Raphael are up yet. Well, time to head in and see.

***

Command Centre

As soon as Danielle opens the door to enter her mansion, all the screens in the command centre go blank.

“Hey,” someone says loudly. “That’s not funny, turn them back on.”

Michelle stands up and walks to the front screen, flipping switches and pressing buttons. “I can’t get any of them to work,” she says. “Brandon, any idea what’s happening?”

Everyone in the room looks away from the monitor towards Brandon. Someone gasps in alarm, Brandon is slumped forward in his chair.

Trew crosses the room and gently shakes Brandon by the shoulder, which causes him to flop backwards like a rag doll.

“What’s wrong with him?” Lilith asks.

“I don’t know,” Trew says. “He was fine a second ago.” Trew feels for a pulse and frowns. “Back up!” he says loudly as he pushes tablets and glasses off the table in one quick motion and lifts Brandon onto the surface.

The room becomes completely silent as Trew places his hand on Brandon’s neck. He shakes his head, then loosens Brandon’s collar and listens closely for signs of breathing. Behind them, unseen by

Trew, A white light appears and Cooper steps through it into the room.

“Someone get the paramedics here immediately!” Trew shouts as he begins to compress Brandon’s chest, manually forcing air into his unresponsive lungs.

“You’ve got to stop that now, Trew,” Cooper says.

Trew looks over his shoulder, still performing CPR. “Cooper, perfect timing. Get over here and help me! He’s not breathing.”

“I know,” Cooper says softly. “You’re not helping him. Stop the CPR, now.”

“I’m not going to let him die, Cooper!” Trew looks around the room frantically, wondering if he looks as terrified as everyone else does.

Cooper places his hand on Trew’s shoulders.

“This was the price that he agreed to earlier, Trew; he admitted it when we spoke in the courtyard. His life for another’s. The deal has been struck and accepted. There’s nothing to be done.”

Trew stops pushing on Brandon’s chest, tears forming in his eyes. “It was for me, wasn’t it?”

Cooper nods and looks away.

Trew wipes away hot tears and looks down at Brandon. “That wasn’t a good deal, Brandon. Not a good deal at all!” He stands up and places one hand on Brandon’s chest, the other on his head. Then he closes his eyes and his face becomes very calm.

“You’re wasting your time,” Cooper says.

Trew ignores him.

“Okay,” Cooper snaps, speaking to the others in the room. “Everyone out. Quickly, out of the room.”

The team quickly moves out of the office, leaving only Trew and Cooper.

"You're wasting your time," Cooper says again.

The medical team arrives, entering the room carrying a stretcher between them.

"You are to do nothing to revive him," Cooper instructs the paramedics as he hands them a letter.

The lead paramedic quickly reads the letter, then makes a grim face and nods. "Instructions from Mr. Strayne himself, clearly telling us not to revive him."

"Trew," Cooper says. "They need to take him now."

Trew opens his eyes and lifts his hands, then slowly moves away from Brandon's body.

The paramedics lift Brandon and put him gently on the stretcher. "Hey, wait a minute," one of them says. "He's breathing."

"What? That's impossible." Cooper walks over and leans in close to Brandon. He looks up at Trew, fury and rage in his gaze. "Take him to a hospital room, gentlemen. When he stops breathing again, you don't touch him, do you understand?"

"Yes, sir," the paramedic says. They wheel Brandon out of the office and into the elevator.

Cooper looks at Trew silently. Trew returns his gaze calmly.

"That was cruel," Cooper says, tapping his head forcefully, "In his head he's gone, boy. You're wasting your time."

"He's breathing again," Trew says.

"He was supposed to die. None of us are happy about it, but that was how things were set up."

"It's a stupid arrangement," Trew says.

"You have no idea what you're dealing with here!" Cooper shouts. "Everything is riding on this, and you might have just ruined it all!"

"You said he agreed to die, as payment for something," Trew says. "Well, he paid it. He was dead, and now he's not."

"He will be, Trew. You don't buy a car and then get to take the money back and keep the car."

"Maybe your analogy isn't a good one," Trew says.

Cooper just looks at him.

“I’m going to see how he’s doing.” Trew walks towards the door.

“You don’t have time for that, Lobato.” Cooper says.

Trew stops. “How do you know that name? Stephanie used to call me that inside the Game.”

Cooper ignores the question and points to the blank screens. “You see those?” he asks.

“Yes,”

“That’s your most important problem at the moment.”

“Some screens that lost power?”

“No,” Cooper walks over to a screen and presses a button, the viewer makes a sound as it powers off.

“They have no signal,” Trew whispers.

“That’s right. Loss of signal.”

“Danielle,” Trew says.

“Not just Danielle,” Cooper says.

“Who else?”

“Every single player in the Game, Trew,” Cooper says.

Trew sits down heavily into a chair, not realizing it’s Brandon’s. He looks around numbly, the news hitting him like a bullet to the brain. Finally he says what Cooper has just confirmed.

“No one on Tygon can view the Game.”

Epilogue

Two hours ago, all feeds from the Game went dead. Don't bother calling customer support, they aren't answering the phones.

Gaming centres have assured us that players are still safe and alive on their tables, their brain patterns indicating that they are still inside the Game.

Game central maintains that there is nothing to be alarmed about. This is thought to be a 30th anniversary event and we can expect the Game to come back online in a short time.

We attempted to contact Brandon Strayne for comment; his office informed us that he is unavailable at this time.

Lisa Rohansen

" What's the word ?" Danielle asked.

"Chaos," Raphael answered. He sat down beside Stephanie and grabbed an apple, taking a bite and chewing loudly.

"How far does this reach?" Stephanie asked.

"The entire planet," Raphael said, taking another bite of his apple.

"Everyone is behaving so far," Danielle said. "But that can't last for much longer. Soon violence will begin." She turned to Raphael and Carl. "What do you think we should do?"

"That's easy," Carl said. He stood up from his corner in the room; over the past couple of years, it had become his spot to lounge in when they were all together. He moved to stand in front of

Danielle. "We get out of here and hole up in a safe area. Somewhere isolated from others."

"Agreed," Raphael said. "Let's see how long this lasts, determine if anyone comes forward to claim responsibility, and protect ourselves as we go."

"What about the Gamers?" Danielle asked.

"They are all prepared for this type of scenario," Stephanie said. "Everyone will lay low and live their own separate lives. The small cells will continue to band together and meet, helping each other against any trouble that arises."

“Okay,” Danielle said. “Let’s gather what we can and move to a safe spot. If this blows over in just a few days, fine. If it lasts longer, we deal with it. We all go together if that works?”

“That’s fine,” Raphael said. “It doesn’t hurt to have so many Timeless in place for the moment, especially where we’re going.”

Stephanie listed off the names. “Danni, Melissa, me, Raph, Miranda, Carl, and Sam?”

“Add me to the group,” a new voice said.

All heads turned as a beautiful young woman with long, silky blonde hair and an athletic frame walked in. Raphael and Stephanie laughed happily, each hugged her and said a few words while the others watched.

“When did you get in?” Raphael asked.

“Not long ago,” she replied.

“It’s good to have you back,” Stephanie said.

“It’s good to be back. I barely started my training before I was forced to leave you.”

“We will begin again,” Raphael said. “Can you tell us anything about what’s happening out there?”

The woman shook her head. “No clue. Looks like I walked into an interesting time in the Game.”

“Is she coming with us?” Danielle asked.

“Yes,” Raphael said.

“What’s your name?” Danielle asked her.

“Danielle,” Stephanie said. “this is our newest addition to the Timeless family. She will start training to become an Eternal.”

“Great,” Carl muttered. It was obvious that he wasn’t happy. He looked like he wanted to jump across the room and rip her throat out.

“Nice to meet you, Danielle.” The woman stuck out her hand, and the two of them shook.

“The name’s Angelica.”